NARUTO

SHONEN JUMP MANGA

Story & Art by

Masashi Kishimoto

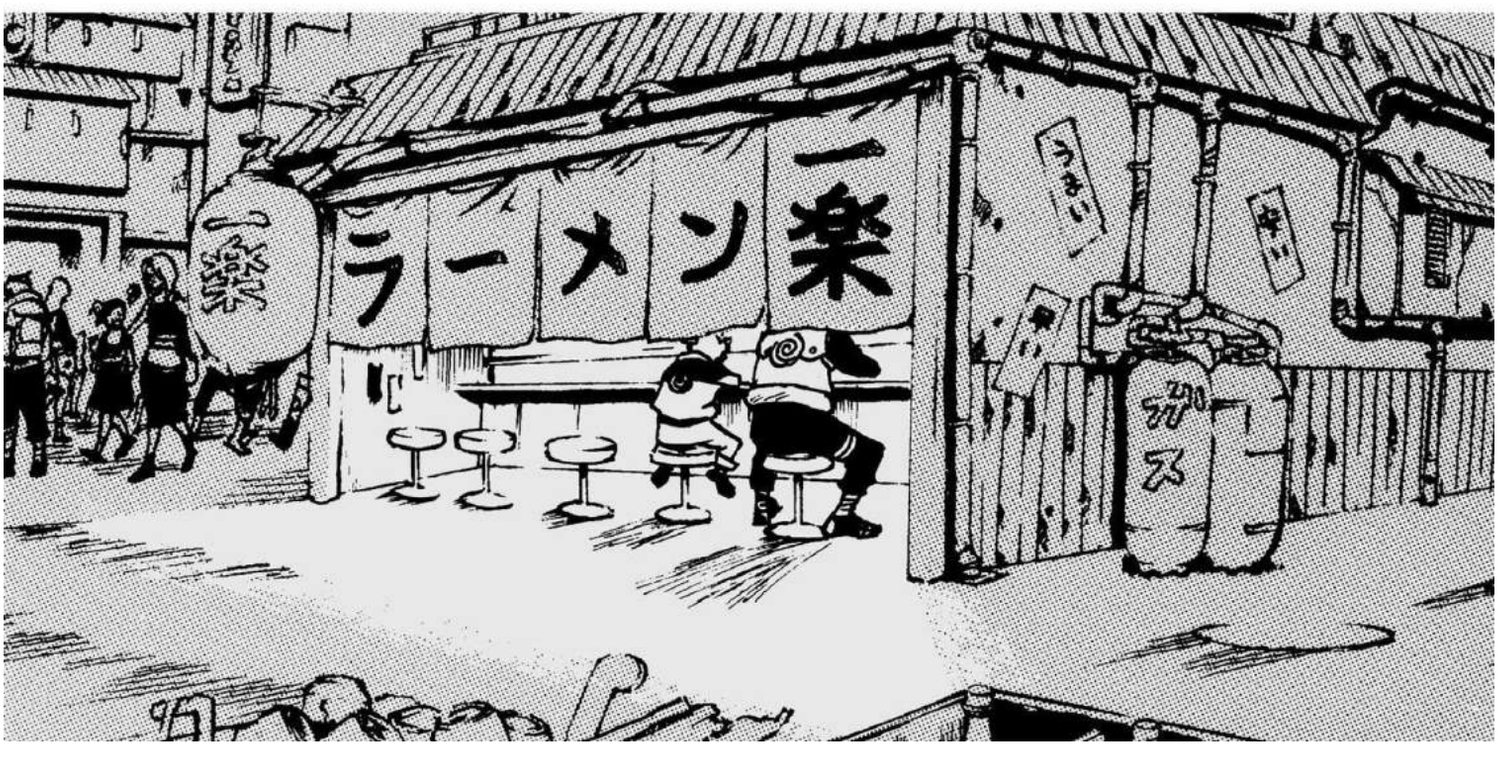
volume 10

岸本斉史

The *Naruto* comics are already at volume 10! In the blink of an eye, we've reached double digits! Although I doubt that triple digits is a milestone we'll ever achieve, it would make me exceedingly happy if all of you would continue to read and enjoy *Naruto*, without ever getting bored, for the entire run of the series!

—Masashi Kishimoto, 2001

Author/artist Masashi Kishimoto was born in 1974 in rural Okayama Prefecture, Japan. After spending time in art college, he won the Hop Step Award for new manga artists with his manga **Karakuri** (Mechanism). Kishimoto decided to base his next story on traditional Japanese culture. His first version of **Naruto**, drawn in 1997, was a one-shot story about fox spirits; his final version, which debuted in **Weekly Shonen Jump** in 1999, quickly became the most popular ninja manga in Japan.



NARUTO VOL. 10
SHONEN JUMP Manga Edition

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STORY AND ART BY MASASHI KISHIMOTO

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PARENTAL ADVISORY
NARUTO is rated T for Teen and is recommended for ages 13 and up. This volume contains realistic & fantasy violence and partial nudity.
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SHONEN JUMP MANGA

VOL. 10

A SPLENDID NINJA

STORY AND ART BY

MASASHI KISHIMOTO

SAKURA サクラ

Smart and studious, Sakura is the brightest of Naruto's classmates, but she's constantly distracted by her crush on Sasuke. Her goal: to win Sasuke's heart!

NARUTO ナルト

When Naruto was born, a destructive fox spirit was imprisoned inside his body. Spurned by the older villagers, he's grown into an attention-seeking trouble-maker. His goal: to become the village's next *Hokage*.

SASUKE サスケ

The top student in Naruto's class, Sasuke comes from the prestigious Uchiha clan. His goal: to get revenge on a mysterious person who wronged him in the past.

Gaara 我愛羅
Bloodthirsty Gaara is one of the scariest ninja competing in the Chûnin Exams.

Rock Lee ロック・リー
Lee has been carefully observing the other students' fights while his anticipation for his own battle builds. Now it's about to begin!

Might Guy マイト・ガイ
The flamboyant Master Guy is Lee's idol…and Kakashi's rival!

Kakashi カカシ
Although he doesn't have an especially warm personality, Kakashi is protective of his students.

Orochimaru 大蛇丸
This nefarious master of disguise placed a mysterious curse-mark on Sasuke and hopes to mold Sasuke into his successor.

Kabuto カブト
A spy for Orochimaru's village of Otogakure (The Village Hidden in the Sound), Kabuto has been living a double life in Konohagakure since childhood.

THE STORY SO FAR...

Twelve years ago, a destructive nine-tailed fox spirit attacked the ninja village of Konohagakure. The *Hokage*, or village champion, defeated the fox by sealing its soul into the body of a baby boy. Now that boy, Uzumaki Naruto, has grown up to become a ninja-in-training, learning the art of *ninjutsu* with his classmates Sakura and Sasuke.

Naruto, Sasuke and Sakura (along with six other teams of student ninja) have moved on to the third portion of the Chûnin (Journeyman Ninja) Selection Exam—a series of no-holds-barred, one-on-one bouts that begin with a set of preliminary matches. As the preliminaries continue, the battles become increasingly vicious and it's clear that lives are on the line. After the fight between Hyuga Hinata and her cousin Hyuga Neji ends with Hinata being rushed to the emergency room, tensions are at an all-time high. Then the next two combatants are announced: Rock Lee and Gaara!

NARUTO

VOL. 10
A SPLENDID NINJA

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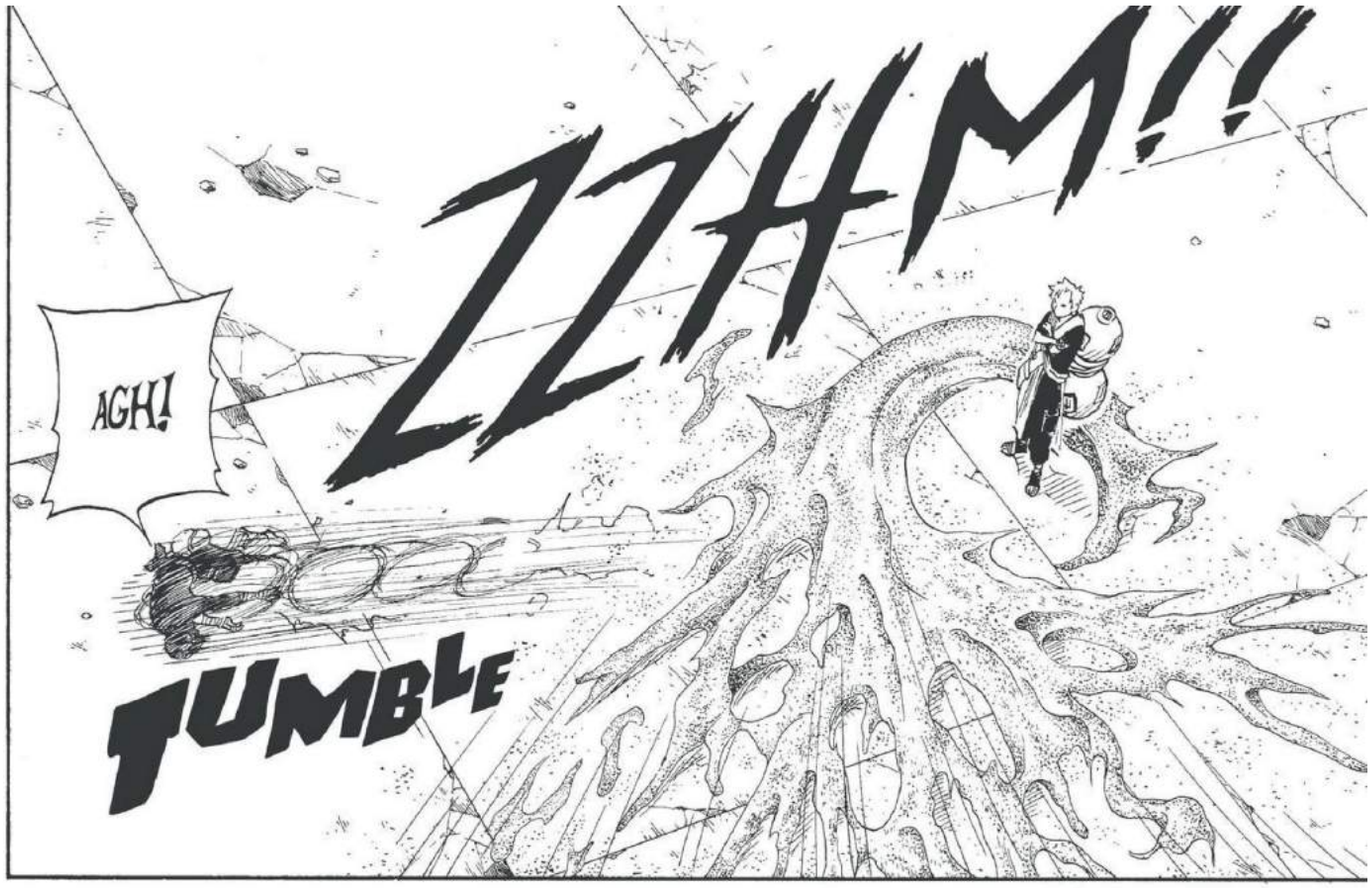
Number 82: Lee's Secret!!!

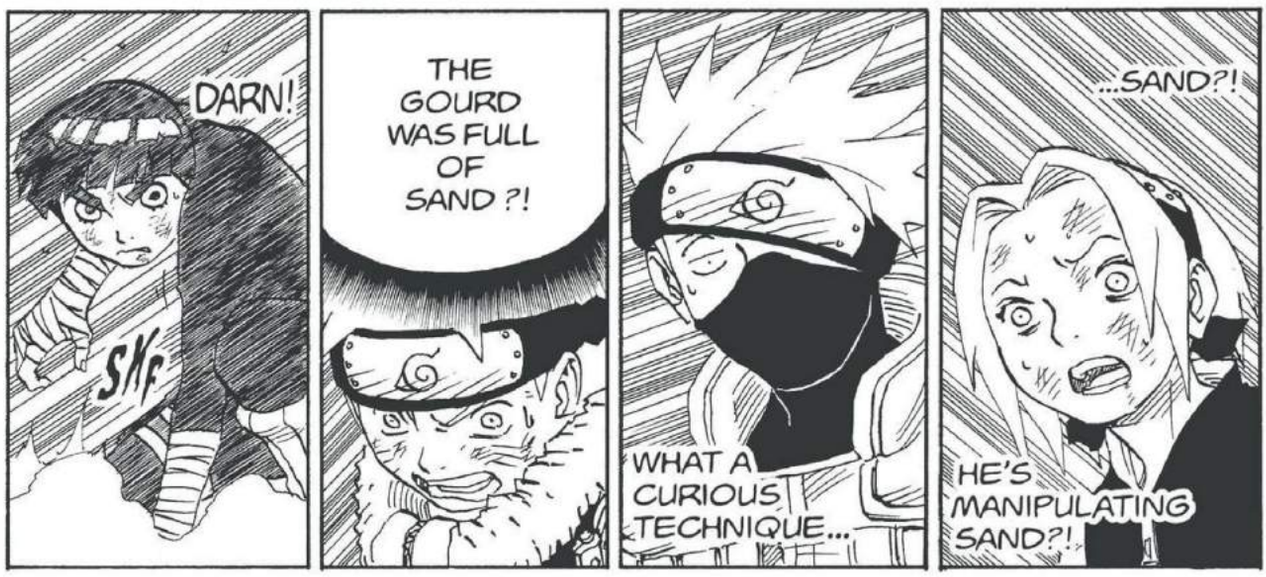
...
GULP
...BUT THERE'S NO WAY HE'LL WIN AGAINST GAARA.
I DON'T KNOW WHAT KIND OF TRICKS THIS BOWL-CUT KID HAS UP HIS SLEEVE...
SHF
!
FW
UP
BAM
NO... HE'S STRONGER THAN YOU THINK...

READ THIS WAY
PLEASE... DON'T RUSH THINGS.
GRAB
ALL RIGHT, THEN. LET THE NINTH-ROUND BATTLE BEGIN!!
...
...LEE.
WATCH YOURSELF...

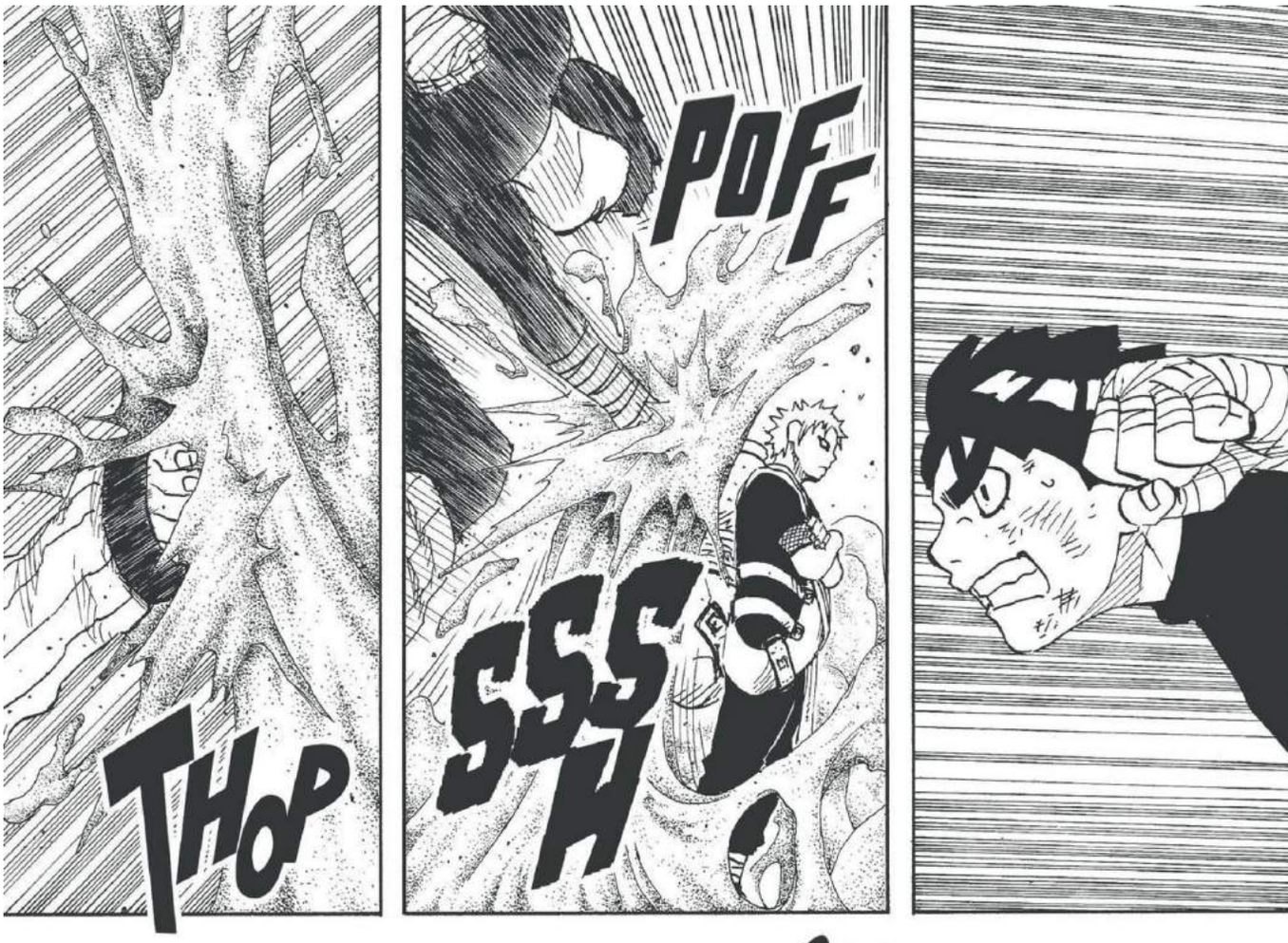
!
HEH... HE'S NO MATCH FOR GAARA.
HE MAY BE FAST... ...BUT HIS KICK WASN'T ANY-THING SPECIAL.
TAK
HOP

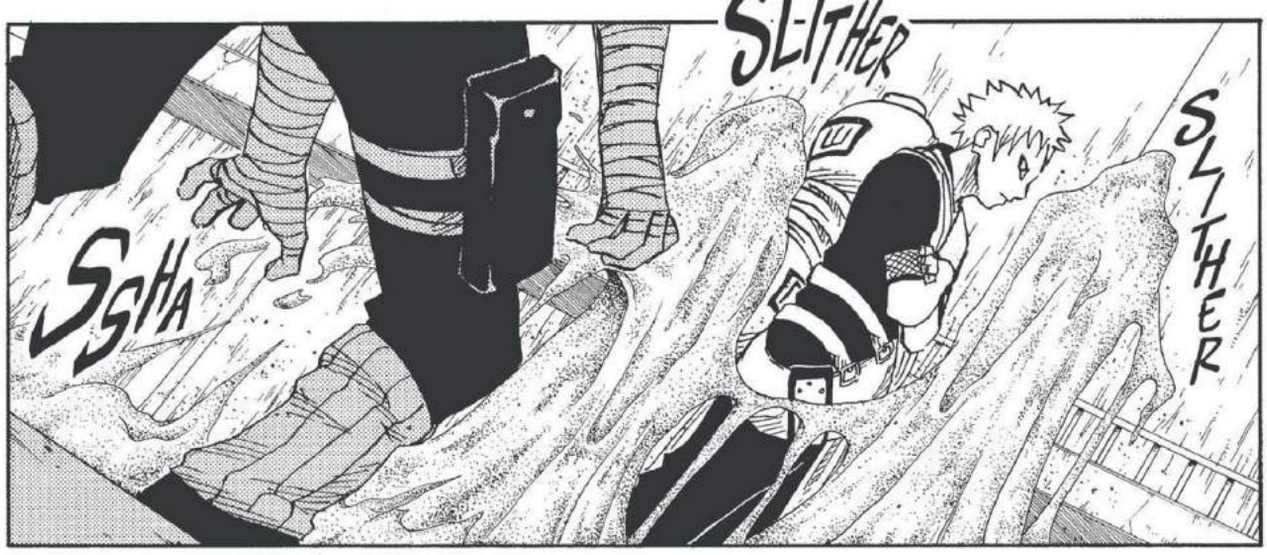
KONOHA HURRICANE!!!
FWSH
THOPSSSSSS
!!
!!
...
...SAND ...?!


AGH!
TUMBLE


DARN!
SKF
THE GOURD WAS FULL OF SAND?!
WHAT A CURIOUS TECHNIQUE...
...SAND?!
HE'S MANIPULATING SAND?!

TAK
TAK
HOP
TAK


THOP
POFF
SSSH


SLITHER
SSHA
SLITHER

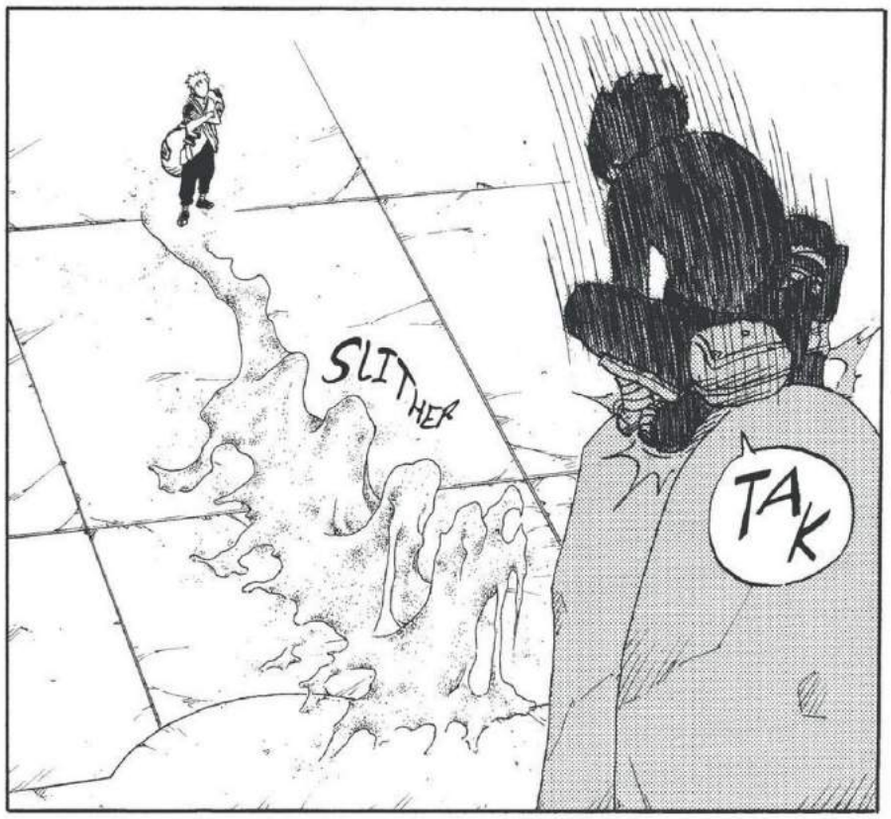
FAST AS HE IS, LEE IS GETTING NOWHERE!

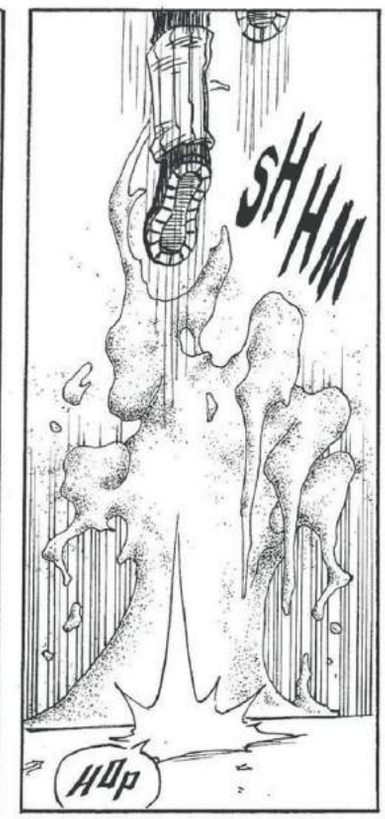
HUF
HUF
DARN!
WITHOUT EVEN MOVING A MUSCLE...
HUF

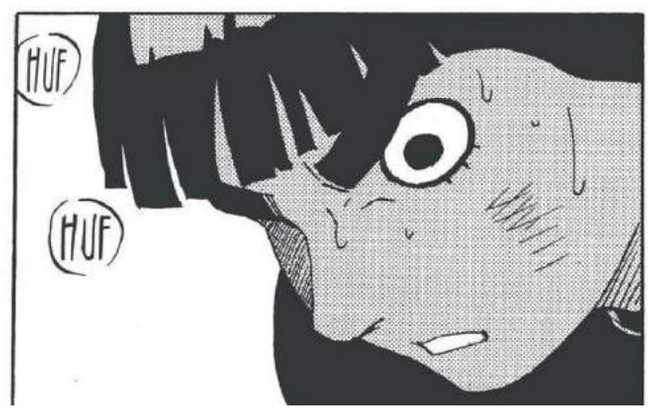
THAT'S WHY, TO THIS DAY, THERE'S NOT ONE PERSON...
...?
HIS ATTACKS JUST AREN'T WORKING!
PHYSICAL ATTACKS ARE WORTHLESS AGAINST GAARA.
THE SAND FORMS A SHIELD TO PROTECT HIS BODY...
... INDEPENDENT OF GAARA'S WILL.
...WHO HAS EVER WOUNDED HIM.
WHY IS LEE ONLY USING TAIJUTSU?!
TAIJUTSU ARE INEFFECTIVE AND PAINFUL AGAINST THAT WALL OF SAND. HE NEEDS TO USE NINJUTSU AND START ATTACKING FROM A DISTANCE!
GULP
...!
WHOP!
UNH!
SHUP

?!
...WHAT?!
HUNH?
IT'S NOT THAT LEE WON'T USE NINJUTSU...
...IT'S THAT HE CAN'T.
WHEN I FIRST MET LEE, HE HAD ABSOLUTELY NO SENSE... AND NO TALENT OR ABILITY WHATSOEVER!
A-ARE YOU JOKING? THEN HOW HAS HE LASTED THIS LONG?!
...LEE HAS PRACTICALLY NO NINJUTSU OR GENJUTSU ABILITIES...
!
THERE AREN'T MANY NINJA WHO CAN USE NEITHER NINJUTSU NOR GENJUTSU...
THAT'S WHY THE ONLY MOVES HE'S BEEN ABLE TO DEVELOP ARE TAIJUTSU.

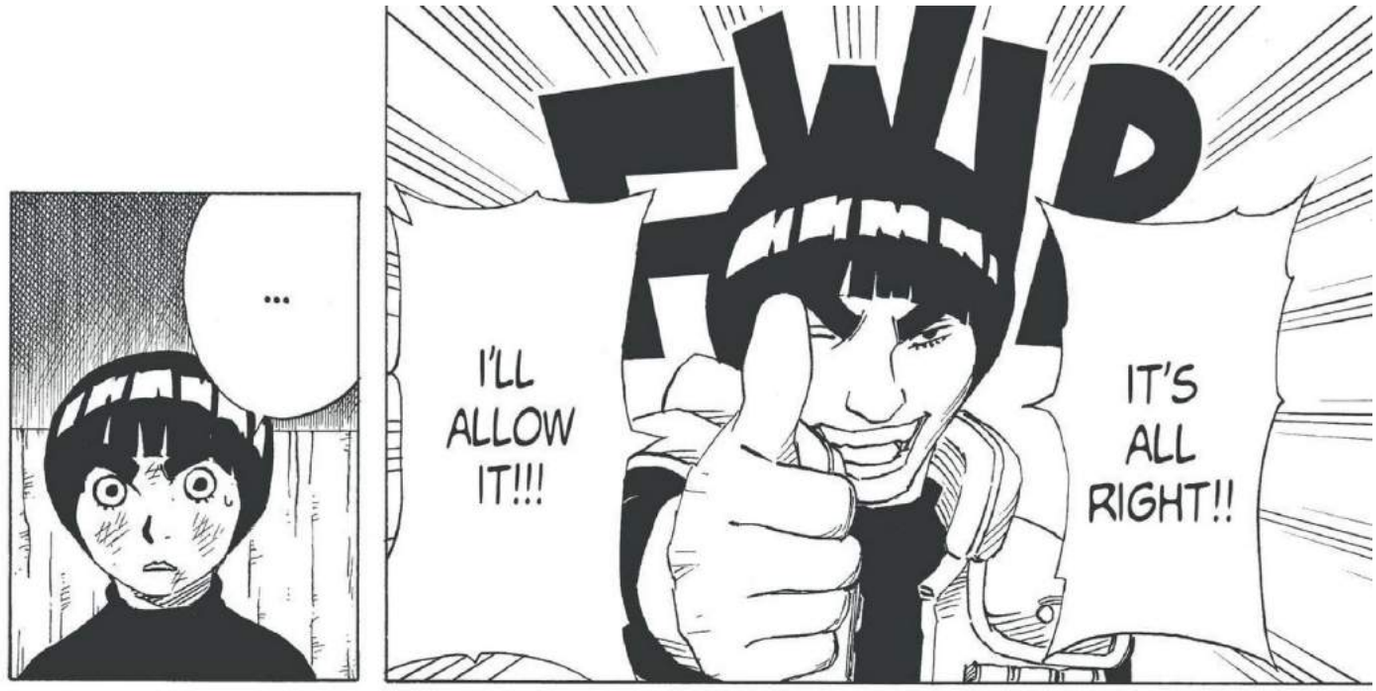
SWOP

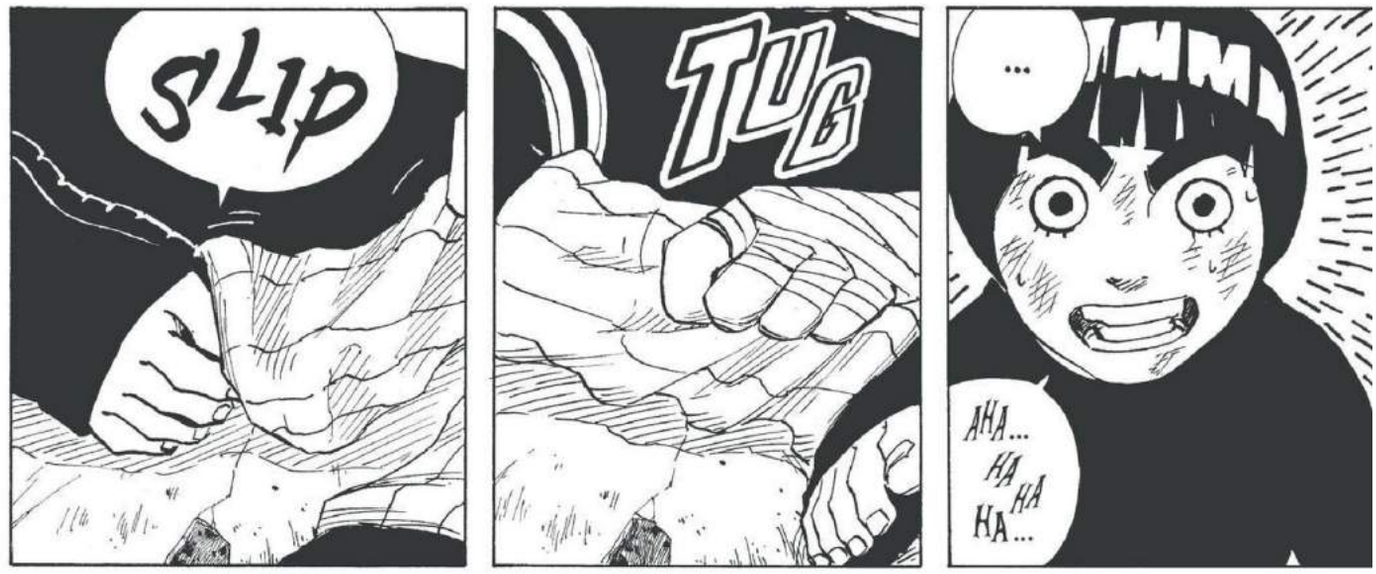

SLITHER
TAK


SHHM
HOP


HUF
HUF

READ THIS WAY
LEE! TAKE THEM OFF!!
...AND THAT'S PRECISELY WHY LEE CAN WIN!
HM?
HUH?
...!
愛
?
!
!
--NEVER TO DO THAT UNLESS I WAS DEFENDING THE LIVES OF PEOPLE WHO ARE PRECIOUS TO ME!!
B...BUT MASTER GUY! YOU SAID--

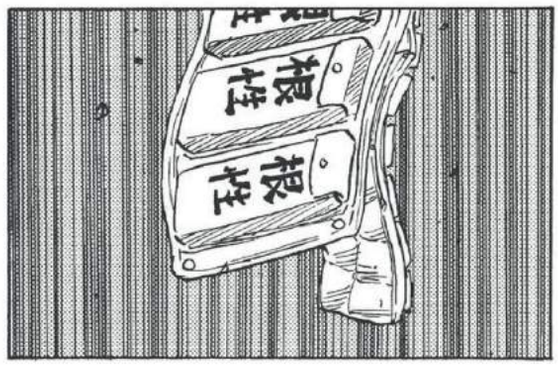




THE CHARACTERS BELOW SAY "KONJÔ," MEANING "GUTS," "TRUE GRIT" OR "WILLPOWER."

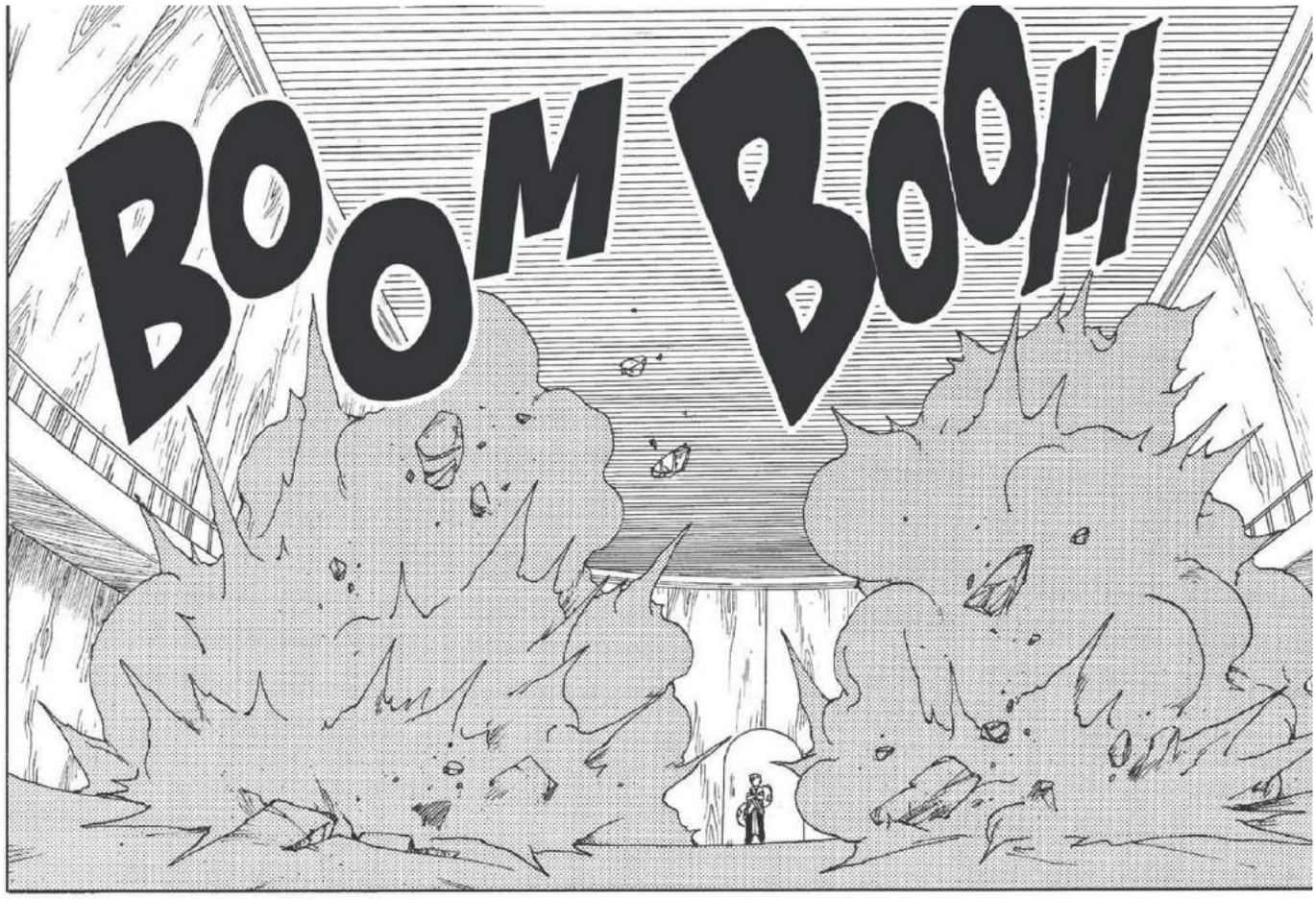
OH, GUY... THE MOST SICKENINGLY SWEET, SENTIMENTALLY TRADITIONAL KIND OF TRAINING!
...WEIGHTS?
...!
GRIN

I SEE!
HOW DUMB!!



SHF
NOW I CAN MOVE FREELY!!
RIGHT!!
SLIP
SLIP

...WILL LET YOU KEEP UP WITH GAARA'S SAND...
HMPH... THERE'S NO WAY DROPPING A FEW WEIGHTS...

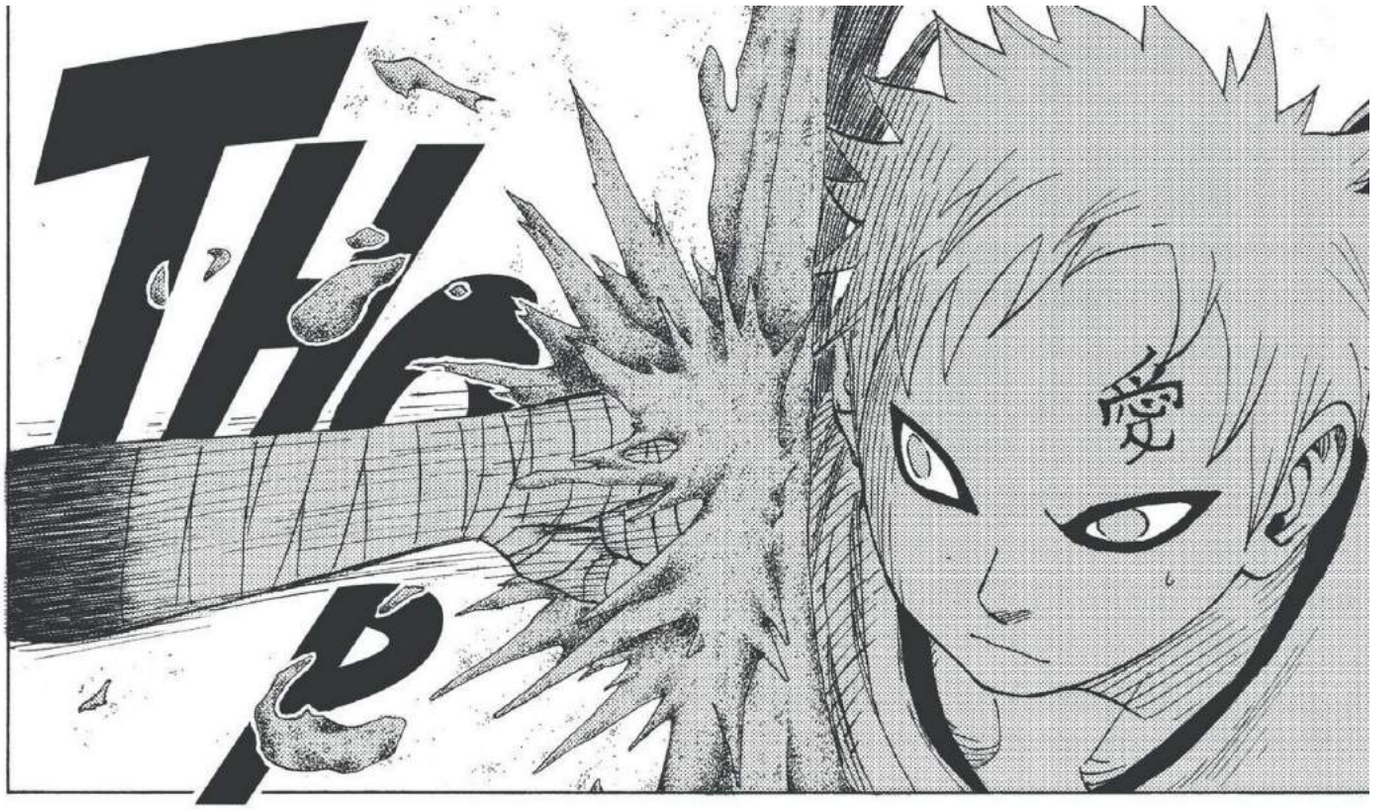

BOOM BOOM

!!
!!
!!
!!
...

FWIP
GO!!
LEE!!

AREN'T YOU OVER-DOING IT, GUY?
...

READ THIS WAY
FFN
YES, SIR!!
SMOKER
SMOKER
愛
!
POP
!!


愛

HE'S FAST...
ALMOST!!

BAM
SHHF
POW
WHAM
愛

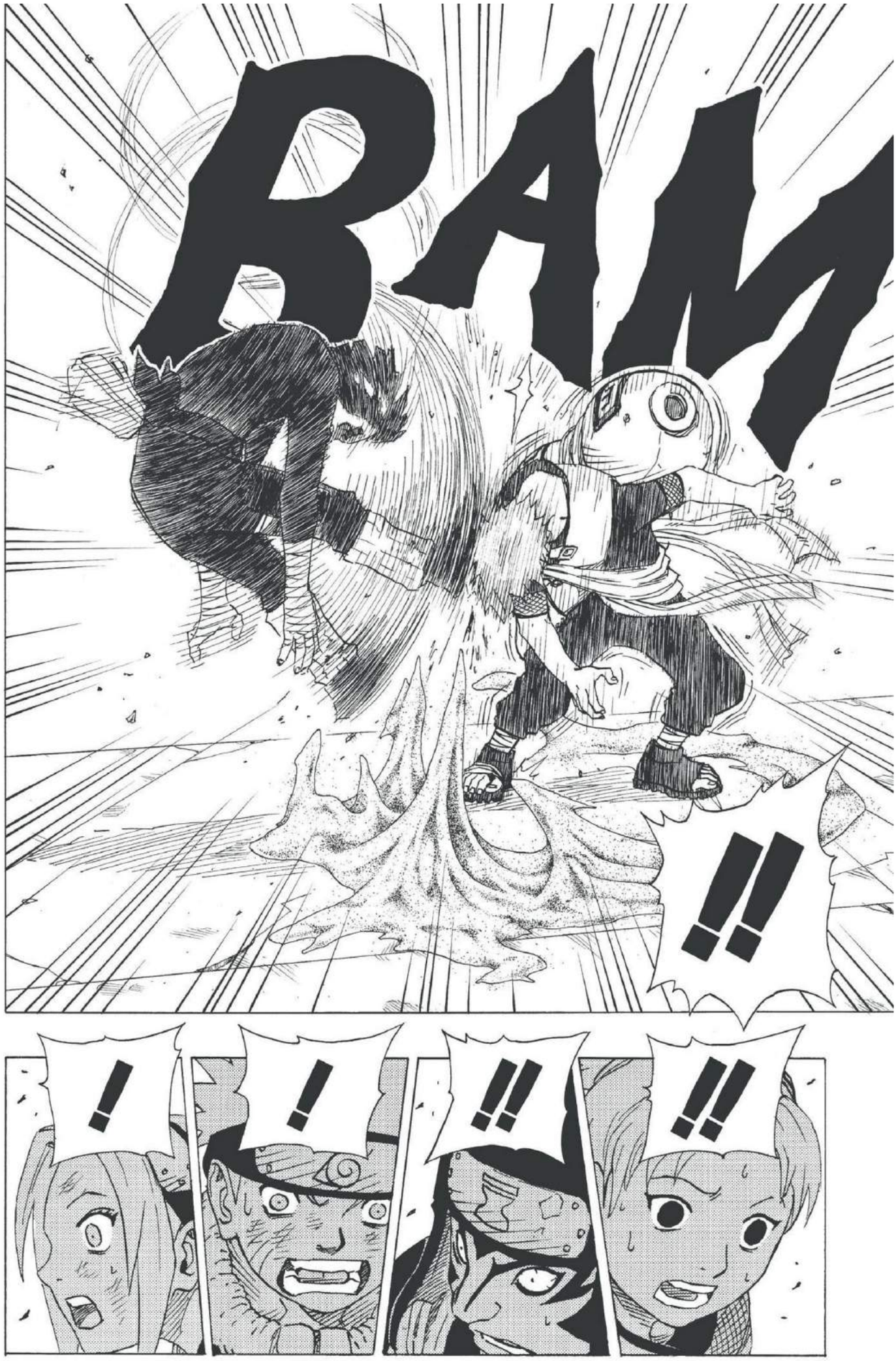
...THAT LEE DEVOTED HIMSELF SO EXCLUSIVELY TO TAIJUTSU. ALL HIS TIME... ALL HIS ENERGY... ALL HIS FOCUS.
IT'S BECAUSE HE HAD NO APTITUDE FOR EITHER NINJUTSU OR GENJUTSU...

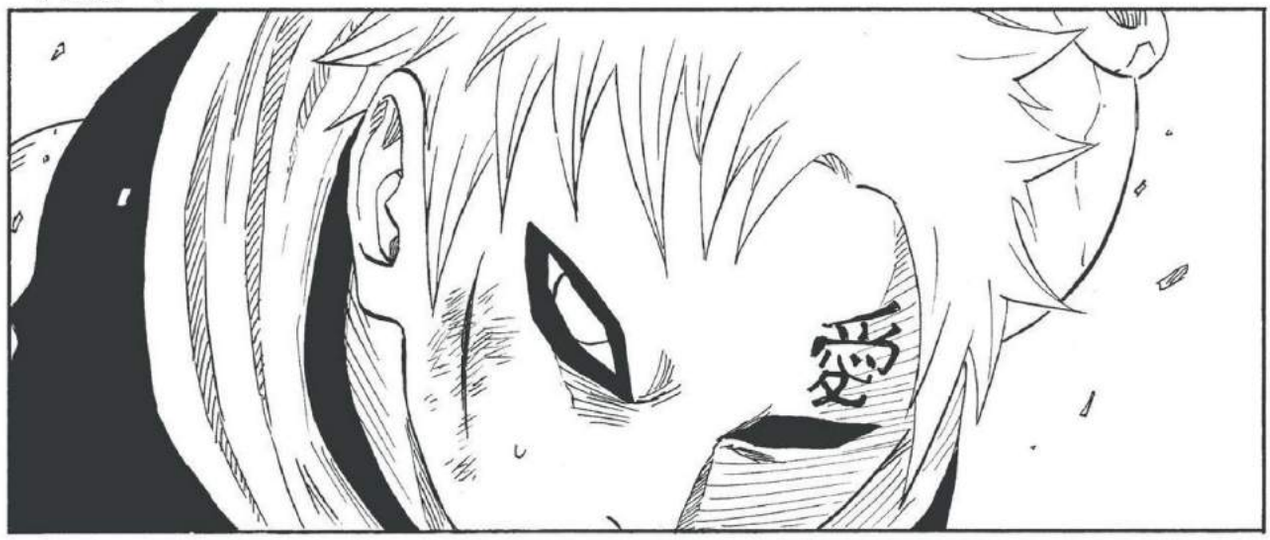
FWSH

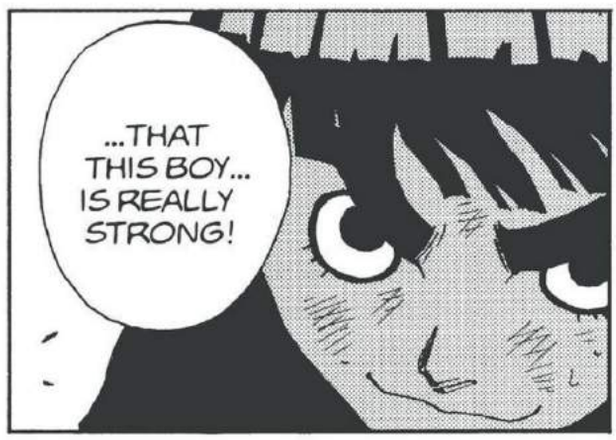
HE'D STILL BE UNBEAT-ABLE...
SO THAT EVEN IF HE LACKED ANY OTHER KIND OF ABILITIES AT ALL...

FWSH
?!

...AS A TAIJUTSU SPECIALIST!!


RAM
!!
!
!
!!
!!


愛


...THAT THIS BOY... IS REALLY STRONG!

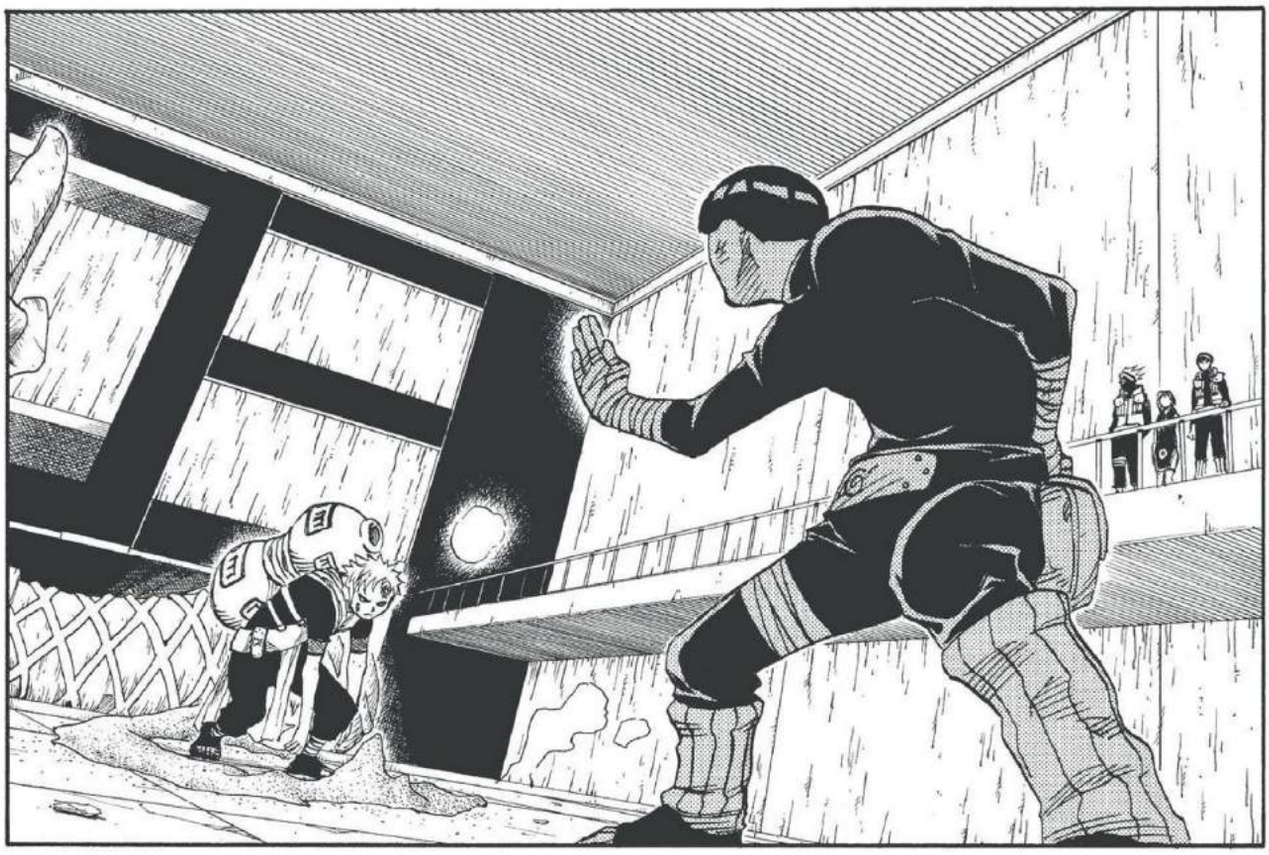
I THOUGHT I GAVE YOU ALL FAIR WARNING...
IN TERMS OF SPEED, LEE CAN'T BE SURPASSED ...

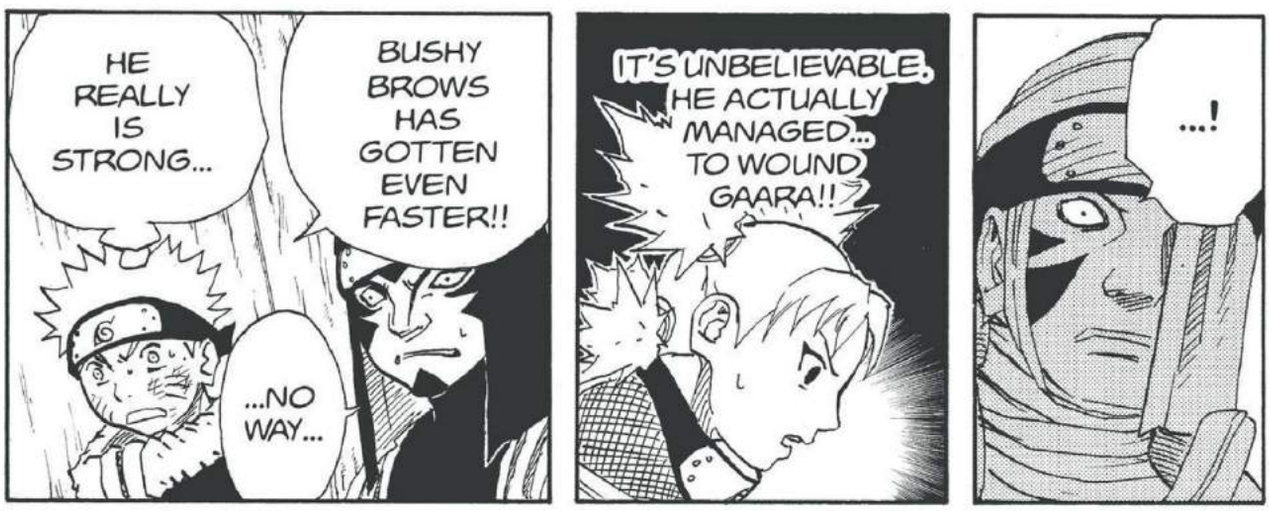
WELL... HERE WE GO!
SSLIDE

...
SSKF

Number 83: The Ultimate Defense... Crumbles?! zz

愛




HE REALLY IS STRONG...
BUSHY BROWS HAS GOTTEN EVEN FASTER!!
...NO WAY...
IT'S UNBELIEVABLE. HE ACTUALLY MANAGED... TO WOUND GAARA!!
...!

YES, SIR!!
HOP
NOW... EXPLODE!!!
LEE!!
!!
!
FWWM
FWWM
FFFM
!
OVER HERE...

THE SAND BARRIER COULDN'T KEEP UP WITH HIM. IT WAS NO PROTECTION AT ALL!
W...WOW! HE'S SO FAST!
KA
POW
HUF
SKFF
HUF
FLOP
I'M WEARING HIM DOWN!
HUF
SHHF
SHHF
SLUMP

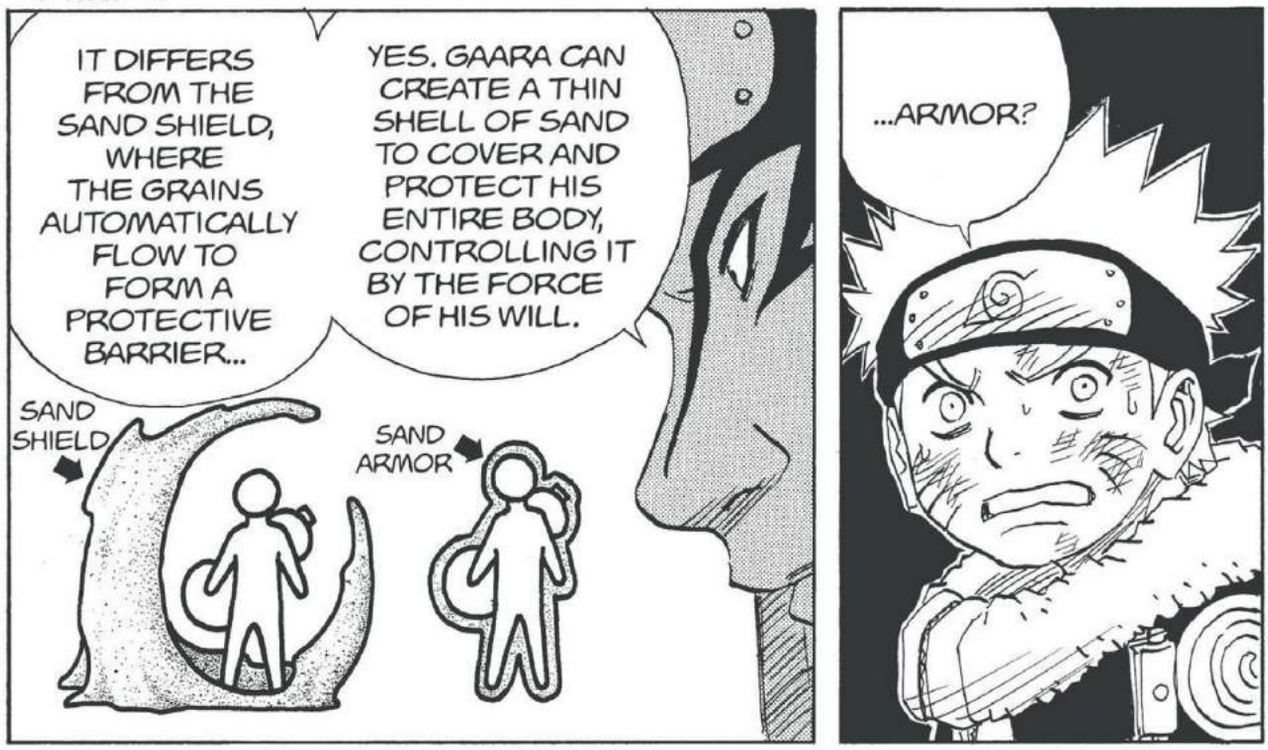
HIS MOVES ARE SO FAST, MY EYES CAN'T EVEN TRACK THEM!
W... WOW...
GULP

READ THIS WAY
?
...THAT'S NOT THE PROBLEM...
YOU GOT THAT RIGHT! THAT RACCOON-EYED JERK! AFTER THE WAY HE JUST GOT HIT, HE SHOULDN'T EVEN STILL BE STANDING!!
...THIS IS BAD...
SKIFF
SKITTER
SHHHF
PITTER
PAT
?!
...
...WHAT...?!
!!

愈
POK
SQUIRM
SKITTER
KRAK
SNAP
SHIVER
!!

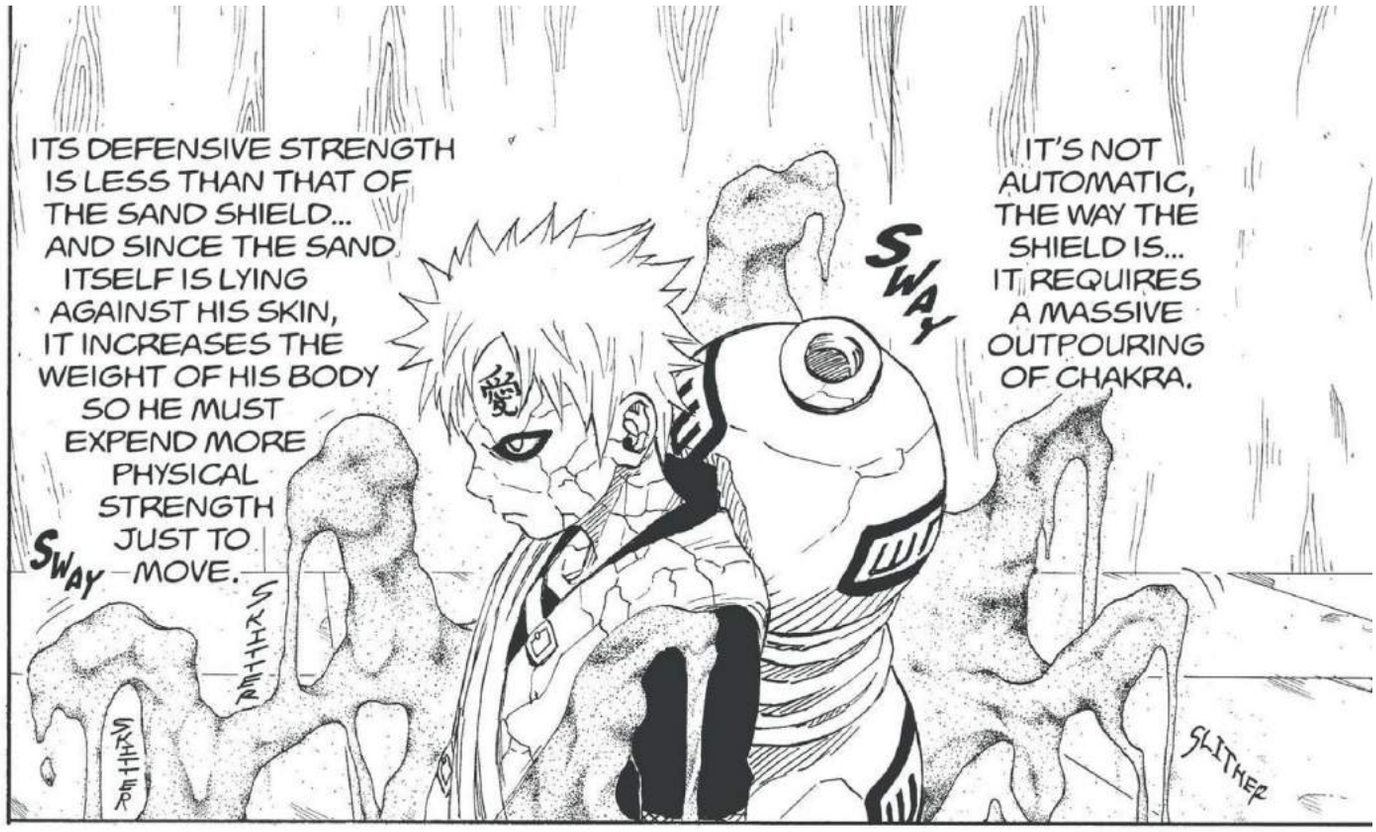
TREMBLE
WH...WHAT IS HE...?
GULP
THE BLOWS BARELY TOUCHED HIM.
HE MUMMIFIED HIMSELF IN SAND...!
HE'S USUALLY AS COMPOSED AS A STATUE, THE PICTURE OF POLITENESS AND DECORUM.
I HAD SENSED THAT, DURING THIS CHŪNIN SELECTION EXAMINATION, HE WAS BECOMING MORE AND MORE UNSTABLE... BUT...
HE WAS WEARING THE SAND LIKE A SHELL, EH...? HMM... IT'S BEEN QUITE SOME TIME SINCE I SAW THAT EXPRESSION ON HIS FACE...
WHOA! HIS WHOLE FACE JUST BROKE AND FELL OFF?!
...
SKF
THE OTHER GAARA...
IS NOW TOTALLY AWAKE...!
IF THIS GAARA IS ABLE TO CATCH LEE...
GULP

...!
...LEE WILL BE TOYED WITH AND THEN KILLED!
ZZZHZHZH
HEY! WHAT'S THAT?! WHAT'S HE...?
IS IT SOME WAY OF PROTECTING HIMSELF FROM BUSHY BROWS?!
IT'S SAND ARMOR.
ZZH
愛
ZZHE

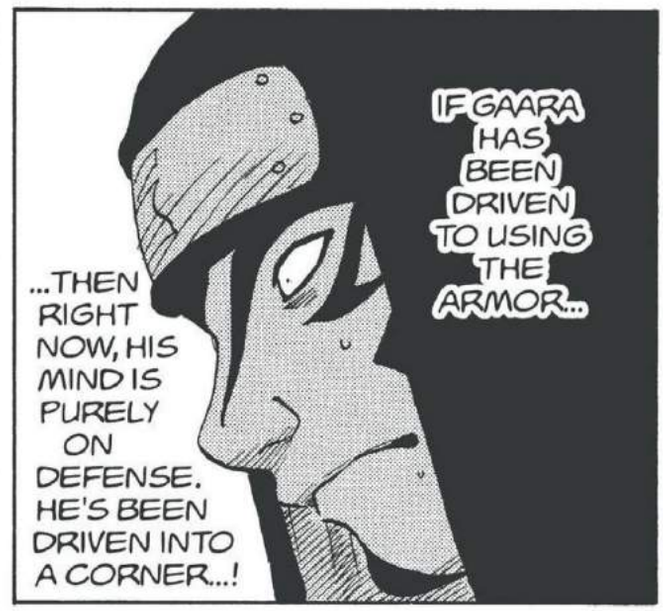

IT DIFFERS FROM THE SAND SHIELD, WHERE THE GRAINS AUTOMATICALLY FLOW TO FORM A PROTECTIVE BARRIER...
YES. GAARA CAN CREATE A THIN SHELL OF SAND TO COVER AND PROTECT HIS ENTIRE BODY, CONTROLLING IT BY THE FORCE OF HIS WILL.
SAND SHIELD
SAND ARMOR
...ARMOR?

...THEN... THERE'S NOTHING LEE CAN DO!
...ULTIMATE DEFENSE!
IT'S GOT NO WEAKNESSES...!
IT'S GAARA'S...

IT'S HIS PROTECTION OF LAST RESORT.
THAT'S NOT EXACTLY TRUE. THE SAND ARMOR IS ACTUALLY RIDDLED WITH WEAK POINTS...


ITS DEFENSIVE STRENGTH IS LESS THAN THAT OF THE SAND SHIELD... AND SINCE THE SAND ITSELF IS LYING AGAINST HIS SKIN, IT INCREASES THE WEIGHT OF HIS BODY SO HE MUST EXPEND MORE PHYSICAL STRENGTH JUST TO MOVE.
SWAY
SWAY
SLITHER
SLITHER
SLITHER
IT'S NOT AUTOMATIC, THE WAY THE SHIELD IS... IT REQUIRES A MASSIVE OUTPOURING OF CHAKRA.

BUT THE END OF THIS IS A FORE-GONE CONCLU-SION...
THAT LEE IS REALLY SOME-THING!


IF GAARA HAS BEEN DRIVEN TO USING THE ARMOR...
...THEN RIGHT NOW, HIS MIND IS PURELY ON DEFENSE. HE'S BEEN DRIVEN INTO A CORNER...!

!
IS THAT ALL...?

BECAUSE GAARA... IS A GENIUS!!!

READ THIS WAY
WHAT'S HE UP TO NOW?!
LEE...
MY ONLY SHOT IS TO JUST KEEP POUNDING AND PUNISHING THAT OUTER LAYER OF SAND!
IT'S AN AMAZING DEFENSE! HE'S ENCASED IN PROTECTION, WHICH MAKES MY SPEED IRRELEVANT...
...THE LOTUS!!
HEH!
NOD

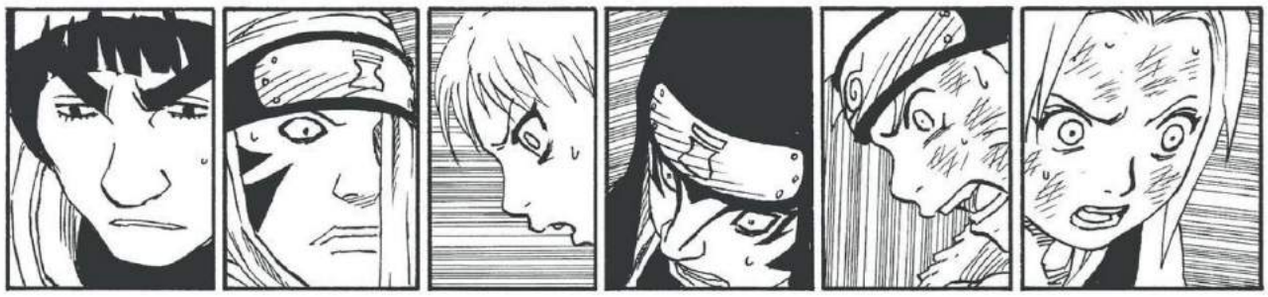
A THIN LAYER OF SAND WON'T STAND UP TO IT.
THE LOTUS TECHNIQUE WILL LET HIM STRIKE HIS FOE AT HIGH SPEED...
SH F
FLUTTER
FLUTTER
!
TAK TAK TAK TAK TAK
COME ON... HURRY UP!
...IN WHICH CASE...!
AND IF IT HAPPENS THAT HE'S WEARING A THICK SHELL OF SAND, IT WILL BE ALMOST IMPOSSIBLE FOR HIM TO KICK OUTWARD...

KRA
JK
AUGH!
AS YOU WISH!
BOOM
AND THAT'S NOT ALL!!
TAK-TAK-TAK
THOP THOP
THOP THOP

THAT MANY CONSECUTIVE KICKS MAY BE TOO MUCH EVEN FOR LEE... BETTER MAKE YOUR NEXT MOVE A DECISIVE ONE, KID!!
...EVEN AN ORDINARY LOTUS MOVE EXERTS A GREAT STRAIN ON THE USER'S BODY...
!!
愈
THROB
OWW!
GLARE
...
SLITHER
GOTCHA!!
SNAT
!!
YANK!!

WWOW
FOR-
WARD
LOTUS!!

SL
AM
HOP



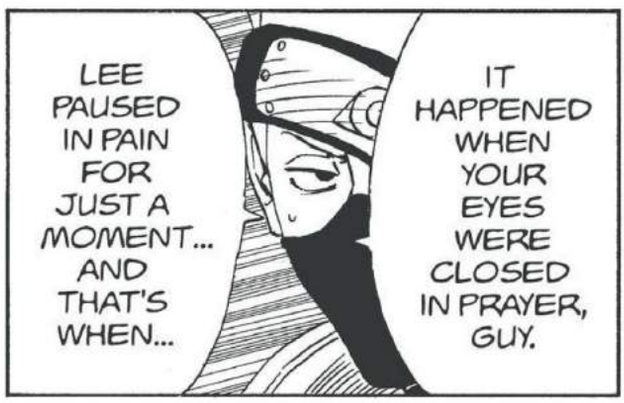
...D-DO YOU THINK HE'S DEAD...?
UH... YOU'RE KIDDING, RIGHT...?!

SSS
SSSSS

HE WON!!
LEE... HE...

TAP
...
YES!
...
PLINK
KLAT
PLINK
KRAK
KRAK
!!
HUF
HUF
HUF
!
HUF

愛
SLITHER
SLITHER


LEE PAUSED IN PAIN FOR JUST A MOMENT... AND THAT'S WHEN...
IT HAPPENED WHEN YOUR EYES WERE CLOSED IN PRAYER, GUY.

THERE'S NO WAY HE COULD HAVE GOTTEN PAST LEE!!
!
...WHEN DID HE SLIP OUT OF THAT SHELL?!

!!
SSSSHHHHHH
HEH HEH HEH...
SSSFFFF

Number 84: The Genius of Hard Work...!!

愛

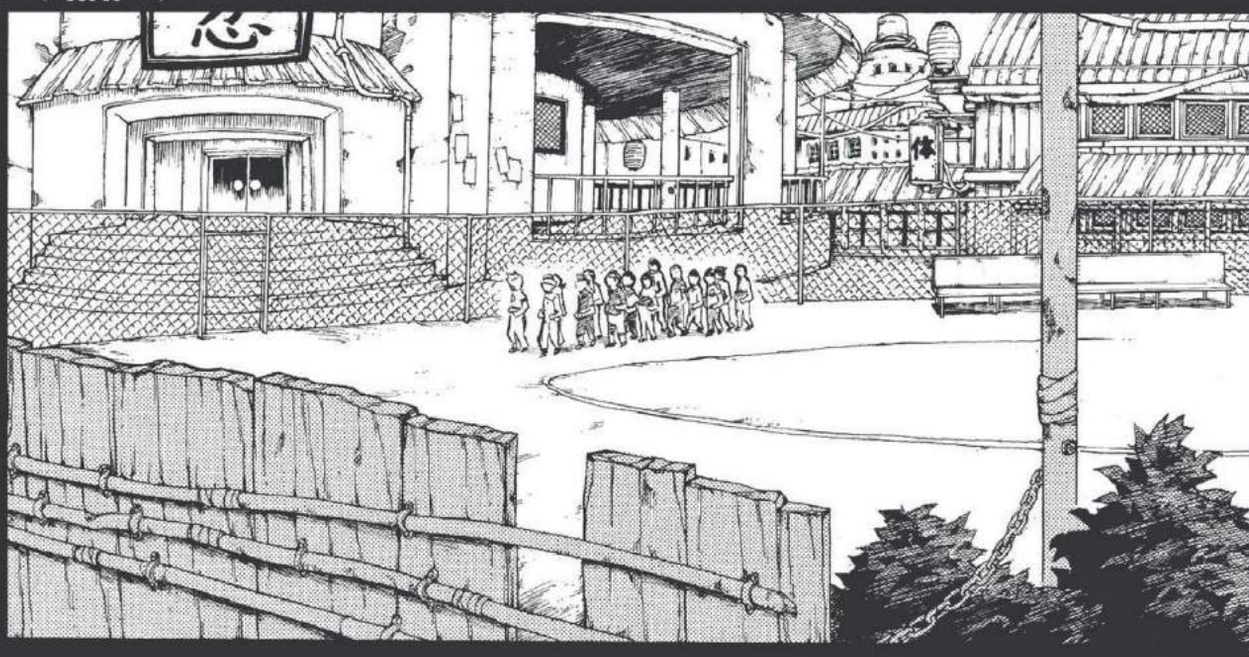
GAARA'S
INNER
DEMON!

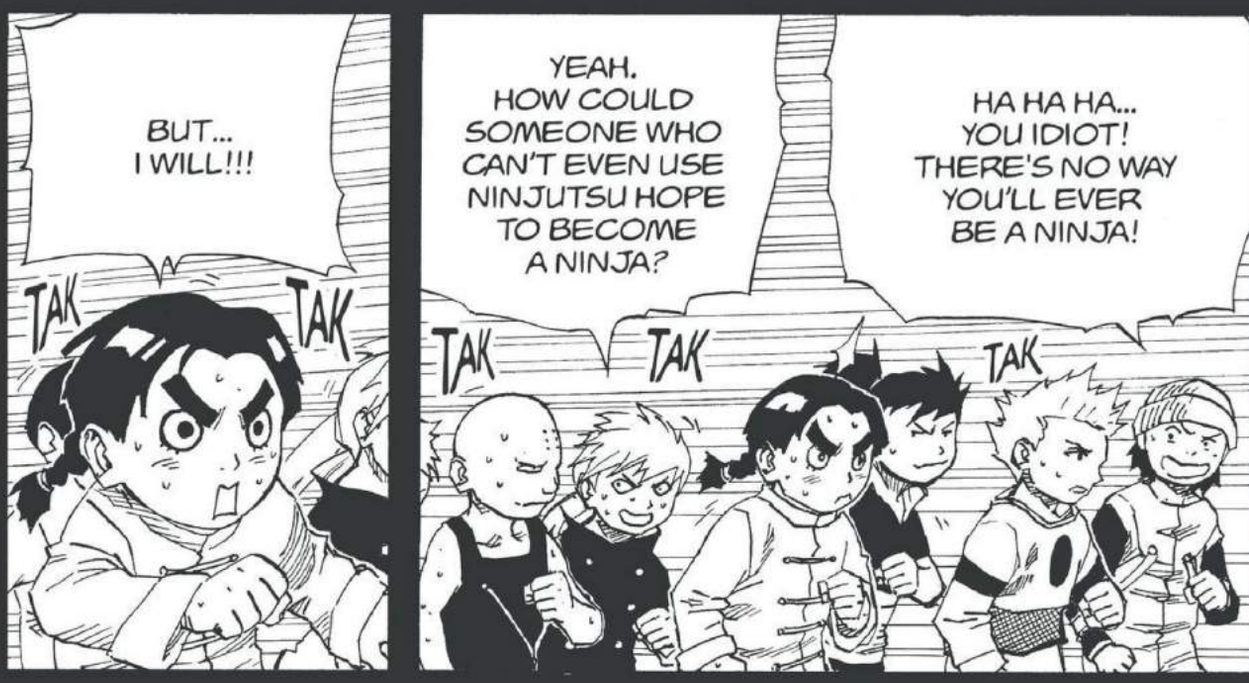
Number 84: The Genius of Hard Work!!

FW
SH
AUGH!!
SSLIP
!
FLOP
BA
MM
UNH!
FWAM
SKF
UGH

HUF
HUF
HUF
PLUFF
GAARA'S JUST TOYING WITH HIM...
MISTER BOWL-CUT IS AT THE END OF HIS ROPE.
POFFF
WHY DOESN'T LEE JUST DUCK?!
...
HUF
HUF
HUF
HUF
KUNK ?!
...THE LOTUS TECHNIQUE HE JUST USED... IT'S A DOUBLE-EDGED SWORD.

WHAM
AGH!
WHUD
USING THAT LEVEL OF HIGH-SPEED TAIJUTSU PUTS A HUGE STRAIN ON THE BODY...
FUNDA-MENTALLY, IT'S A FORBIDDEN MOVE.
RIGHT NOW, LEE'S NOTHING BUT A MASS OF PAIN AND WEAKNESS... ISN'T THAT RIGHT, GUY?
B-BUT... THAT MEANS...
HUF
HUF
SKF
RUMBLE
RUMBLE
...
LEE
...
...AT THIS RATE, LEE'S GONNA...
HUF
HUF




BUT... I WILL!!!
TAK
TAK
YEAH. HOW COULD SOMEONE WHO CAN'T EVEN USE NINJUTSU HOPE TO BECOME A NINJA?
HA HA HA... YOU IDIOT! THERE'S NO WAY YOU'LL EVER BE A NINJA!
TAK
TAK
TAK

HEH... WANT TO KNOW WHAT THE OTHER KIDS CALL YOU?
NO!
WHAT WERE THEY THINKING, LETTING YOU INTO THE NINJA ACADEMY?
YOU'RE NOT CAPABLE OF ANYTHING BUT TAIJUTSU... AND YOU'RE EVEN MEDIOCRE AT THAT!

*GENIN = JUNIOR NINJA

WELL THEN...

I DON'T WANT TO SAY.

FWAp
MASTER!!
!
EEP!

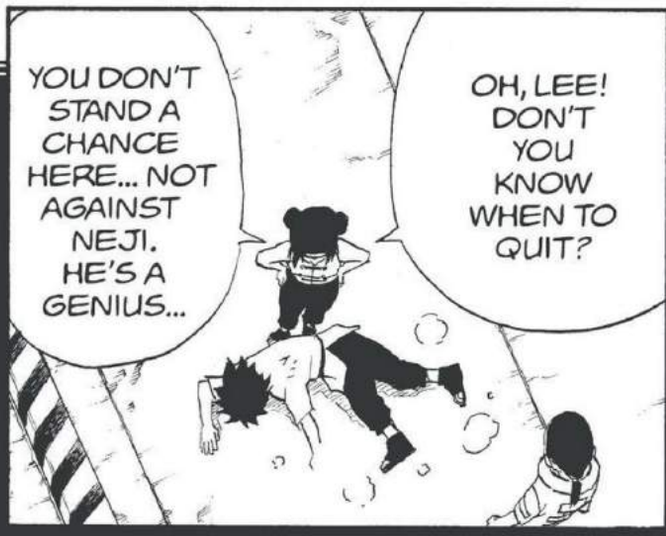
...THE LEGEND-ARY LADY TSUNADE!
I WANT TO BECOME A STRONG KUNOICHI, LIKE MY IDOL...

IT'S MY ONLY GOAL!!
...CAN STILL BECOME A SPLENDID NINJA!
I WANT TO PROVE THAT EVEN A PERSON WHO CAN'T USE NINJUTSU OR GENJUTSU...

HEY! WHAT'S SO FUNNY?!
JAB
HEH...

HE'S GOT GOOD EYES...

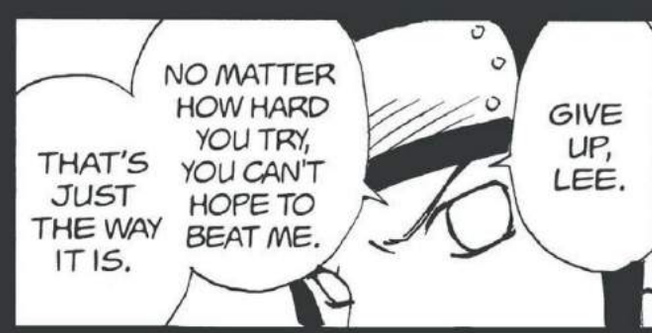
UNH...


YOU DON'T STAND A CHANCE HERE... NOT AGAINST NEJI. HE'S A GENIUS...
OH, LEE! DON'T YOU KNOW WHEN TO QUIT?

WHAM

...AND YOU'RE NOT.

UGH...


GIVE UP, LEE.
NO MATTER HOW HARD YOU TRY, YOU CAN'T HOPE TO BEAT ME.
THAT'S JUST THE WAY IT IS.

...
HUF
HUF
OKAY... IF 500 CONSECUTIVE PUSHUPS DON'T MAKE ME STRONG ENOUGH, THEN I'LL DO 1200 DOUBLE-SKIPS WITH THE JUMP ROPE...
HUP
HUF
HUF
HUF
HUF
YEAH! YEAH! YEAH!
HUP
HUF
AND IF 1200 DOUBLE-SKIPS DON'T DO IT, THEN I'LL KICK THE WOODEN PRACTICE DUMMY 2000 TIMES!
VVWW
HOP
HOP
...1116... 1117...
WHOA!
TRIP

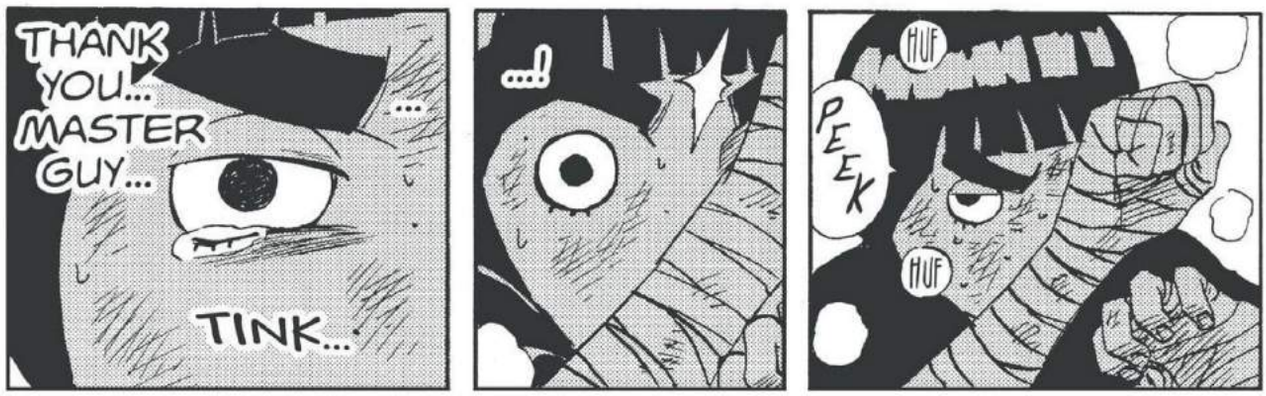
WHUMP
...
CHOK
SOB
WAH...
OWW!
UNH...
...
!
SHHF
SO, LEE... TAKING A BREAK ALREADY?

WHAK
SKF
DID YOU... NEED SOME-THING, MASTER GUY?
IF IT'S ABOUT THE BLUNDER I MADE DURING THE LAST MISSION, I THOUGHT I'D ALREADY MADE IT UP TO YOU!
PAT PAT
...
NEVERTHELESS, LEE... THERE'S ONE AREA WHERE YOU COMPLETELY SURPASS NEJI.
YOU'RE A GENIUS OF ANOTHER KIND WITH GREAT HIDDEN POTENTIAL.
YOU KNOW... YOU REALLY ARE VERY DIFFERENT FROM NEJI...
YOU'RE NO GENIUS AT NINJUTSU OR GENJUTSU... AND YOU REALLY AREN'T A TAIJUTSU VIRTUOSO, EITHER.
...
...THAT YOU ARE...
I'M NOT TRYING TO BE NICE. I'M JUST SAYING...
YOU'RE JUST SAYING THAT TO BE NICE!!
THOK

...A GENIUS OF HARD WORK.
...!
...MEAN THAT?
...DO YOU REALLY...
...
...OF EVER MEASURING UP TO A TRUE GENIUS LIKE NEJI.
BUT... LATELY, I'VE STARTED TO FEEL THAT I HAD NO HOPE...
...BY HAVING FAITH THAT, IF I TRAINED TWO OR THREE TIMES AS HARD AS NEJI, I MIGHT FINALLY BEAT HIM.
I'VE ALWAYS BELIEVED THAT.
CLENCH
I... I'VE ONLY BEEN ABLE TO MAKE IT THIS FAR...

READ THIS WAY
AND EVEN NOW, ON MISSIONS, MY LEGS STILL TREMBLE IN FEAR...
...SO I'VE KEPT CHALLENG-ING NEJI... BUT THE RESULTS HAVE ALWAYS BEEN THE SAME...
I'M NO MATCH FOR HIM!
I'VE WONDERED IF IT WAS POSSIBLE FOR HARD WORK ALONE TO BE REWARDED...
SMAK
IT SCARES ME SO MUCH I CAN'T STAND IT.
PLIT PLIT
...FEAR THAT NO MATTER HOW HARD I WORK, I'LL NEVER GET STRONGER.
...I DON'T KNOW WHAT TO DO...
...

ALL YOUR HARD WORK WILL PROVE WORTH-LESS...
...UNLESS YOU BELIEVE IN YOURSELF!


THANK YOU... MASTER GUY...
TINK...
...!
HUF
PEEK
HUF

READ THIS WAY
THAT'S YOUR SHINOBI PATH, ISN'T IT?
"I WANT TO PROVE THAT EVEN A PERSON WHO CAN'T USE NINJUTSU OR GENJUTSU CAN STILL BECOME A SPLENDID NINJA!"
NOWADAYS, IN MATCHES AGAINST THAT ELITE GENIUS, KAKASHI, WE'RE NEARLY EVEN!!
YOU REMIND ME OF ME... WAY BACK WHEN I WAS A COMPLETE FAILURE.
!
...ONE THAT'S REALLY WORTH FIGHTING FOR.
IT'S A GREAT GOAL...
BECOME SUCH A STRONG FIGHTER THAT I CAN JUST SIT BACK AND ENJOY THE SHOW!
IT'S THE PATH YOU CHOSE, SO HAVE FAITH AND FOLLOW IT!
...!
YES, SIR!!
YOU GOT THAT, LEE?!

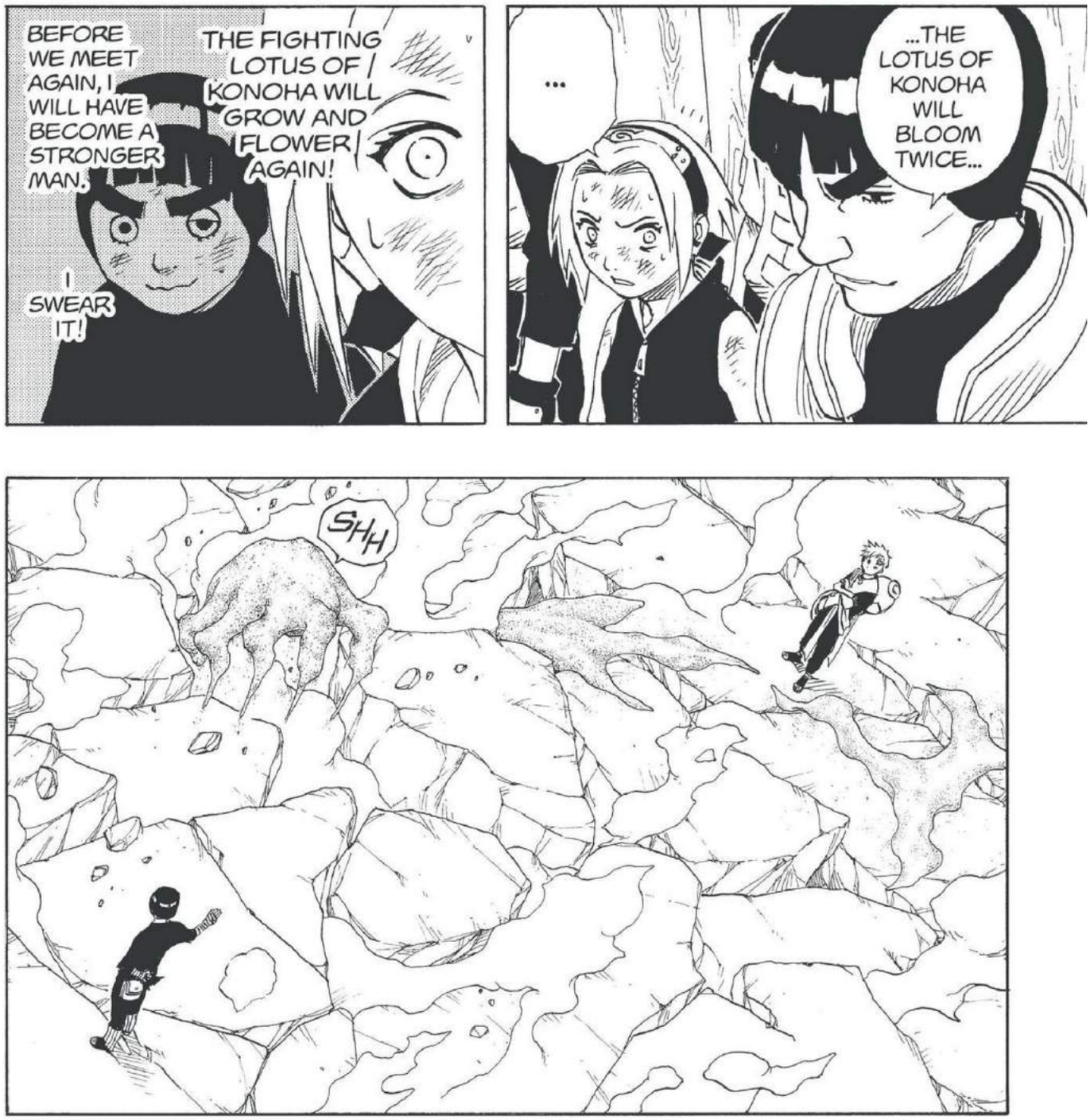
...LEE, NO! GIVE UP BEFORE HE KILLS YOU!!
SKF
WHSH
HOP
BAM

¡HE GOT HIS SPEED BACK!!
!
!
!
!
!

...STRONGER THAN EVER!
...AND TO MAKE ME...
FWUP
...JUST KNOWING THAT IS ENOUGH TO REVIVE ME...!
SHHF
!
RATTLE
MASTER GUY IS SITTING BACK AND ENJOYING THE SHOW...
HUH?
HE'S ABOUT TO START PUSHING BACK!
LEE'S BEING PUSHED AROUND SO BRUTALLY... WHY IS HE SMILING?
...WILL BLOOM TWICE!!
THE LOTUS OF KONOHA...

MASASHI
NA RU TO
KISHIMOTO

Number 85: Now, of All Times...!!


BEFORE WE MEET AGAIN, I WILL HAVE BECOME A STRONGER MAN.
I SWEAR IT!
THE FIGHTING LOTUS OF KONOHA WILL GROW AND FLOWER AGAIN!
...
...THE LOTUS OF KONOHA WILL BLOOM TWICE...
SHH
...THE NEXT MOVE WILL BE THE LAST.
WELL, ONE WAY OR ANOTHER...
...FOR YOU, IT ENDS HERE.

ON THE CONTRARY. I DID.
GUY... DON'T TELL ME YOU...!
THE LOTUS OF KONOHA WILL BLOOM TWICE?
...!
THEN... THAT KID, WHO'S JUST A GENIN...
...IS ABLE TO OPEN THE EIGHT INNER GATES...?
?
IT'S AWFUL ...
YES...
... THAT'S RIGHT.
NO MATTER HOW MUCH TALENT HE HAS, YOU TAUGHT HIM SOMETHING HORRIBLY DANGEROUS!
HE HAS THE TALENT...

THE REVERSE LOTUS TOPS THE LIST...
...OF MOVES THAT YOU SHOULDN'T TEACH!!

...REVERSE LOTUS...?
!!

YOU...
...

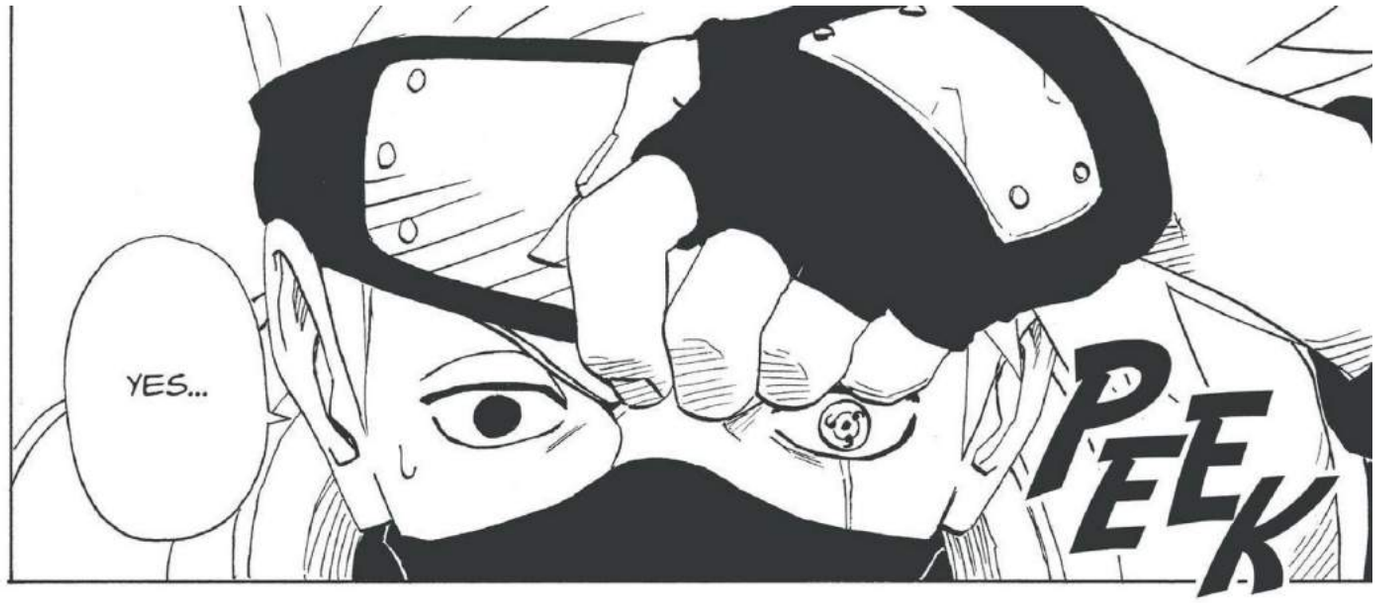
...DON'T KNOW THE FIRST THING ABOUT THAT KID...

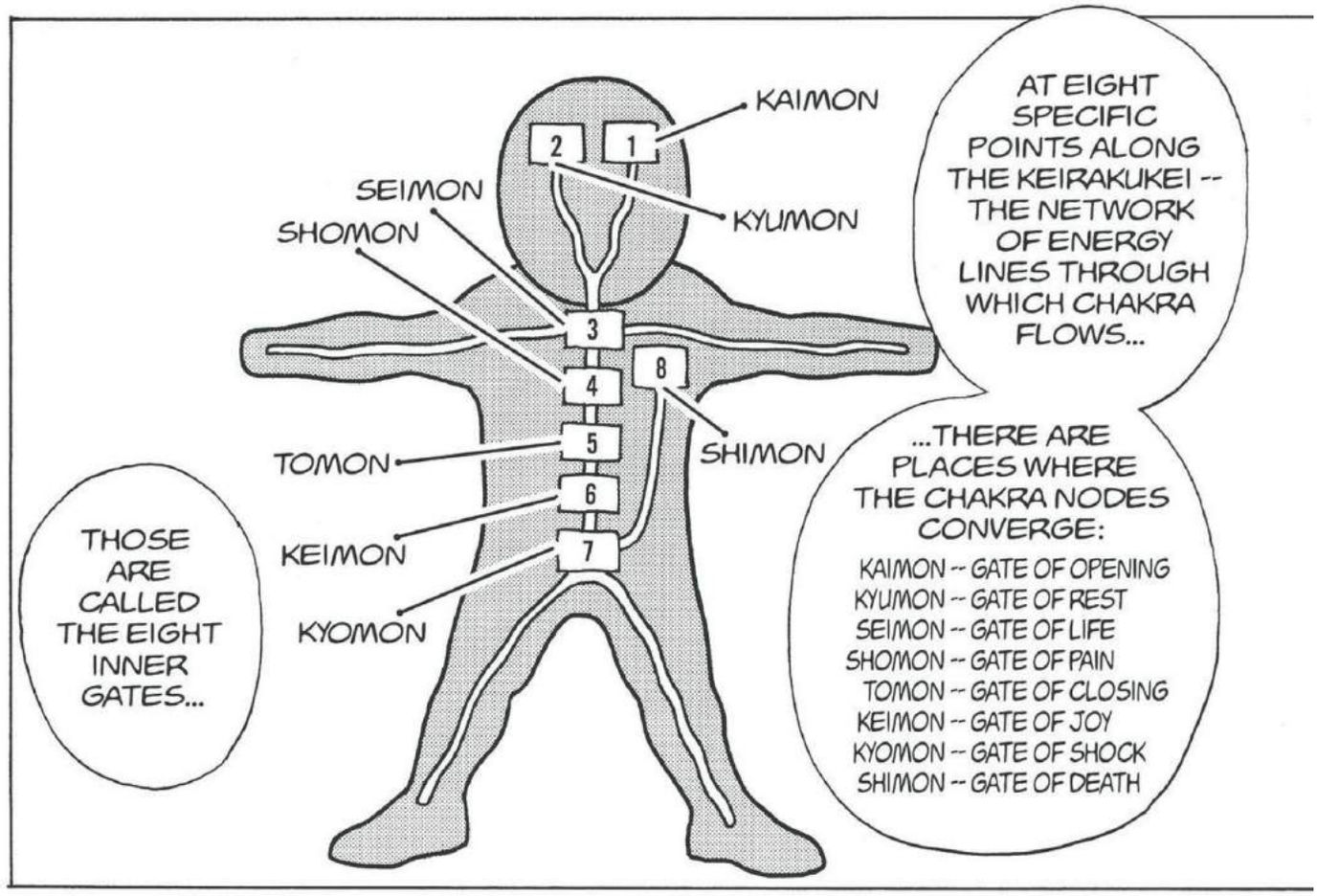
...AND I'LL SPARE US BOTH THE LECTURE ABOUT NOT BEING GOVERNED BY YOUR FEELINGS... BUT YOU CROSSED A LINE ON THIS!
IT'S NONE OF MY BUSINESS WHAT THAT CHILD MEANS TO YOU...
...YOU DISAPPOINT ME, GUY!

...CAN STILL BECOME A SPLENDID NINJA! IT'S MY ONLY GOAL!!
I WANT TO PROVE THAT EVEN A PERSON WHO CAN'T USE NINJUTSU OR GENJUTSU...
THAT'S WHY I... WANTED TO HELP HIM BECOME SOMEONE WHO'D BE ABLE TO STAND UP FOR HIS IDEALS.
I HAD TO.
THAT BOY HAS SOMETHING HE VALUES SO DEEPLY THAT HE'S WILLING TO DIE FOR THE SAKE OF IT.
OH BOY...
...THIS IS GREAT!!!
YOU BET I DID!!
LEE, DID YOU HEAR ME?
SNAP OUT OF IT AND PAY ATTENTION!!
LEE!
...A MOVE THAT CAN BECOME YOUR ACE IN THE HOLE.
...LEE... I'D LIKE TO SHOW YOU SOMETHING NEW...
HUNH?

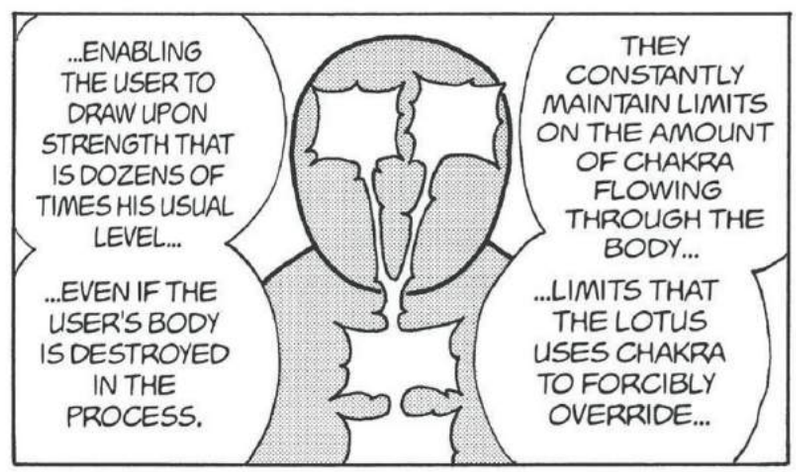
...!
...SPECIAL...
YIPE!
Y-YES, SIR!
I'VE GOT TO START BY WARNING YOU THAT THIS MOVE IS EVEN MORE FORBIDDEN THAN THE LOTUS...
...AND IT WILL BECOME A VERY SPECIAL MOVE IN YOUR ARSENAL.
BUT... PAY CLOSE ATTENTION... YOU CAN ONLY EVER USE IT ON ONE CONDITION...
AND THAT CONDITION IS...
SHHF

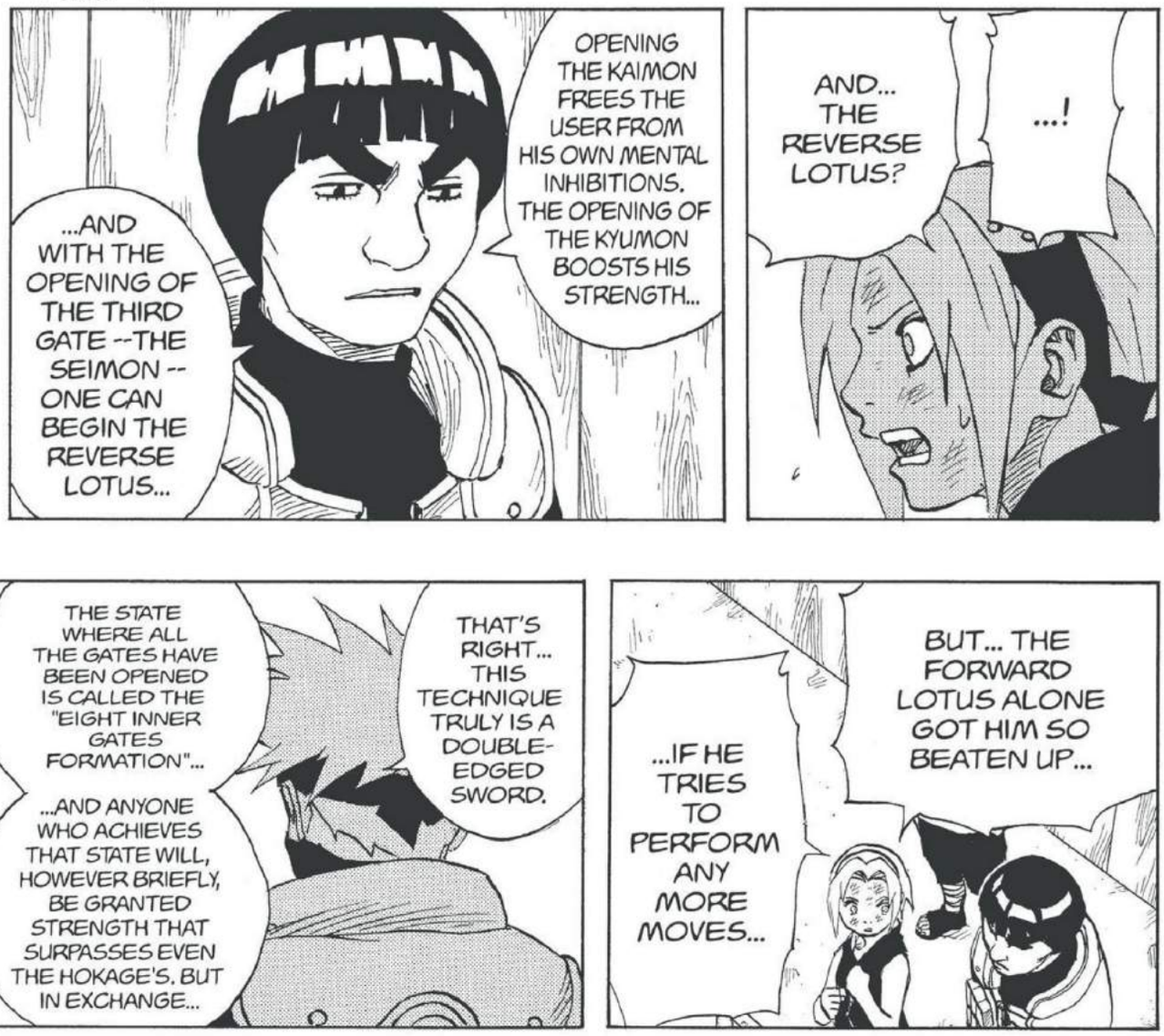
!!!
SO TELL ME, GUY... WHICH OF THE EIGHT INNER GATES HAS HE GOTTEN UP TO SO FAR?
SO HE WAS ABLE TO BOUNCE BACK FROM EXHAUSTION WITH SUCH ABNORMAL SPEED BECAUSE HE'D FORCED OPEN THE KYUMON -- THE GATE OF REST.
THE FIFTH GATE.
WH... WHAT ARE YOU BOTH TALKING ABOUT?!
YOU KEEP MENTION-ING THESE... INNER GATES?
SO... THE BOY'S A GENIUS AFTER ALL.
THAT FEAT SHOULD BE IMPOSSIBLE TO ACHIEVE THROUGH HARD WORK ALONE...
?!
LIMITERS... RELEASED?
THE GATES ACT AS LIMITERS THAT MUST BE RELEASED IN PREPARATION FOR PERFORMING THE REVERSE LOTUS.


YES...
PEEK


AT EIGHT SPECIFIC POINTS ALONG THE KEIRAKUKEI -- THE NETWORK OF ENERGY LINES THROUGH WHICH CHAKRA FLOWS...
...THERE ARE PLACES WHERE THE CHAKRA NODES CONVERGE:
KAIMON -- GATE OF OPENING
KYUMON -- GATE OF REST
SEIMON -- GATE OF LIFE
SHOMON -- GATE OF PAIN
TOMON -- GATE OF CLOSING
KEIMON -- GATE OF JOY
KYOMON -- GATE OF SHOCK
SHIMON -- GATE OF DEATH
THOSE ARE CALLED THE EIGHT INNER GATES...
KAIMON
KYUMON
SEIMON
SHOMON
TOMON
KEIMON
KYOMON
SHIMON
1
2
3
4
5
6
7
8

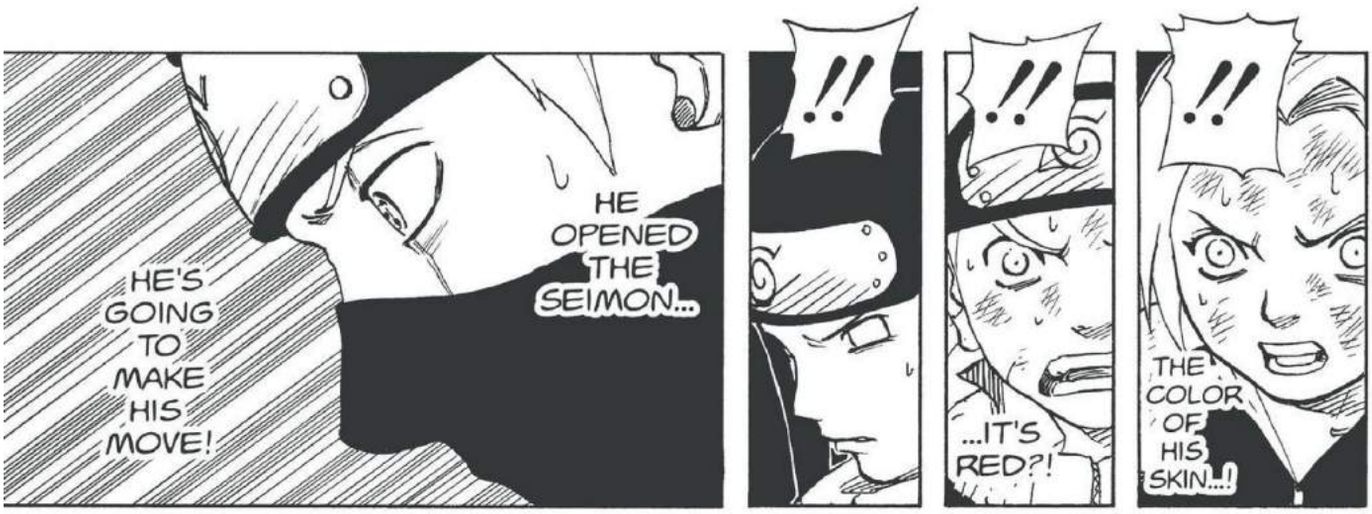
INCIDENTALLY, THE FORWARD LOTUS OPENS ONLY THE FIRST GATE -- KAIMON.


...ENABLING THE USER TO DRAW UPON STRENGTH THAT IS DOZENS OF TIMES HIS USUAL LEVEL...
...EVEN IF THE USER'S BODY IS DESTROYED IN THE PROCESS.
THEY CONSTANTLY MAINTAIN LIMITS ON THE AMOUNT OF CHAKRA FLOWING THROUGH THE BODY...
...LIMITS THAT THE LOTUS USES CHAKRA TO FORCIBLY OVERRIDE...


OPENING THE KAIMON FREES THE USER FROM HIS OWN MENTAL INHIBITIONS. THE OPENING OF THE KYUMON BOOSTS HIS STRENGTH...
...AND WITH THE OPENING OF THE THIRD GATE --THE SEIMON -- ONE CAN BEGIN THE REVERSE LOTUS...
...!
AND... THE REVERSE LOTUS?
THAT'S RIGHT... THIS TECHNIQUE TRULY IS A DOUBLE-EDGED SWORD.
THE STATE WHERE ALL THE GATES HAVE BEEN OPENED IS CALLED THE "EIGHT INNER GATES FORMATION"...
...AND ANYONE WHO ACHIEVES THAT STATE WILL, HOWEVER BRIEFLY, BE GRANTED STRENGTH THAT SURPASSES EVEN THE HOKAGE'S. BUT IN EXCHANGE...
BUT... THE FORWARD LOTUS ALONE GOT HIM SO BEATEN UP...
...IF HE TRIES TO PERFORM ANY MORE MOVES...
!!
...THAT PERSON WILL INEVITABLY DIE!

FLASH
!
愛
AND EVEN...
...SASUKE...
...NEJI...
...NOW, OF ALL TIMES...
MASTER GUY... PLEASE... NOTICE ME...
...THE ONLY ONE WHO FAILS!!
I WILL NOT BE...

...NOW, WHEN I FINALLY ATTAIN...
...MY SHINOBI PATH!!!
THE THIRD GATE, SEIMON... RELEASE!!

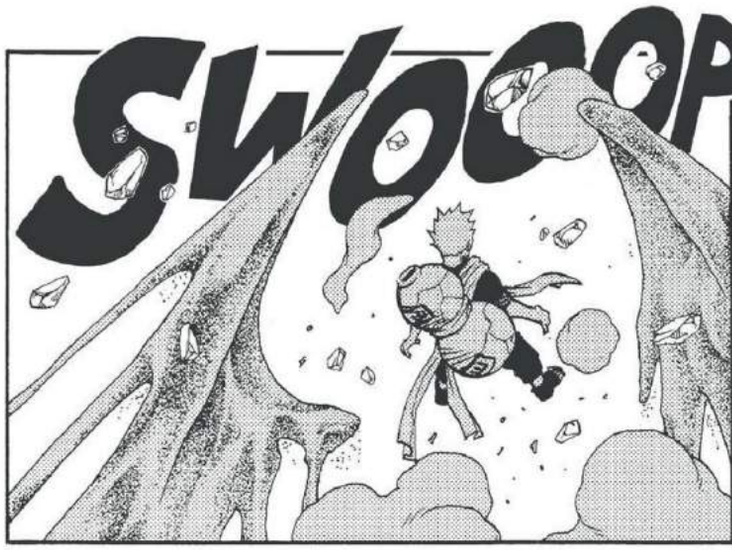

HE'S GOING TO MAKE HIS MOVE!
HE OPENED THE SEIMON...
!!
!!
...IT'S RED?!
!!
THE COLOR OF HIS SKIN...!

KYAAAH!!!
AND, WHILE I'M AT IT... THE FOURTH GATE, SHOMON... RELEASE!!!
HE'S QUITE SOMETHING...
...
DRIP
TAK
!!

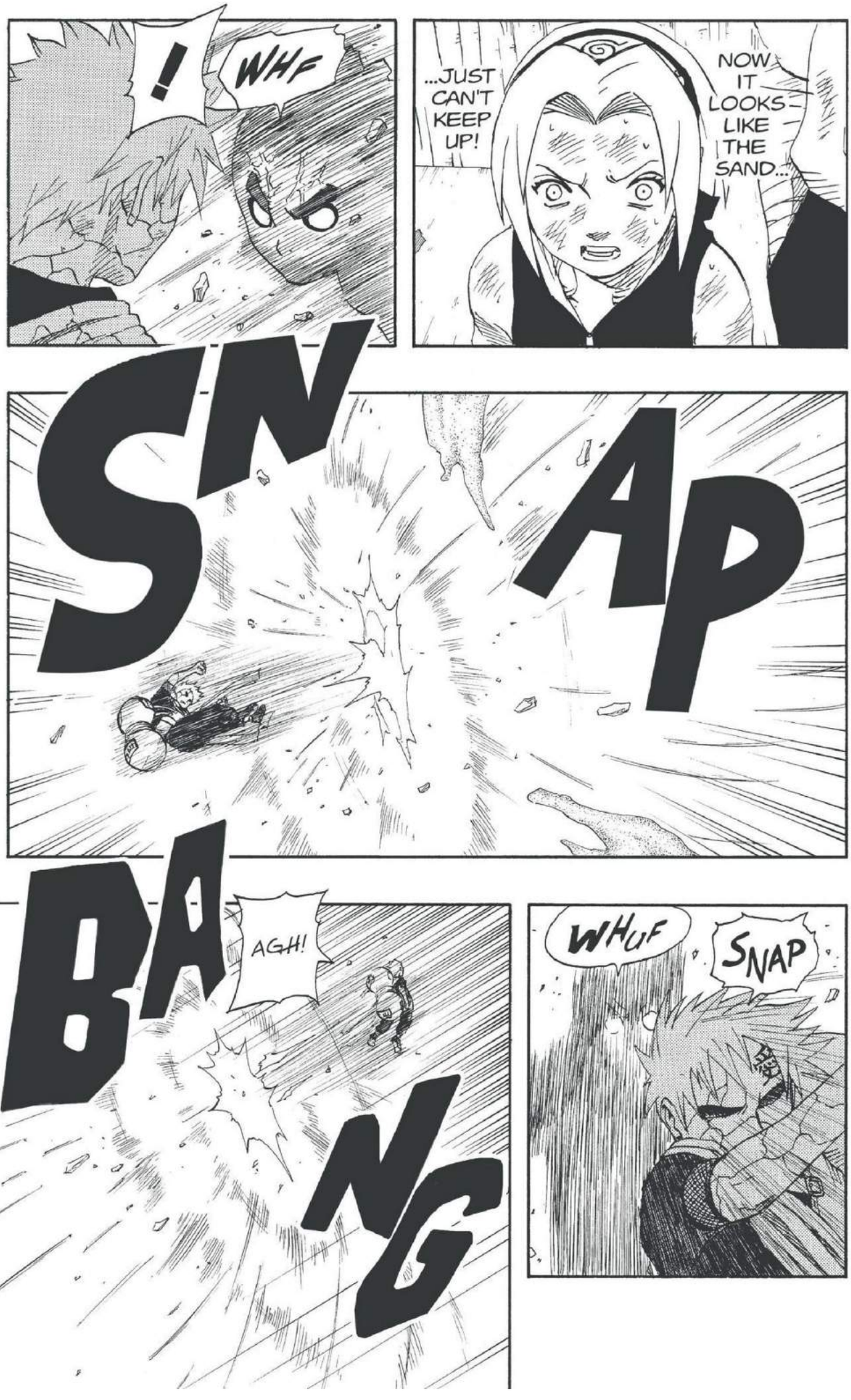
RUMBLE
SLAM
SMA
!!
SH
HE'S FAST!!
CRAK
CRAK
OW!
YAAH!

WHERE DID HE GO?!
GAARA?!

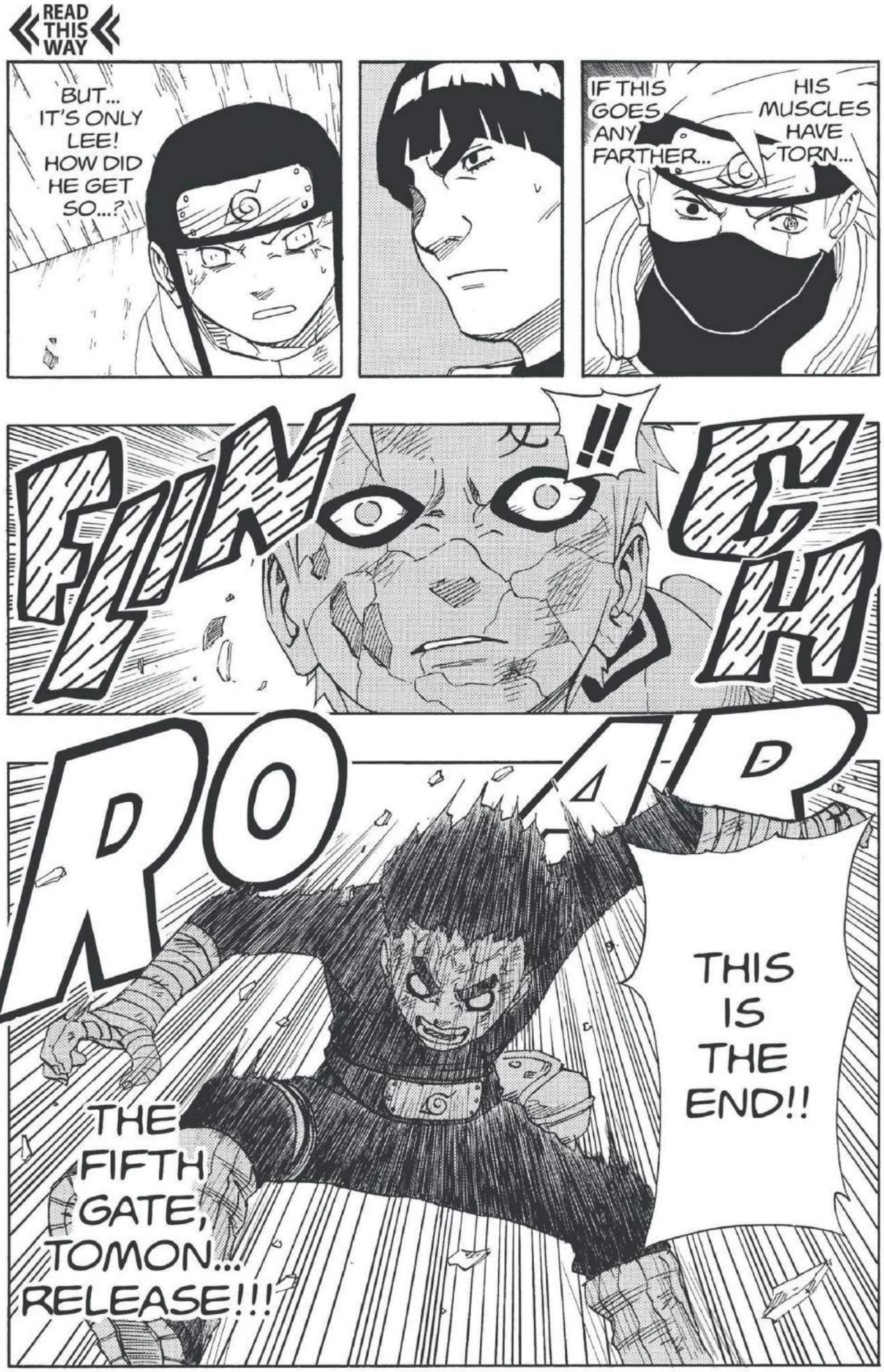
LOOK UP!
BUT WHAT ABOUT LEE?! I DON'T SEE HIM ANYWHERE!


SWOOP

愛
CRUMBLE


!
WHF
...JUST CAN'T KEEP UP!
NOW IT LOOKS LIKE THE SAND...
SNAP
BANG
AGH!
WHUF
SNAP

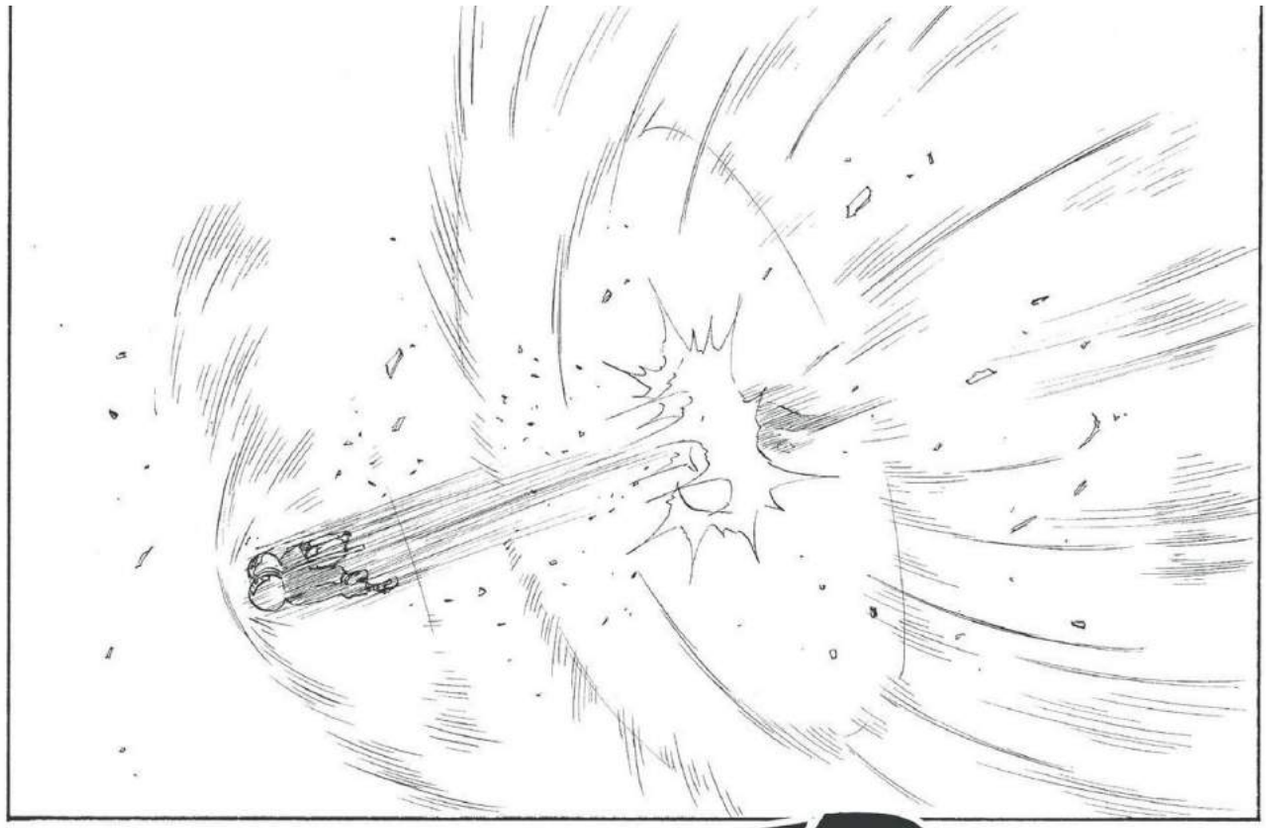
POW POW POW
WHAK
THE SAND ARMOR AGAIN, EH?
WHAT?! MY SAND ARMOR IS...
...PEELING OFF?!
TKSH
TWANG
TWANG
CLENCH
AT THIS RATE...


READ THIS WAY
BUT... IT'S ONLY LEE! HOW DID HE GET SO...?
IF THIS GOES ANY FARTHER...
HIS MUSCLES HAVE TORN...
GUOH!!
ROAR
THIS IS THE END!!
THE FIFTH GATE, TOMON... RELEASE!!!

THE WORLD OF KISHIMOTO MASASHI
MY PERSONAL HISTORY, PART 12

IN MIDDLE SCHOOL, I WAS SO FOCUSED ON BASEBALL THAT I ALMOST STOPPED DRAWING COMPLETELY.
THERE WERE GAMES EVERY SATURDAY AND SUNDAY, AND PRACTICE EVERY WEEKDAY MORNING. EVEN MY AFTER-SCHOOL TIME WAS FILLED WITH HOURS OF CRAM SCHOOL, SO I WAS ALWAYS INCREDIBLY BUSY. IT WAS LIKE ANOTHER WORLD COMPARED TO ELEMENTARY SCHOOL, AND ALL OF THE TIME I HAD ONCE SPENT DRAWING WAS GONE.
ONE DAY, JUST WHEN I WAS STARTING TO THINK, "MAYBE I'VE OUTGROWN THE URGE TO BE DRAWING ALL THE TIME," I HAD A SUDDEN AND INCREDIBLE REVELATION. IT WAS SO AMAZING THAT I STILL LOOK BACK ON THAT MOMENT AS A HUGE TURNING POINT.
THE AMAZING MOMENT OCCURRED WHEN I SAW A MOVIE POSTER.
I WAS ON MY WAY HOME ONE DAY WHEN I HAPPENED TO GLANCE AT A POSTER FOR OTOMO KATSUHIRO'S *AKIRA*.
IN AN INSTANT, THE SIGHT OF IT HAD AN IMPACT ON ME SO POWERFUL THAT EVEN NOW IT'S HARD TO DESCRIBE. I STOOD STARING AT IT FOR OVER AN HOUR. THE POSTER FEATURED AN OVERHEAD SHOT OF THE MAIN CHARACTER, KANEDA, WALKING TOWARDS A MOTORCYCLE. THE COMPOSITION OF IT WAS INCREDIBLY COMPLEX. "HOW DID THIS GUY DRAW ANYTHING SO COMPLICATED THAT WELL?" "I'VE NEVER KNOWN ANYONE WHO COULD HAVE MADE THAT COMPOSITION WORK..."
DESPITE THE TRICKY ANGLES OF THE PERSPECTIVE, THE BIKE AND KANEDA WERE BOTH DRAWN PERFECTLY, WITH ALL THE SPATIAL RELATIONSHIPS CORRECT. THE SENSE THAT KANEDA WAS ACTUALLY STANDING SOLIDLY ON THE GROUND WAS CONVEYED IN A WAY THAT SEEMED TOTALLY REAL AND COOL. THE BIKE HAD AN AMAZING DESIGN, AND THERE WERE CRACKS IN THE GROUND AND PEBBLES SCATTERED ABOUT, SEEMINGLY AT RANDOM. THAT POSTER SEEMED LIKE THE COOLEST, MOST ORIGINAL THING I HAD EVER SEEN AND IT REKINDLED THE FLAME OF MY ARTISTIC PASSION. EVER SINCE THAT DAY, I'VE KEPT DRAWING WITH THE HOPE THAT SOMEDAY I CAN APPROACH THE STANDARD SET BY THAT PICTURE.

Number 86: A Splendid Ninja...!! zzz



!!

KRAK
SWF

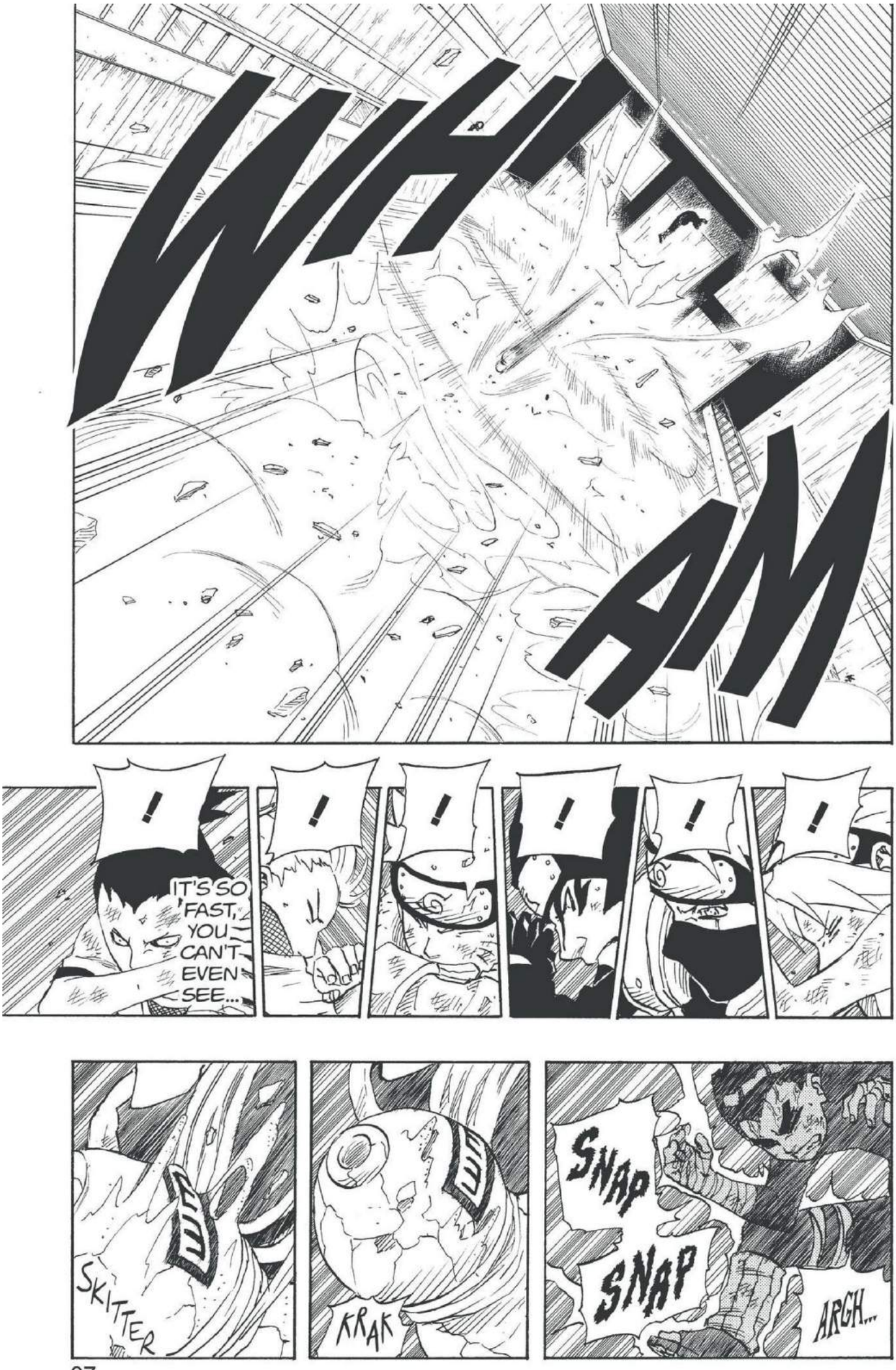
SSSSS
SSSS

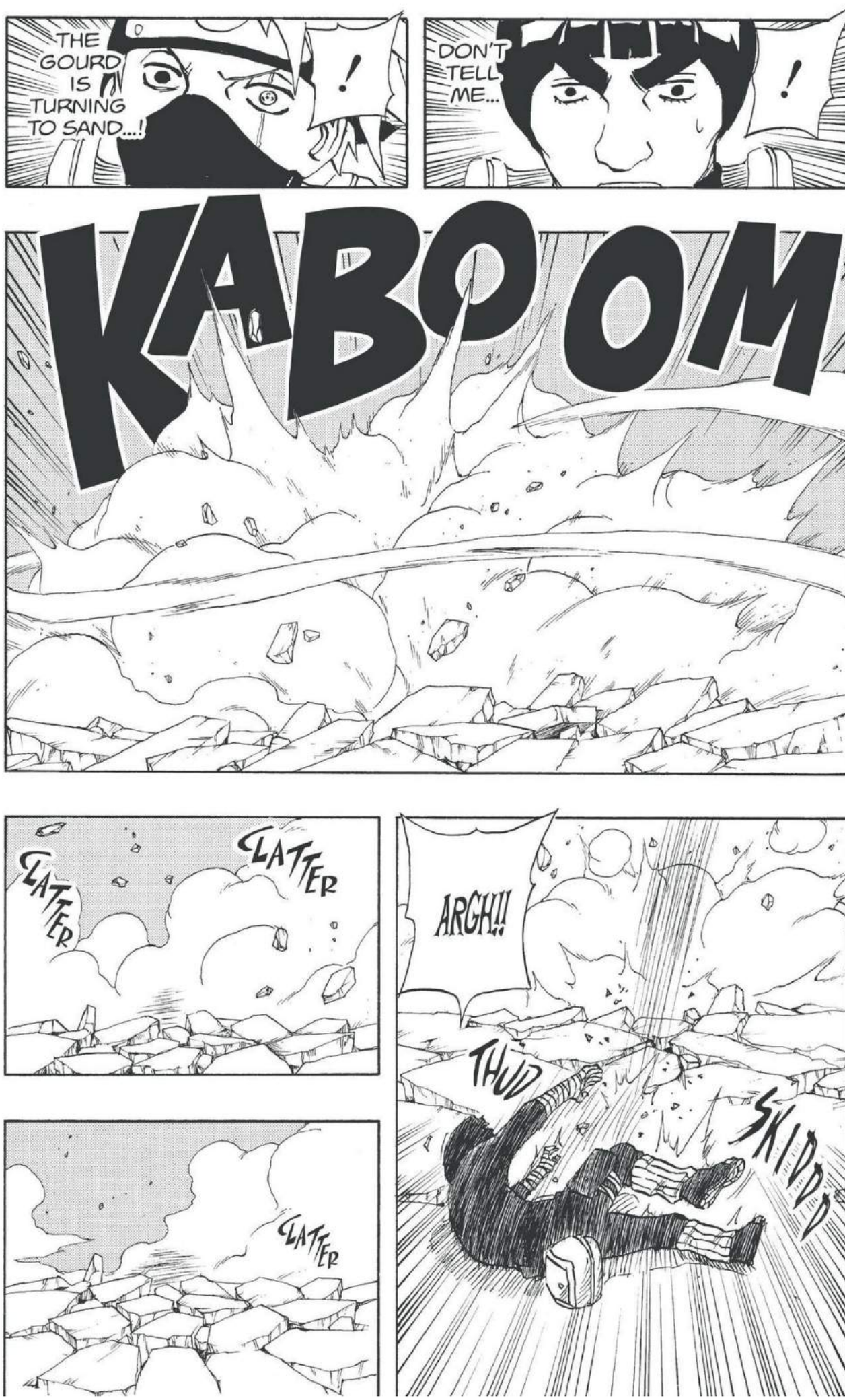
CLE
NCH

...
THIS IS THE FINALE!
GRIP!
THESE RAPID MOVES ARE LEE'S KEY TO WINNING THE MATCH...
THE REVERSE LOTUS... A SERIES OF TAIJUTSU PERFORMED WITH SUCH SPEED THAT THE ATTACKER IS UNTOUCHABLE!
THERE'S NO WAY THE SAND CAN CATCH UP...!
MUCH OF THE SAND ARMOR HAS BEEN TORN AWAY...!!
THE SAND SHIELD CAN'T KEEP UP...
THIS IS NOT GOOD...!!
FWOOM
HYAH!!
YAN
K
!!

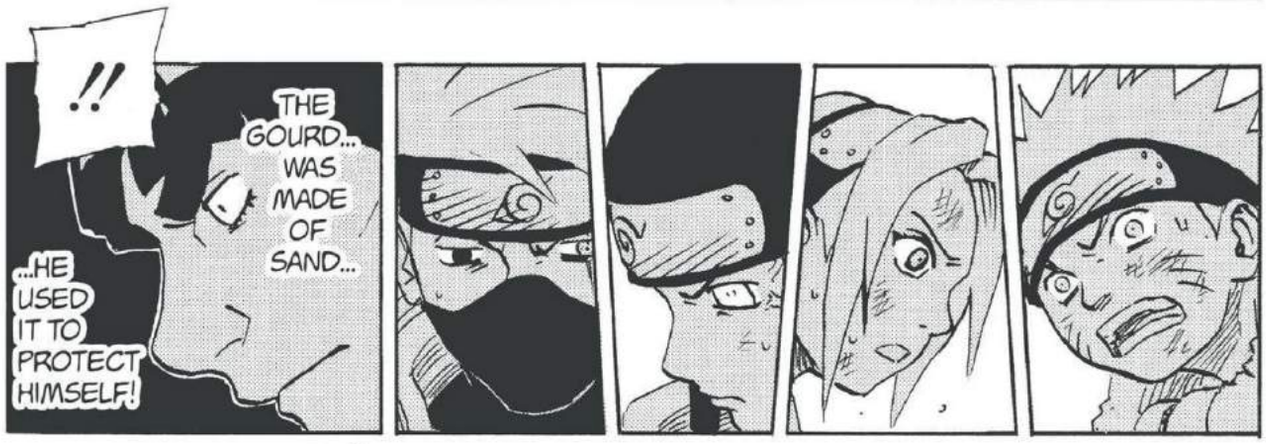
Number 86:

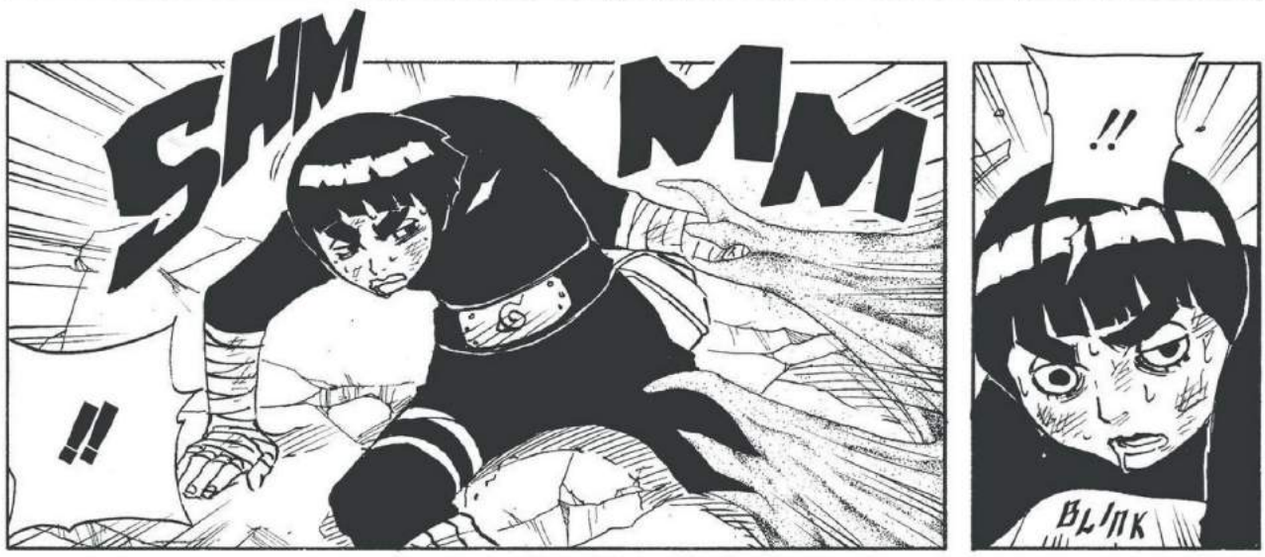
A Splendid Ninja...!!

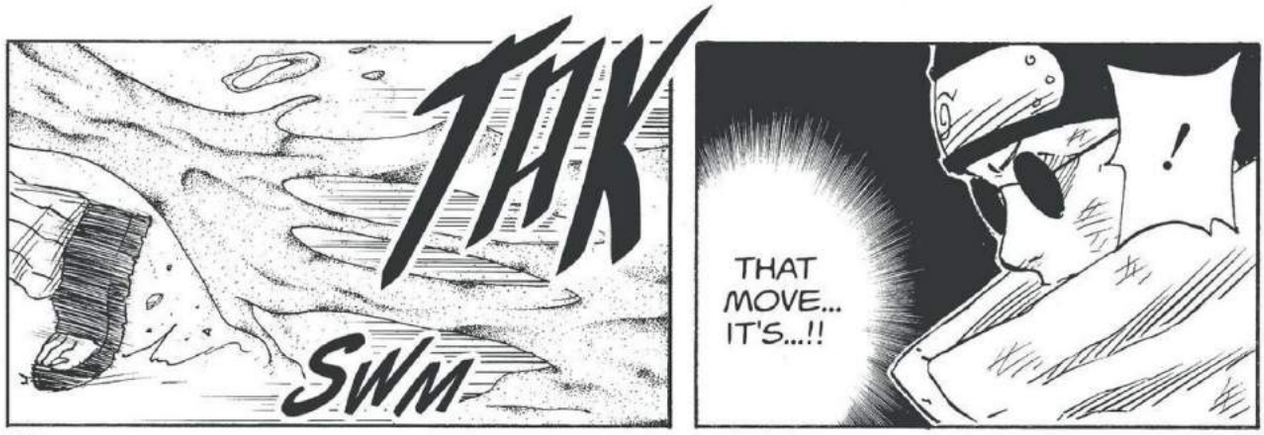

WHIT
AM
!
!
!
!
!
!
IT'S SO FAST, YOU CAN'T EVEN SEE...
SKITTER
KRAK
SNAP
SNAP
ARGH...


THE GOURD IS TURNING TO SAND...!
!
DON'T TELL ME...
!
KABOOM
CLATTER
CLATTER
ARGH!!
THUD
SKIDD
CLATTER

TWITCH
HUF
HUF
SHF

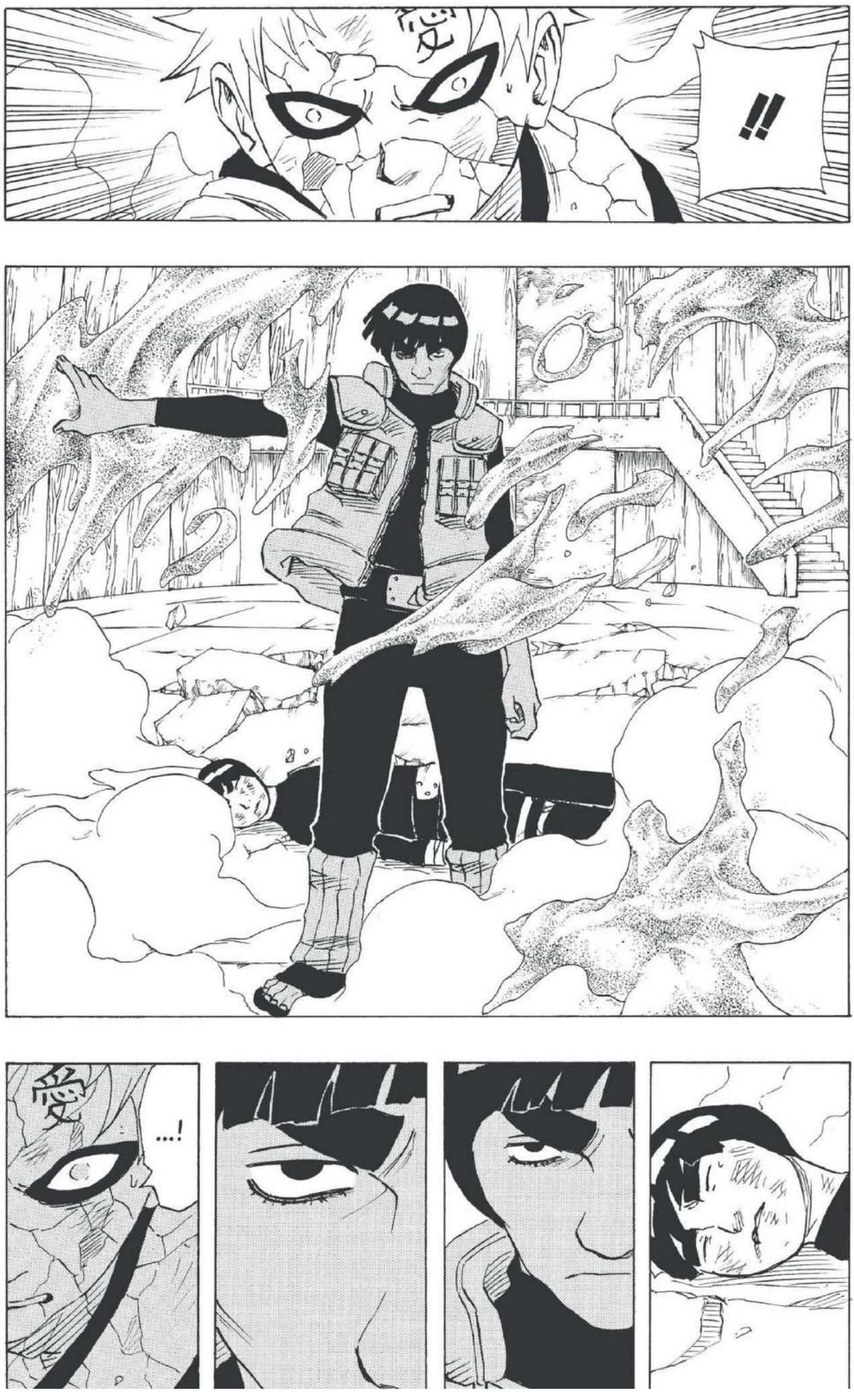

!!
THE GOURD... WAS MADE OF SAND...
...HE USED IT TO PROTECT HIMSELF!


SHM
MM
!!
!!
BLINK

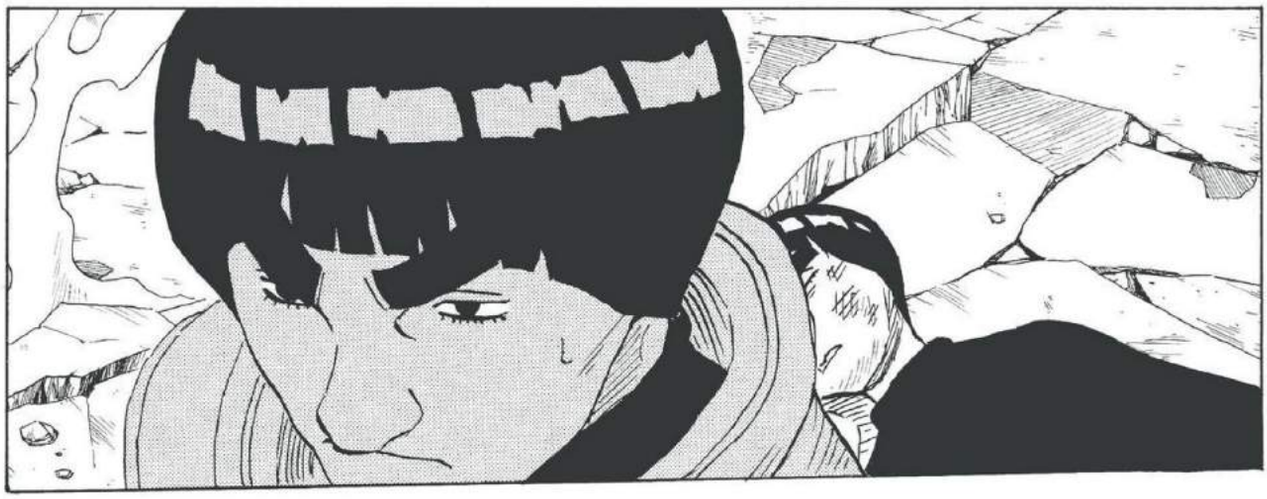

THAK
SWM
THAT MOVE... IT'S...!!
!

CLENCH
SABAKUKYÛ! THE COFFIN OF CRUSHING SAND!!
!!
!!
!
!
!
BLINK
AAGH!!
SNAP
SNAP

READ THIS WAY
SSSHMM
...!
HUF
HUF
HUF
...!
FWASH


!!
愛
…!

TWIK
CHK
OB
UNH...
...HELPING HIM?
WHY ARE YOU...

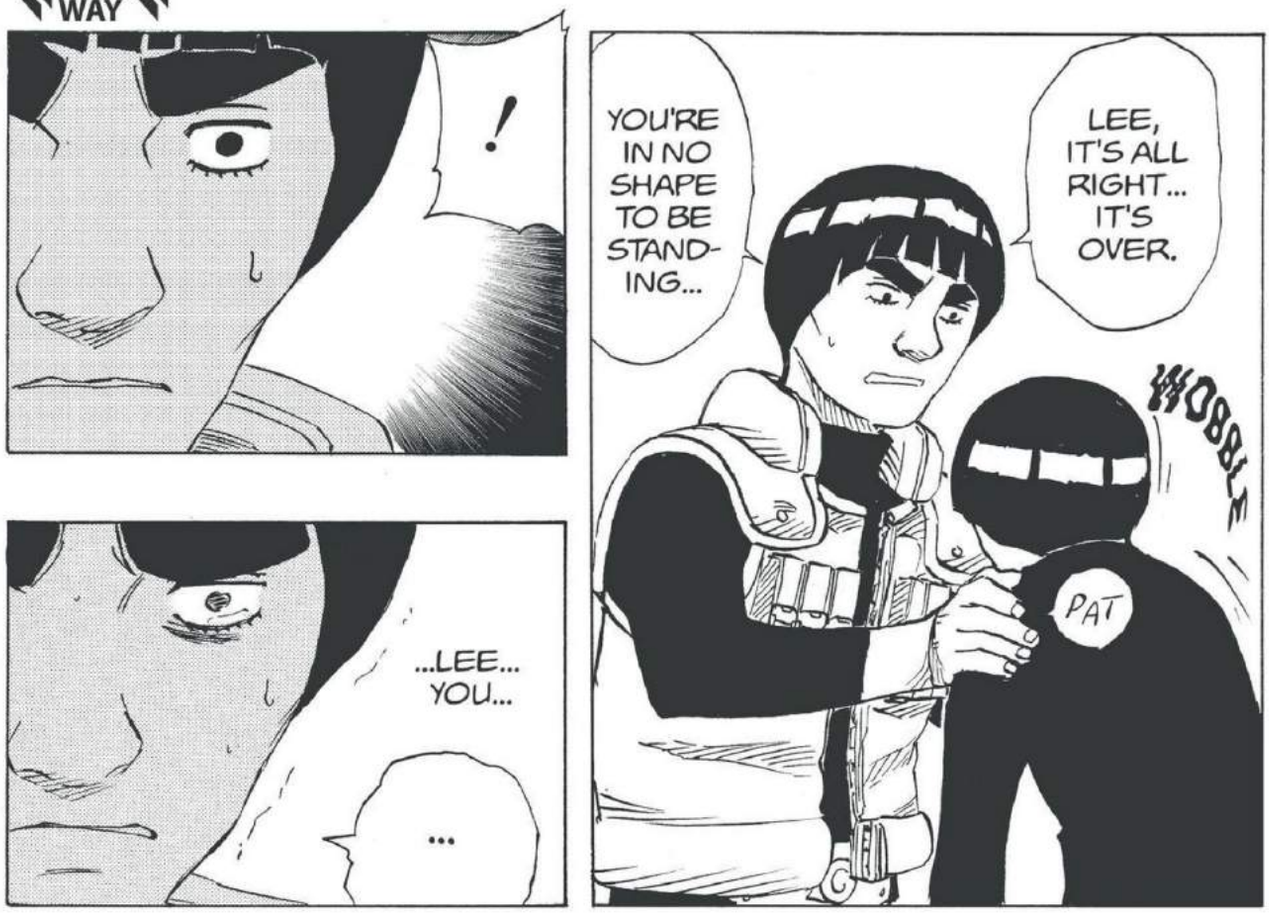


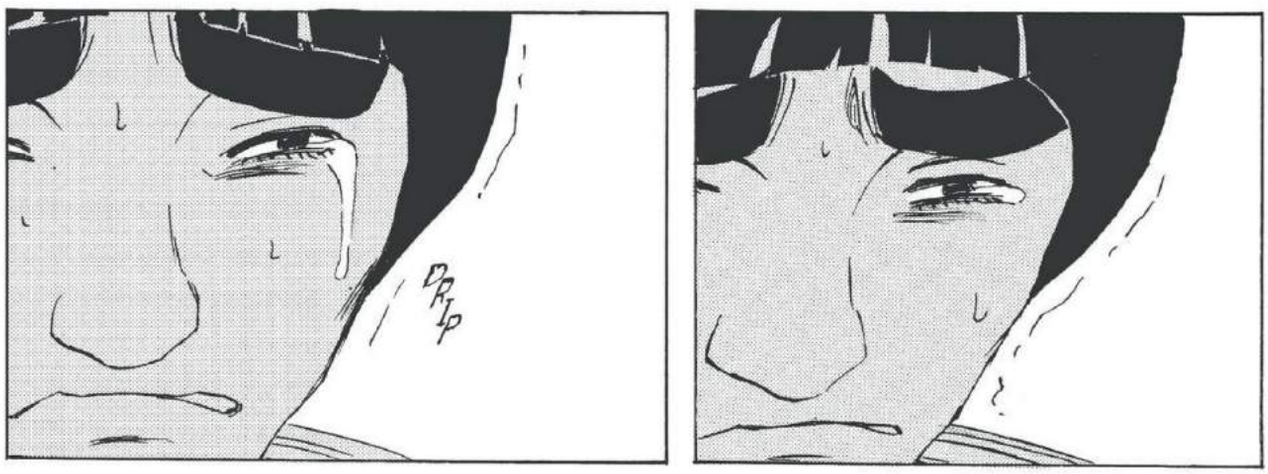
WHOP WHAK
MASTER GUY, I'LL EXCEL IN THE CHÛNIN EXAM... YOU CAN SIT BACK AND ENJOY THE SHOW!
SIZZLE
SIZZ
HEH HEH... I'M ALL RIGHT...
...'CAUSE I'M SO STRONG!

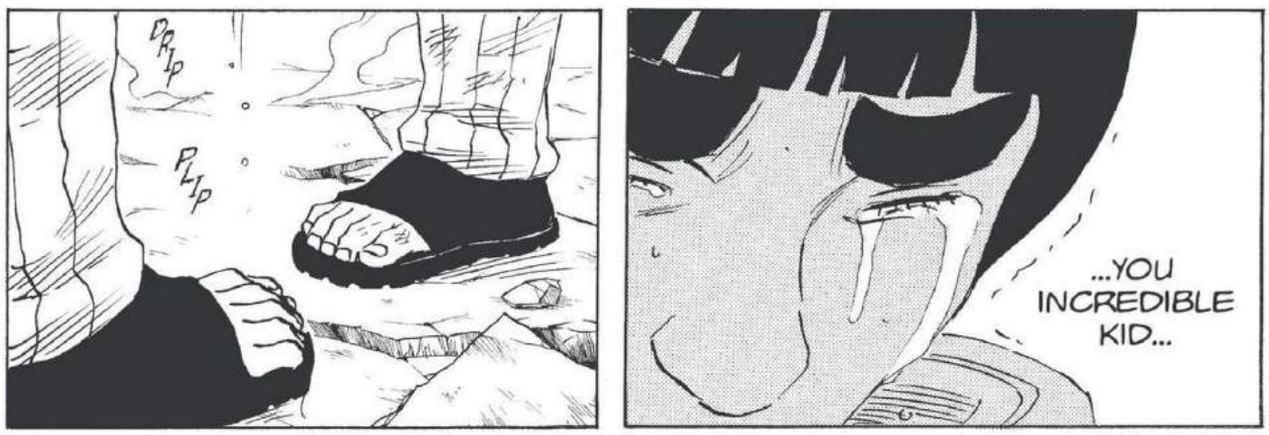
HE'S...
...CAN STILL BECOME A SPLENDID NINJA! IT'S MY ONLY GOAL!!
I WANT TO PROVE THAT EVEN A PERSON WHO CAN'T USE NINJUTSU OR GENJUTSU...

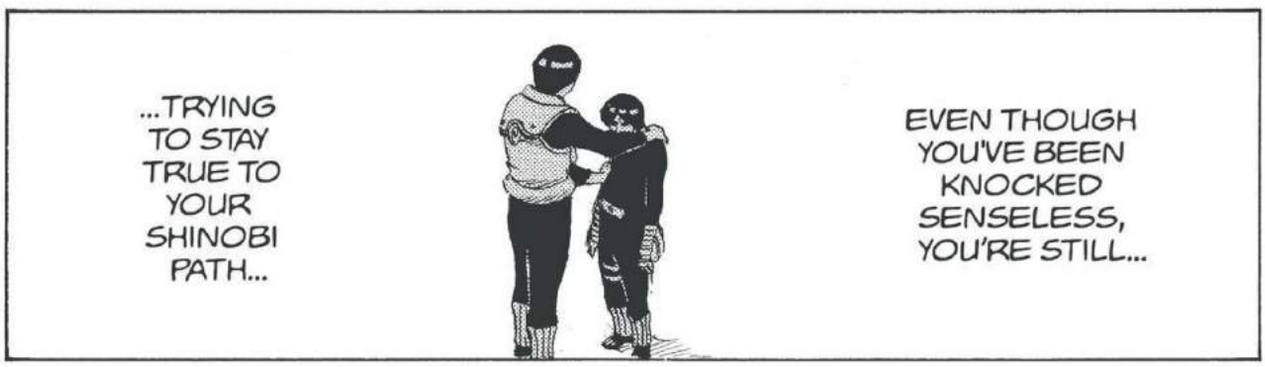
READ THIS WAY
HE'S MY LOVABLE, PRECIOUS PROTÉGÉ!
...THOSE WORDS ARE BEYOND THE SCOPE OF GAARA'S UNDER-STANDING...
TWIST
SHMM
SSS
THE VICTOR IS GAARA!
SHM
SSS
SHM
FORGET IT...

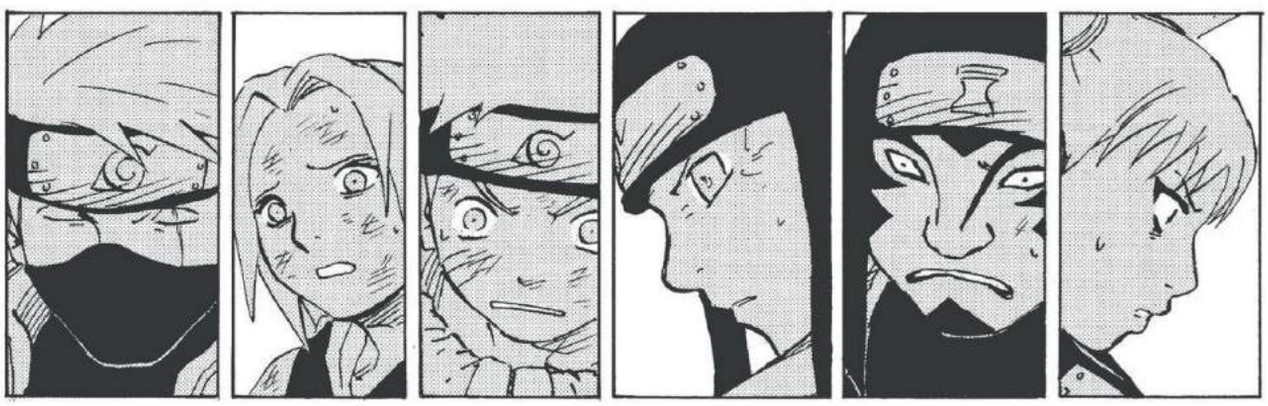
HUH?!
...!
!
I CAN'T BELIEVE IT...
HOW CAN HE STILL STAND?!
HE OPENED FIVE GATES... HIS ARM AND LEG WERE CRUSHED...
KREAK
KREAK
TREMBLE
KRK
POP


!
...LEE... YOU...
...
YOU'RE IN NO SHAPE TO BE STAND-ING...
LEE, IT'S ALL RIGHT... IT'S OVER.
WOBBLE
PAT


DRIP

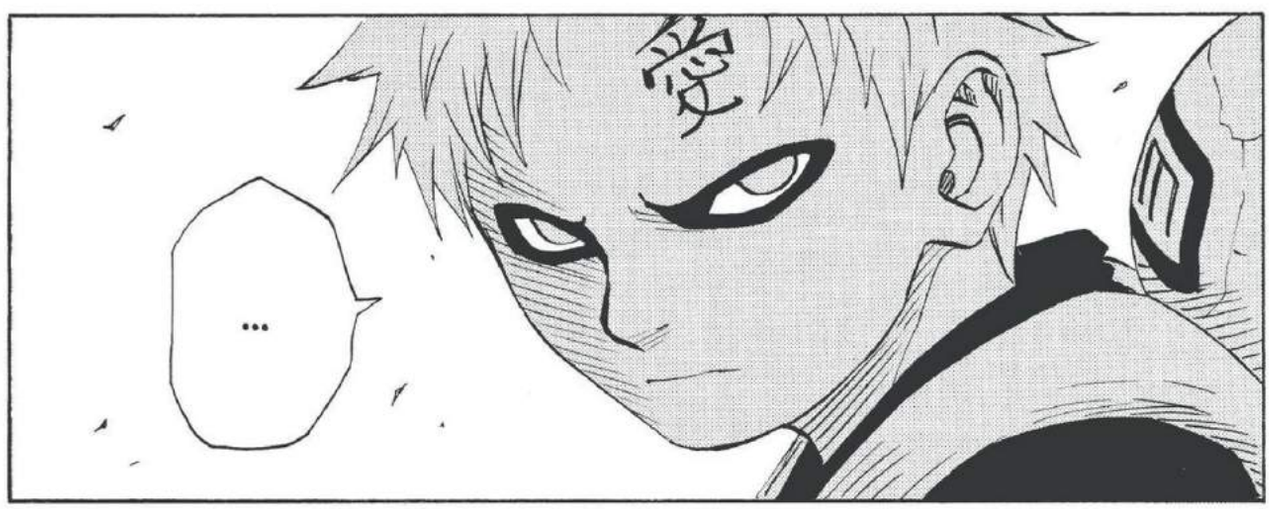

DRIP
PLIP
...YOU INCREDIBLE KID...


...TRYING TO STAY TRUE TO YOUR SHINOBI PATH...
EVEN THOUGH YOU'VE BEEN KNOCKED SENSELESS, YOU'RE STILL...



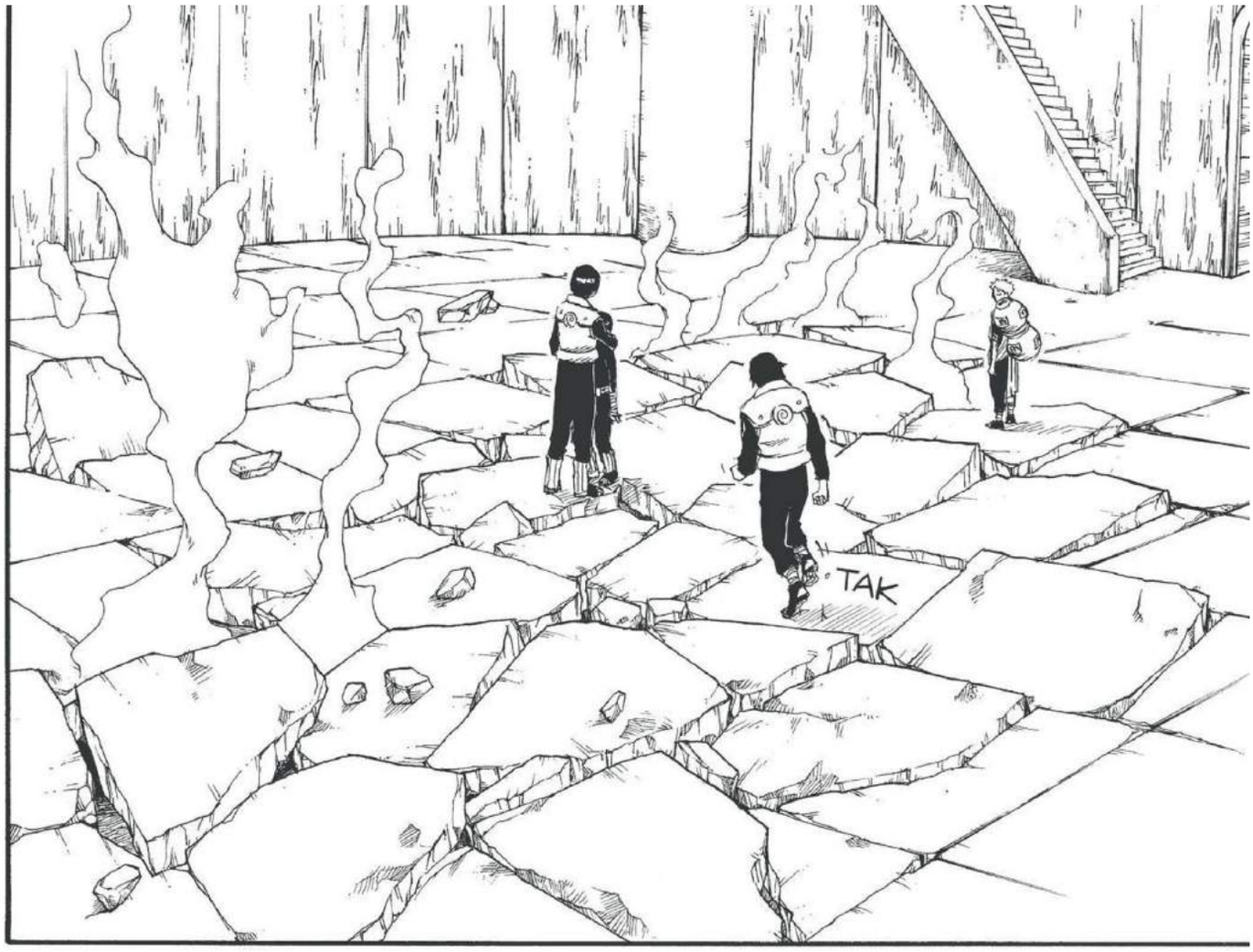
YOU ARE AL-READY ...
LEE...

...A SPLENDID NINJA...!
SQUEEZE...


...

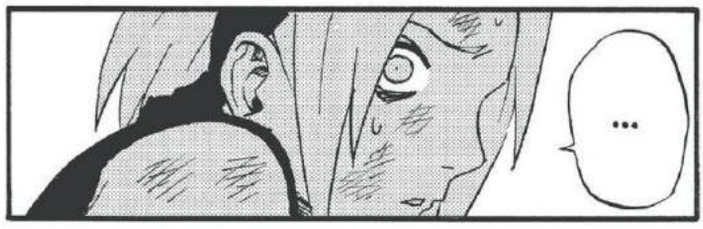
• THIS CHARACTER IS FROM AN UNPUBLISHED WORK I DID PRIOR TO NARUTO.

Number 87: The Preliminaries... Completed!!


TAK

!
SAKURA!
TUP

LEE...!
SKF


...

HOW DO YOU INTEND TO HELP HIM?
YOUR PRESENCE WILL ONLY CAUSE HIM PAIN...

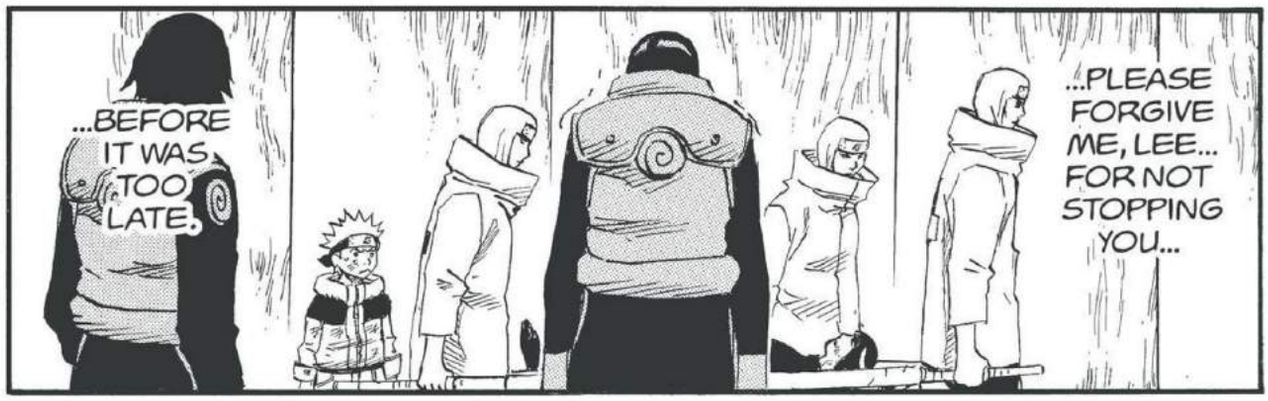
READ THIS WAY
HOP
!
HMPH! HE NEVER HAD A CHANCE AGAINST GAARA...
SHF
NARUTO...
HOW COULD BUSHY BROWS LOSE TO SUCH A JERK?!
TAK
EMERGENCY UNIT, PLEASE HURRY!!
TAK TAK

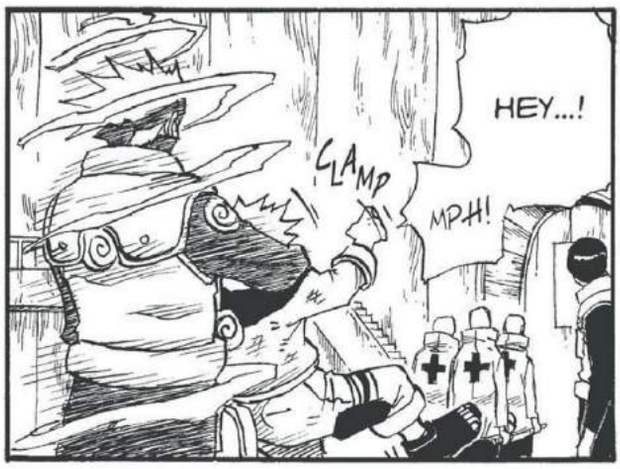
E... EXCUSE US!
...
!
ARE YOU THE JÔNIN RESPONSIBLE FOR HIM? IF I MAY HAVE A WORD...
!

I DON'T WANT TO SAY THIS, BUT...
...
IF THAT WERE THE FULL EXTENT OF HIS INJURIES, WE COULD STILL EXPECT A FULL RECOVERY, BUT...
...THOUGH HE'S BREATHING ON HIS OWN, HE HAS COMPOUND COMPRESSIVE FRACTURES AND TORN MUSCLES THROUGHOUT HIS BODY.
...THE DAMAGE TO HIS ATTACKED LEFT ARM AND LEG IS ESPECIALLY SEVERE.
...HE'LL NEVER RECOVER ENOUGH TO BE A SHINOBI AGAIN.
THIS KID'S BODY IS SO DESTROYED...
!!

I WANTED TO HELP YOU ACHIEVE YOUR SHINOBI PATH...
...LEE... I NEVER LET MYSELF THINK THAT YOU COULD LOSE...

YOU MUST BE KIDDING...
N... NO WAY...

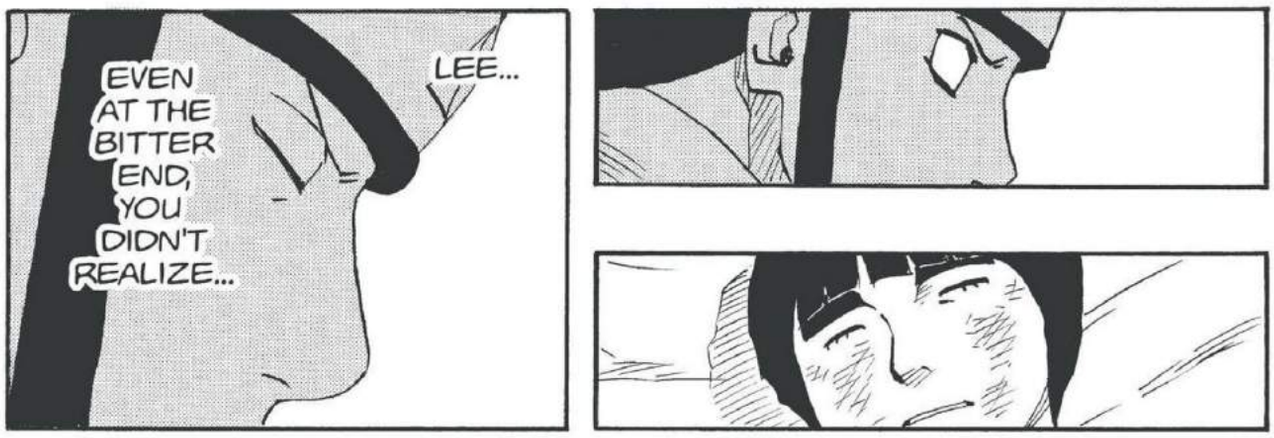

...BEFORE IT WAS TOO LATE.
...PLEASE FORGIVE ME, LEE... FOR NOT STOPPING YOU...

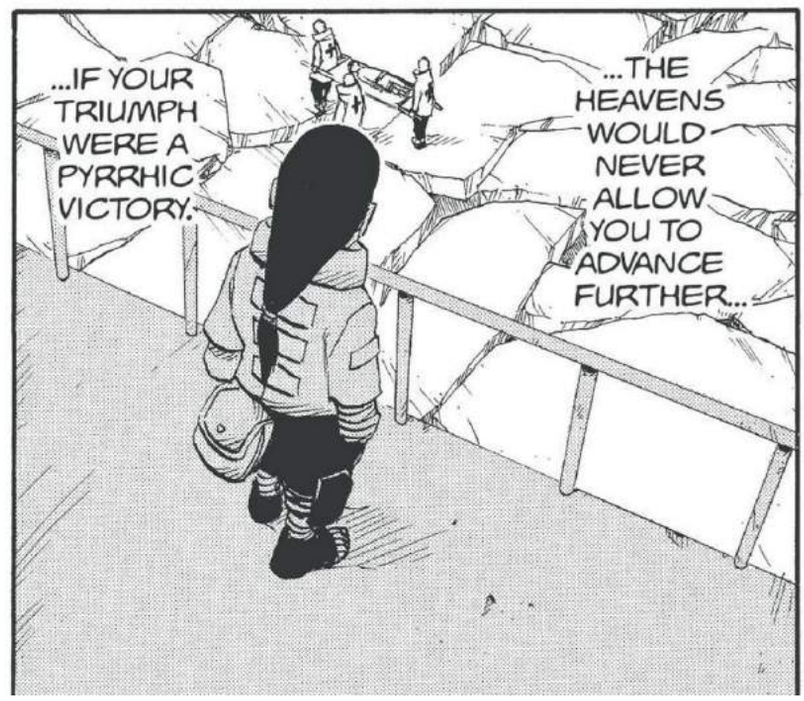

HEY...!
CLAMP
MPH!

HE KEPT SAYING HE WAS DESPERATE TO FIGHT SASUKE AND THAT NEJI GUY...
WHAT IS BUSHY BROWS SUPPOSED TO DO?!
WELL...
CAN'T YOU DO ANY-THING TO HELP HIM?!

IT WAS HIS OWN CHOICE TO USE A FORBIDDEN, SELF-SACRIFICING ART...
...IN A LAST-DITCH EFFORT TO WIN.
...THAT WAS HIS UN-DOING.
...BUT MAYBE...
...!
...THE UN-SPOKEN OATH...
HE SACRIFICED HIMSELF TO HONOR...
HE RISKED HIS LIFE...
...SO THAT HE MIGHT HAVE THE CHANCE TO FIGHT ALL OF YOU.
...
...THE OATH THAT EXISTS BETWEEN HIM AND SASUKE, NEJI... AND EVEN YOU, NARUTO...

...DON'T FORGET THAT.
...

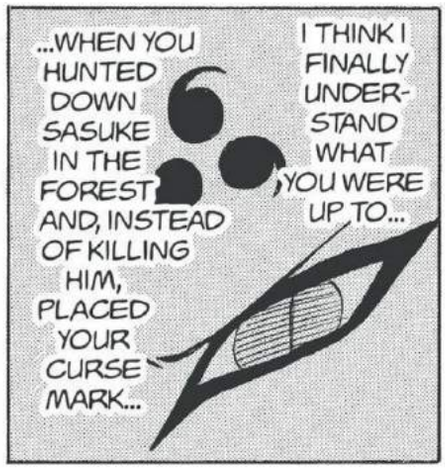

EVEN AT THE BITTER END, YOU DIDN'T REALIZE...
LEE...

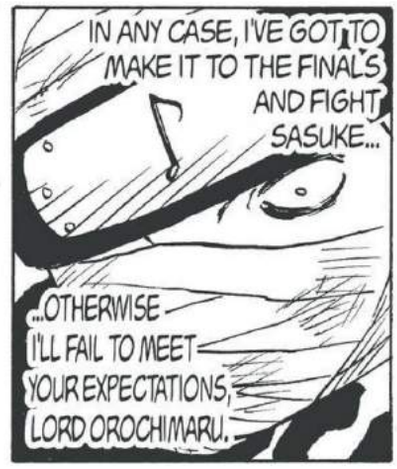

...IF YOUR TRIUMPH WERE A PYRRHIC VICTORY.
...THE HEAVENS WOULD NEVER ALLOW YOU TO ADVANCE FURTHER...

READ THIS WAY
...!
FWM
!
SWIRL
WELCOME BACK, GAARA...

...
GUY...
...I WAS PRETTY COCKY EARLIER, BUT... TO BE HONEST...
...IF I'D BEEN IN YOUR POSITION...
...I PROBABLY WOULDN'T HAVE BEEN ABLE TO STOP LEE EITHER.
!
GUY...
WE'RE IN THE WAY.
LET'S GO BACK UPSTAIRS...
...
YEAH...

BOTH CON-TESTANTS, PLEASE STEP FORWARD!
WELL... IT'S THE FINALE... THE 10TH ROUND BATTLE.


...WHEN YOU HUNTED DOWN SASUKE IN THE FOREST AND, INSTEAD OF KILLING HIM, PLACED YOUR CURSE MARK...
I THINK I FINALLY UNDER-STAND WHAT YOU WERE UP TO...


IN ANY CASE, I'VE GOT TO MAKE IT TO THE FINALS AND FIGHT SASUKE...
...OTHERWISE I'LL FAIL TO MEET YOUR EXPECTATIONS, LORD OROCHIMARU.

LOOKS LIKE I'M LAST...

...TO TEST HIS ABILITIES AND EXPERIENCE THEM FIRSTHAND. WHAT YOU WANT IS NOT SASUKE'S LIFE, BUT SASUKE HIMSELF...
THE THREE OF US SERVED AS YOUR GUINEA PIGS. YOU SENT US AFTER SASUKE WITH ASSASSINATION ORDERS... BUT REALLY YOU JUST INTENDED FOR US TO FIGHT HIM...

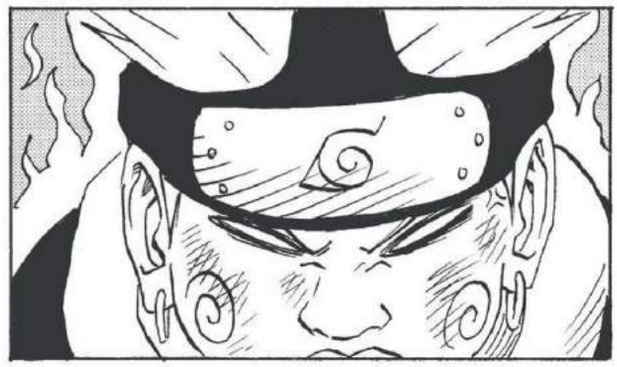
FWISH

YOU'VE BEEN TOYING WITH ME, TOO...
HOP

UH... WELL... LET THE 10TH ROUND BATTLE BEGIN!

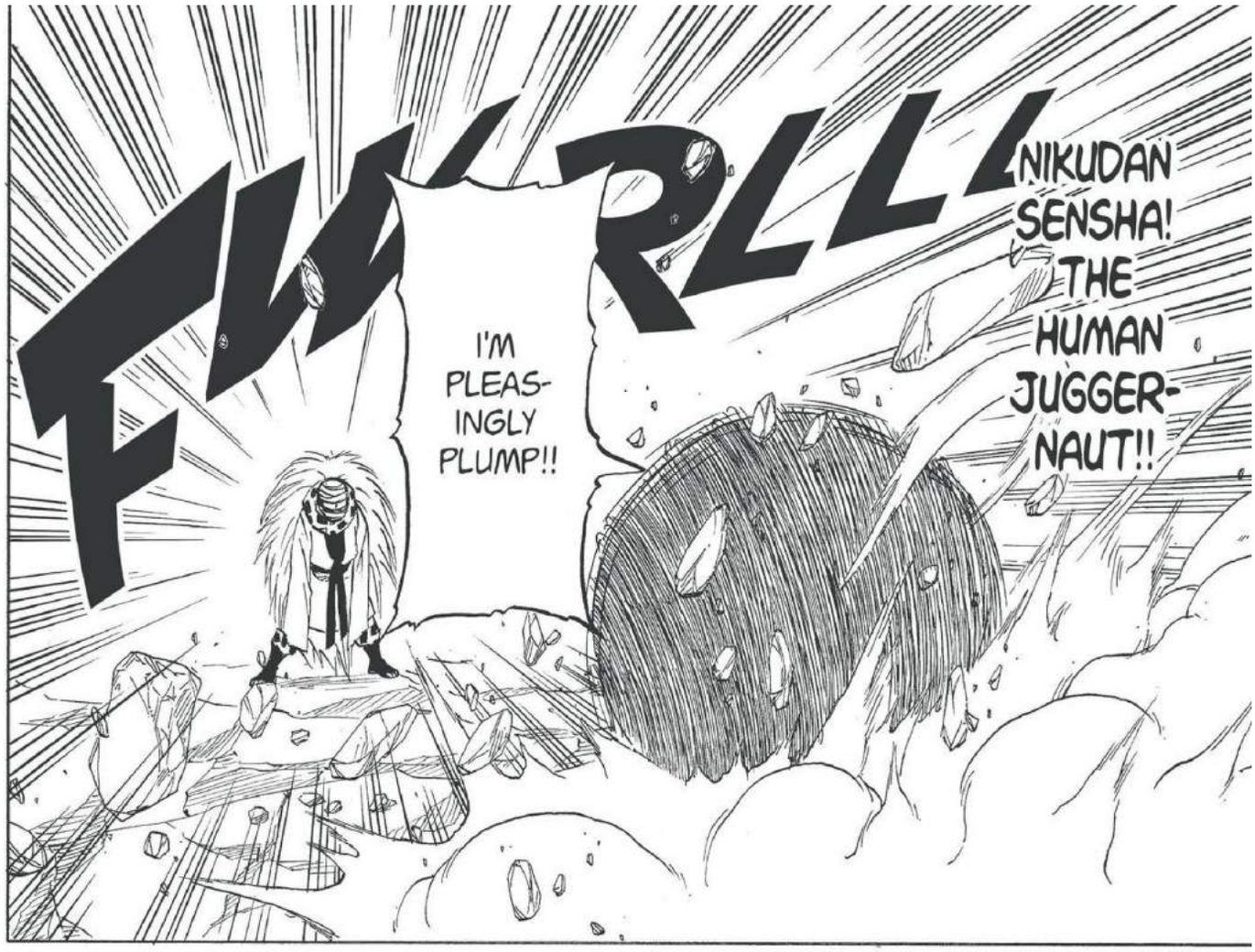
UGH...! SHUT YOUR MOUTH AND KEEP YOUR EYES OPEN!
I'M GONNA END THIS MATCH FAST SO I CAN COME BEAT YOU UP!

GO GET HIM!
YOU CAN DO IT, FATSO!!



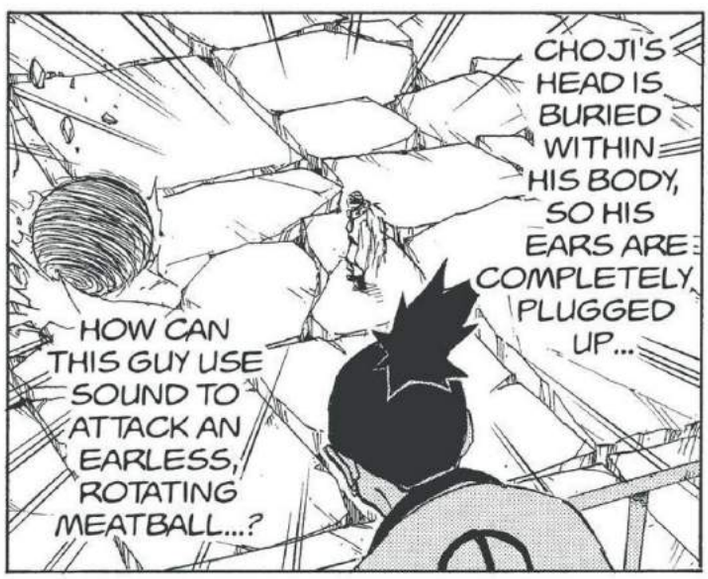
...WELL THEN...
...I'LL DISPENSE WITH THE GAMES AND QUICKLY FINISH IT FOR YOU, FATSO!

READ THIS WAY
NINJA TECHNIQUE: BAIKA NO JUTSU! THE ART OF EXPANSION!!
YOU MUMMIFIED, RAIN-PONCHO-WEARING CREEP...!
I FOUGHT YOU BEFORE, SO I ALREADY KNOW YOUR WEAKNESSES!
YOU RELEASE SOUND WAVES FROM THOSE HOLES IN YOUR ARM, SO...
POOF
SHWMP
AS LONG AS I PROTECT MY EARS...


FU'RLL
I'M PLEAS-INGLY PLUMP!!
NIKUDAN SENSHA! THE HUMAN JUGGER-NAUT!!

ALL RIGHT! CRUSH HIM, CHOJI!!

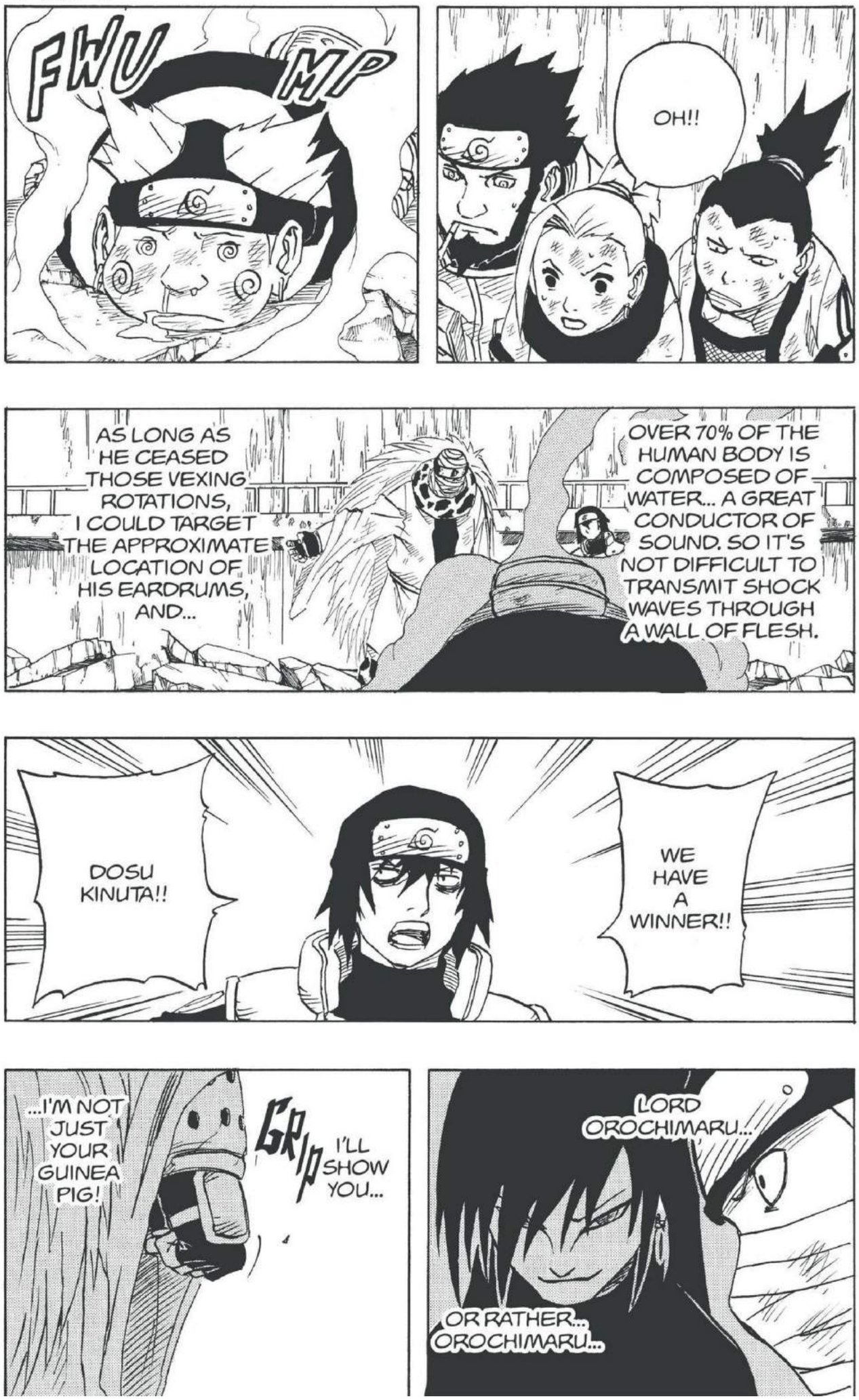
...


CHOJI'S HEAD IS BURIED WITHIN HIS BODY, SO HIS EARS ARE COMPLETELY PLUGGED UP...
HOW CAN THIS GUY USE SOUND TO ATTACK AN EARLESS, ROTATING MEATBALL...?

...THAT'S WHEN HIS ENEMY'S EARS ARE EXPOSED.
HE USES SOUND TO ATTACK WITHOUT EVER BEING IN DIRECT CONTACT WITH HIS OPPONENT, BUT...

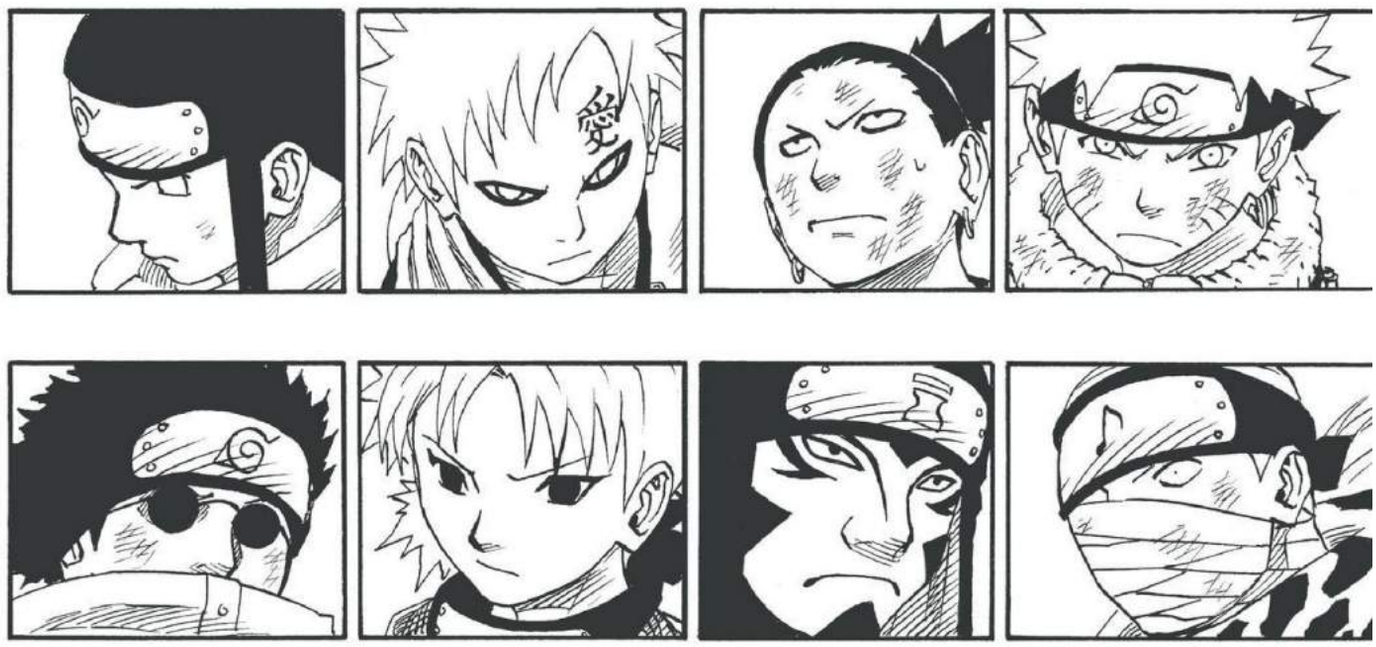
THUD
TAP
THUD
HOP HOP
WHAM
HOP
STAB
THERE'S MY TARGET!
...WHICH MEANS THAT, FOR A MOMENT, YOU'LL NEED TO STOP SPINNING ENTIRELY...
MISSED ME! AND NOW, TO GET FREE FROM THERE, YOU'RE GOING TO HAVE TO ROTATE THE OPPOSITE WAY...
KLAK
KLAK
!
!
TAP
MY EARS ARE PLUGGED, SO IT'S USELESS!

PLINK
YOU'RE DONE FOR!
NO...
WAAAH!!


FWU MP
OH!!
AS LONG AS HE CEASED THOSE VEXING ROTATIONS, I COULD TARGET THE APPROXIMATE LOCATION OF HIS EARDRUMS, AND...
OVER 70% OF THE HUMAN BODY IS COMPOSED OF WATER... A GREAT CONDUCTOR OF SOUND. SO IT'S NOT DIFFICULT TO TRANSMIT SHOCK WAVES THROUGH A WALL OF FLESH.
DOSU KINUTA!!
WE HAVE A WINNER!!
...I'M NOT JUST YOUR GUINEA PIG!
GRIP
I'LL SHOW YOU...
LORD OROCHIMARU...
OR RATHER... OROCHIMARU...

HE EVEN WENT EASY ON HIM...
WELL... HE LOST, BUT I GUESS I'LL STILL TAKE HIM OUT FOR BARBECUE.
HEY, ARE YOU ALL RIGHT?!
I...I WANT...
...TO EAT MEAT...
KOFF
KOFF
IT'S FINALLY OVER...
PHEW...
...THE FINALS...
AT LAST...
...ARE NOW COMPLETE!
UH... WELL THEN, AS OF THIS MOMENT, THE PRELIMINARIES TO THE THIRD EXAM...

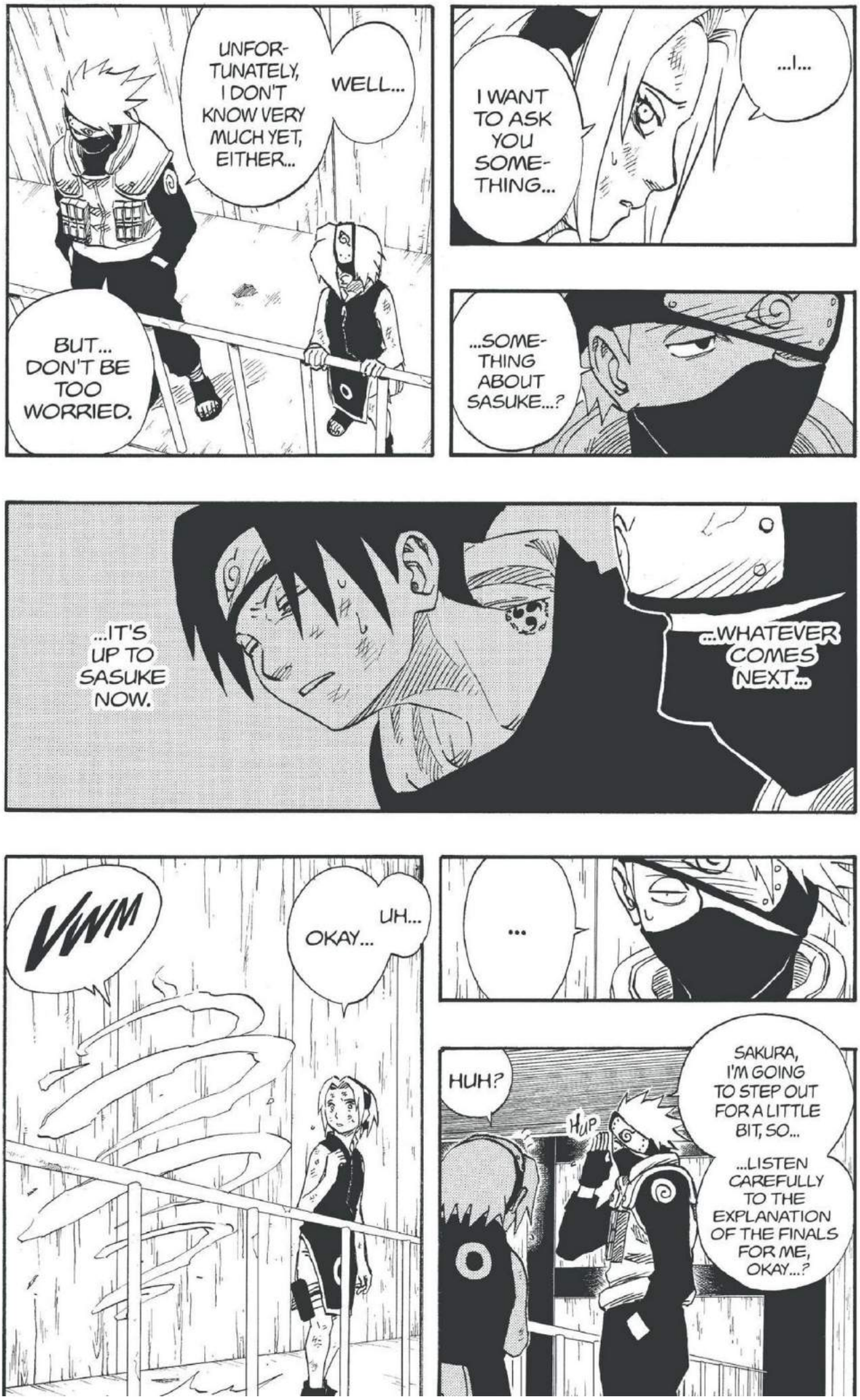
Number 88:



CONGRATULATIONS!
... ALTHOUGH ONE OF YOU ISN'T HERE...
TO THOSE OF YOU WHO WON YOUR BOUTS AND QUALIFIED FOR THE FINALS OF THE THIRD PHASE OF THE CHÛNIN EXAM...
KOFF

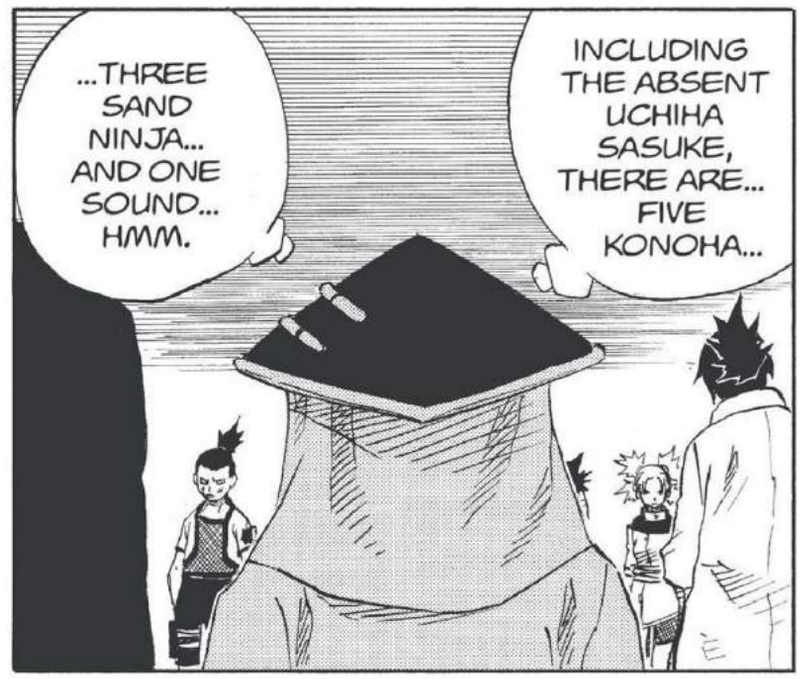
!
MASTER KAKASHI...

...

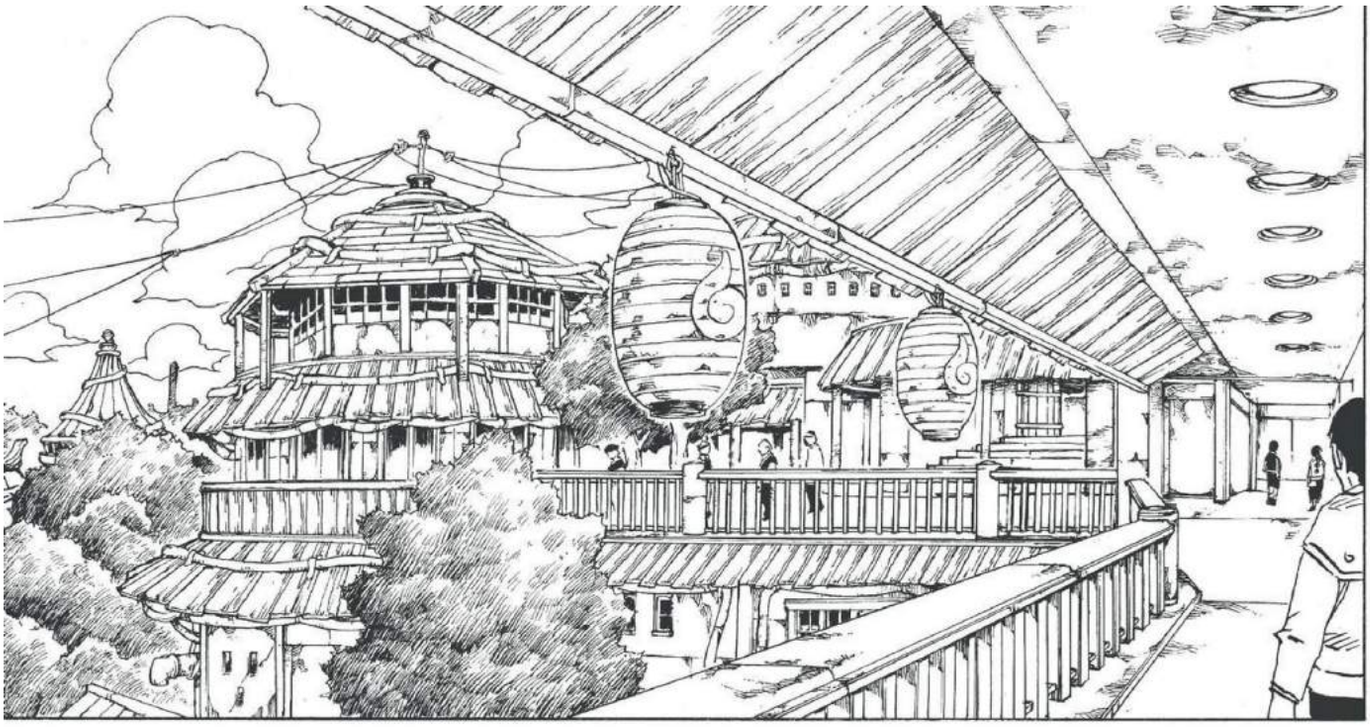

WELL...
UNFORTUNATELY, I DON'T KNOW VERY MUCH YET, EITHER...
BUT... DON'T BE TOO WORRIED.
...I...
I WANT TO ASK YOU SOMETHING...
...SOMETHING ABOUT SASUKE...?
...IT'S UP TO SASUKE NOW.
...WHATEVER COMES NEXT...
VWM
UH... OKAY...
...
HUH?
HUP
SAKURA, I'M GOING TO STEP OUT FOR A LITTLE BIT, SO...
...LISTEN CAREFULLY TO THE EXPLANATION OF THE FINALS FOR ME, OKAY...?

...

UH... WELL, LORD HOKAGE... THEY'RE ALL YOURS.
YES...


...THREE SAND NINJA... AND ONE SOUND... HMM.
INCLUDING THE ABSENT UCHIHA SASUKE, THERE ARE... FIVE KONOHA...

...I SHALL BEGIN EXPLAINING THE FINALS...
WELL THEN... STARTING NOW...
OKAY! FINALLY!!



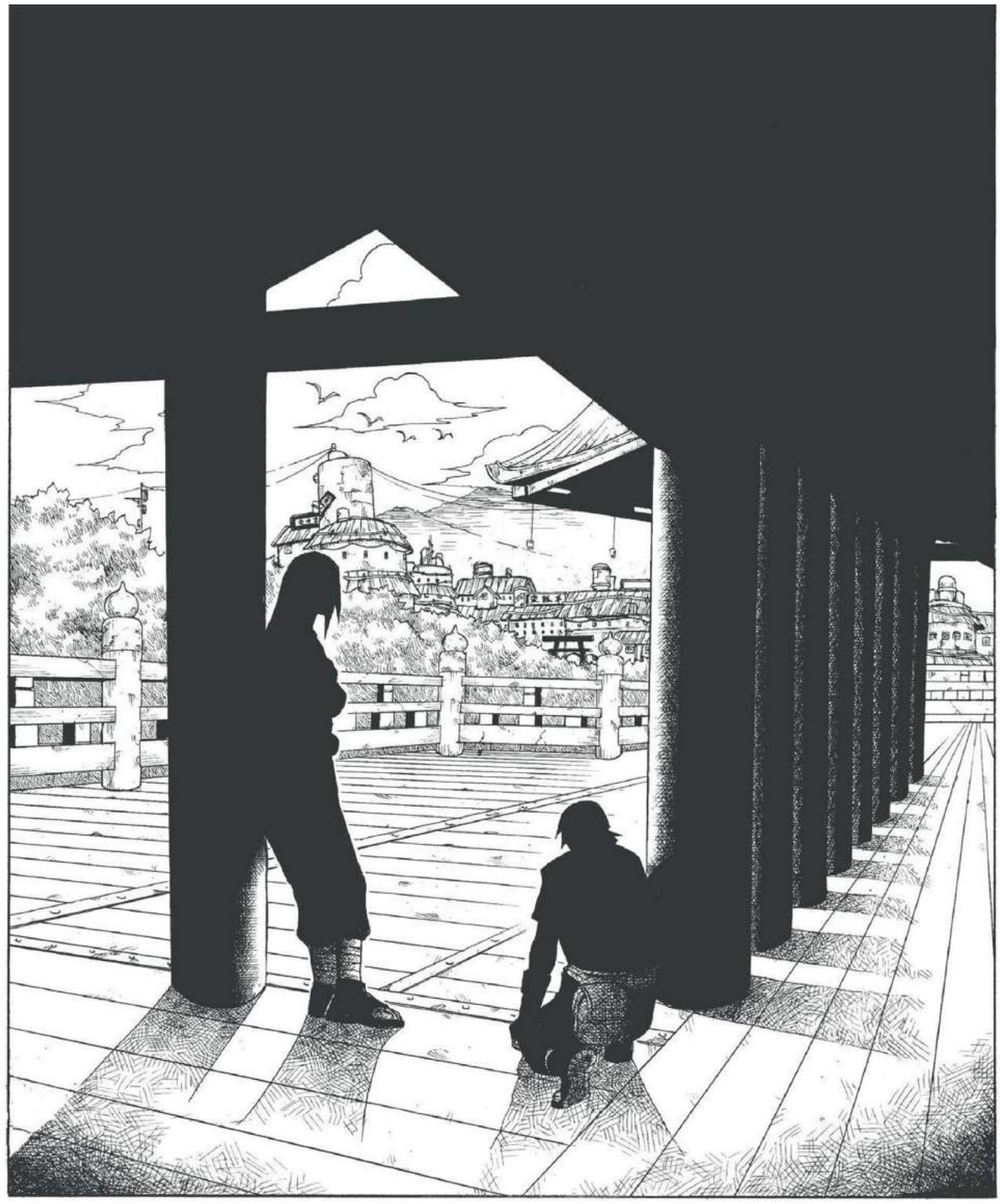
I WONDER HOW IT TURNED OUT...
...FOR NARUTO...

!

TRYING TO PLAY HOOKY AGAIN, HUH?
HEY!! KONOHAMARU!!
I...I NEED TO USE THE BATHROOM, SIR!!

MASTER IRUKA'S BEEN TOTALLY DISTRACTED LATELY, SO THIS IS OUR CHANCE!
HEY, LET'S SNEAK OUT NOW WHILE WE CAN!

BLINK
!



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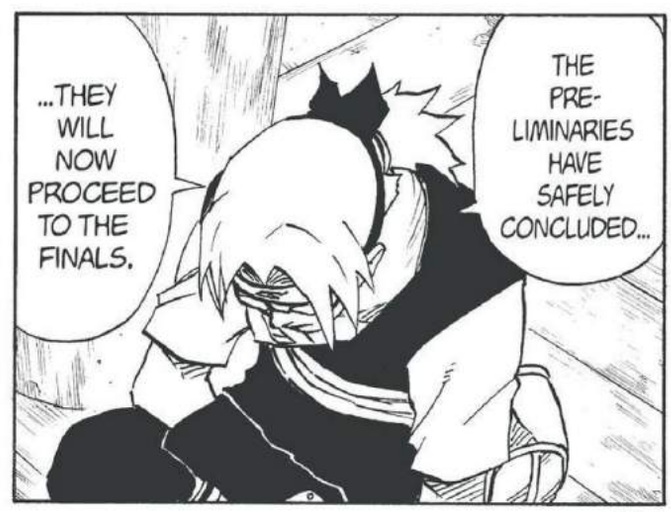
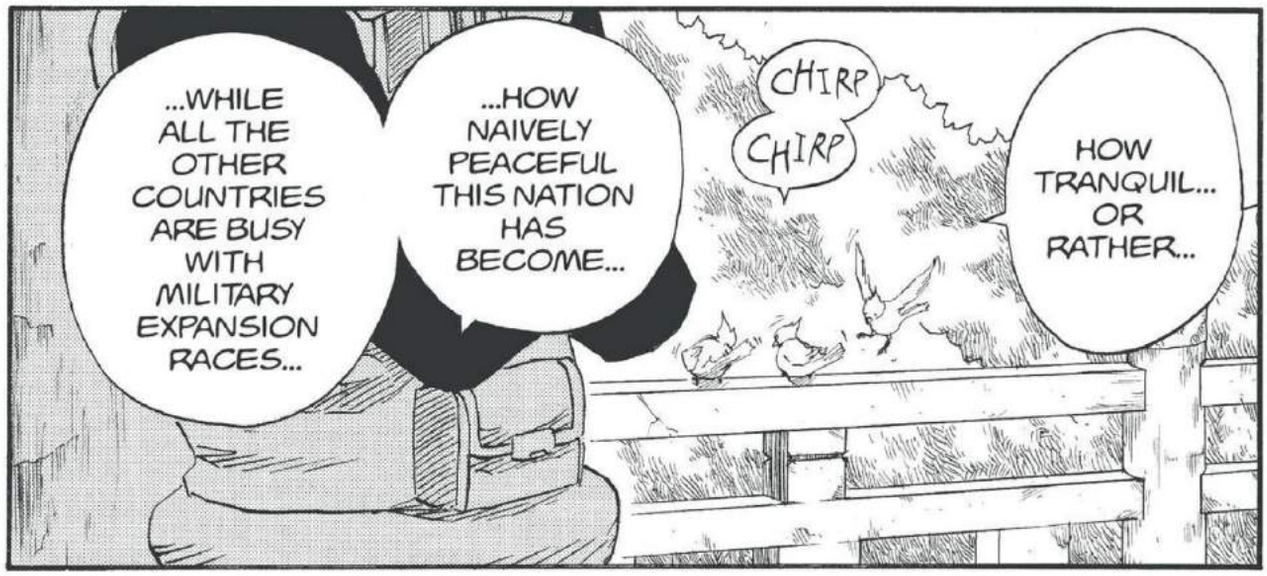

THE PRE-LIMINARIES HAVE SAFELY CONCLUDED...
...THEY WILL NOW PROCEED TO THE FINALS.


HOW TRANQUIL... OR RATHER...
CHIRP
CHIRP
...HOW NAIVELY PEACEFUL THIS NATION HAS BECOME...
...WHILE ALL THE OTHER COUNTRIES ARE BUSY WITH MILITARY EXPANSION RACES...

...ARE YOU SO SURE OF YOURSELF...?

SO IF WE STRIKE NOW...?

WELL, YES...
ALTHOUGH I DOUBT IT WOULD BE ANY FUN TO KILL THAT FEEBLE OLD GEEZER...

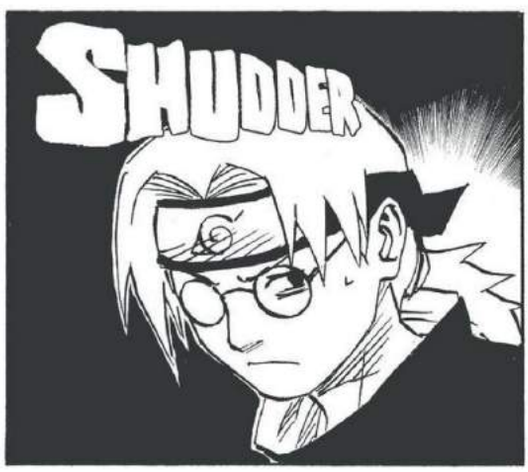
TO ME...
...IT STILL SEEMS LIKE YOU'RE FALTERING...
...

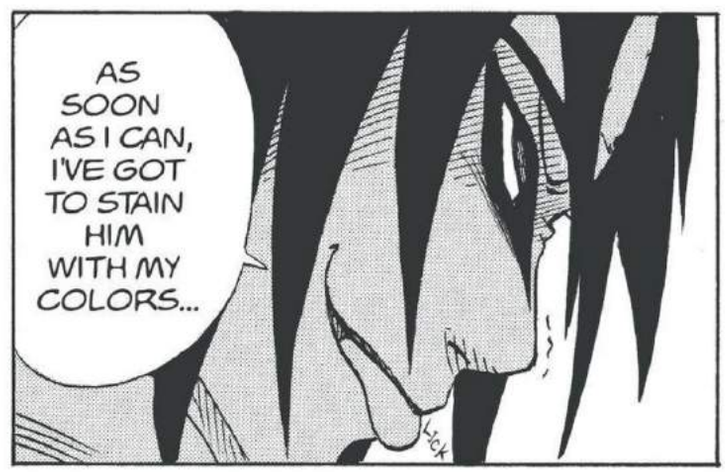
...
OTOGAKURE, THE HIDDEN SOUND VILLAGE, WILL BE ONE OF THOSE INVOLVED...
SOON, THE POWERS OF EACH HIDDEN VILLAGE WILL COLLIDE AND ENTER A FIERCE, LENGTHY CONFLICT...
...AND YOU'RE PLANNING TO BE THE TRIGGER OF THAT...
...UCHIHA SASUKE, WASN'T IT...?
AND TO THAT END, THAT BOY...
...HE'S A BULLET, RIGHT?
...BECAUSE I DIDN'T KNOW ABOUT DOSU, ZAKU AND KIN.
WELL, OBVIOUSLY NOT...
HEH...
I MADE A FOOLISH TACTICAL ERROR... I EVEN PROVOKED THEM INTO ATTACKING ME...
WHEN I WAS ASSIGNED TO GATHER INTELLIGENCE ON SASUKE...
...AND OVER-ESTIMATED MY OWN DEFENSES.
...I WANTED TO UNDERSTAND THE POWER OF THOSE THREE SOUND NINJA.
YOUR INSIGHTS ARE DISGUSTINGLY ACCURATE...

IT SEEMS... YOU STILL DON'T PUT YOUR FULL TRUST IN ME...
...ISN'T THAT RIGHT?
...
YOU'RE MY RIGHT-HAND MAN... THAT ITSELF IS EVIDENCE OF MY TRUST.
THOSE THREE ARE SO INCONSEQUENTIAL... IS IT REALLY NECESSARY FOR ME TO TELL YOU OF SUCH TRIVIALITIES?
...I WAS THINKING OF ENTRUSTING SASUKE TO YOU...
THAT'S WHY...
BUT BEFORE THE DARKNESS IN HIS SOUL IS EXTINGUISHED...
...NOT THAT IT'S OF MUCH CONSEQUENCE.
THE CURSE MARK I PUT ON HIM... IT SEEMS IT'S BEEN SEALED BY THAT PESKY KAKASHI...

HOW UNLIKE YOU...
YOU'RE WORRIED!
THERE IS SOMETHING CAUSING ME A BIT OF CONCERN...
YOU MEAN... UZUMAKI NARUTO?
...I WANT YOU TO KIDNAP HIM RIGHT AWAY.
...HE CAME AT ME WITHOUT ANY FEAR OF DEATH.
AND YET... WHEN WE FOUGHT EACH OTHER... EVEN THOUGH HE KNEW HE COULDN'T PREVAIL AGAINST ME...
AND I HADN'T THOUGHT HE WAS A CHILD WHO WOULD RUSH SO EAGERLY TO HIS DEMISE...
SASUKE IS AN EMBODIMENT OF VENGEANCE... HIS SOLE REASON FOR LIVING IS THE DESIRE TO KILL HIS OLDER BROTHER.
HEH... A SHARP CHILD, INDEED...
UNTIL HE ACHIEVES THAT GOAL, HE CANNOT DIE.

SINCE NARUTO POSSESSES SO MUCH INFLUENCE OVER SASUKE...
ACCORDING TO YOUR NOTES, IT SEEMS THAT HIS CONTACT WITH THE NINE-TAILED FOX CHILD...
...I MUST SEPARATE THEM IMMEDIATELY...
FWUP
...IS CHANGING SASUKE'S PURPOSE AND HIS SOUL.


SHUDDER


AS SOON AS I CAN, I'VE GOT TO STAIN HIM WITH MY COLORS...
LICK

KABUTO... YOU...
WELL THEN...
TAK

IF YOU WANT TO STOP ME...

...YOUR ONLY CHANCE IS TO KILL SASUKE NOW.

EVEN IF YOU'RE STRONG...
YOU'RE NO STRONGER THAN KAKASHI, SO...
THERE'S NO WAY YOU COULD KILL ME, EH?

!!

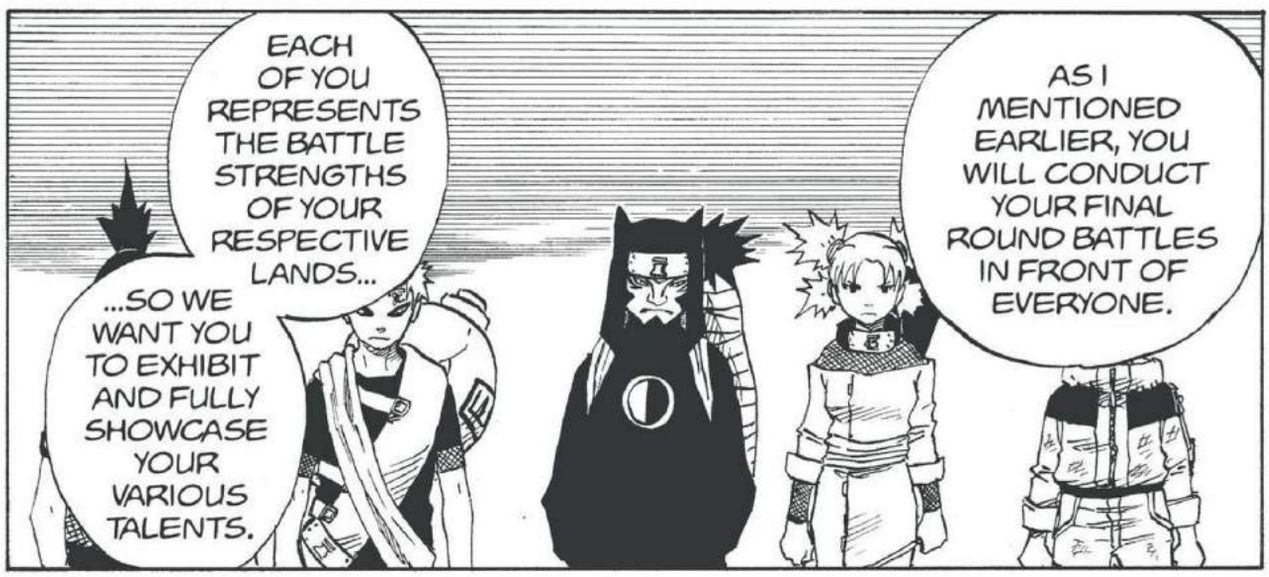
...

I'M PUTTING MY TRUST IN YOU...
NOW... YOU MAY GO!

GULP

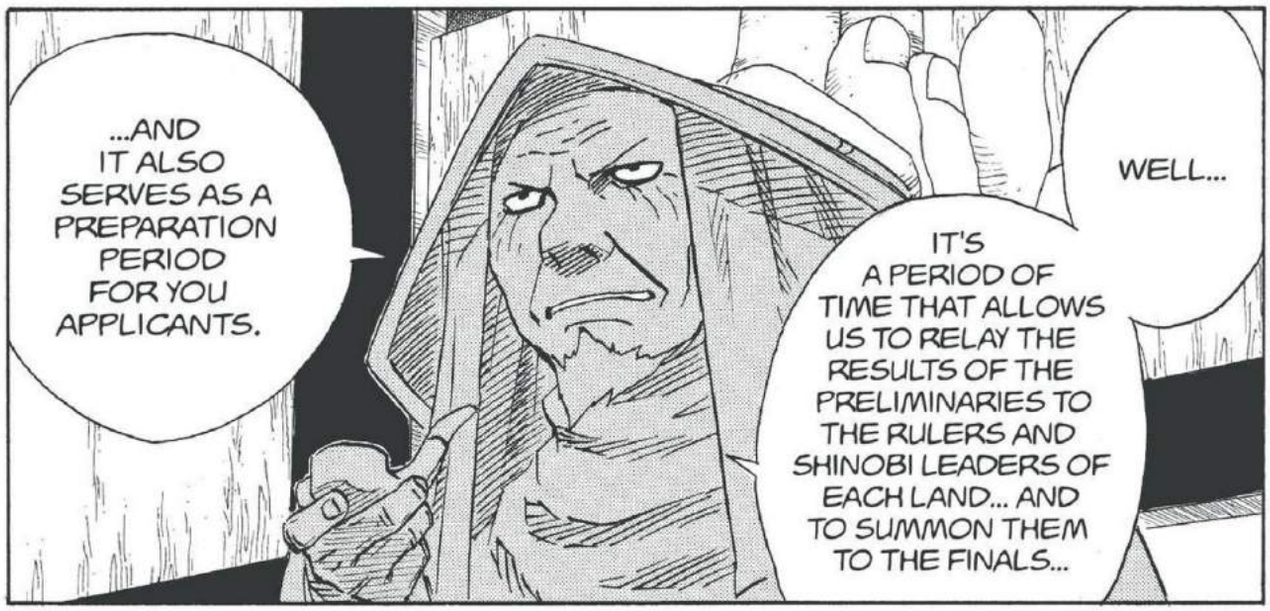
HEH... I'M JOKING...

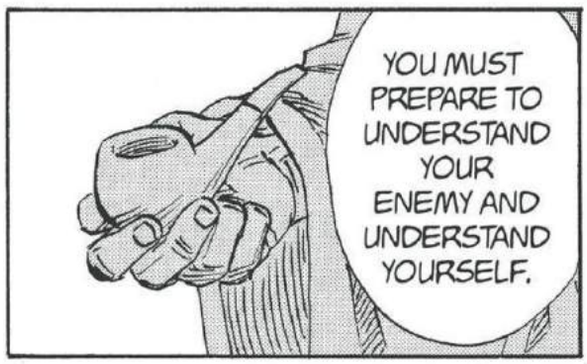
I WONDER WHAT HE'S THINKING...
HEH... THAT FACE...
HOP
VWM


EACH OF YOU REPRESENTS THE BATTLE STRENGTHS OF YOUR RESPECTIVE LANDS...
...SO WE WANT YOU TO EXHIBIT AND FULLY SHOWCASE YOUR VARIOUS TALENTS.
AS I MENTIONED EARLIER, YOU WILL CONDUCT YOUR FINAL ROUND BATTLES IN FRONT OF EVERYONE.

...WILL COMMENCE ONE MONTH FROM NOW!
AND THUS THE FINALS...

WHAT DO YOU MEAN?
WE CALL THIS THE REQUISITE PREPARATION PERIOD...
WE'RE NOT DOING IT RIGHT HERE, RIGHT NOW?
!

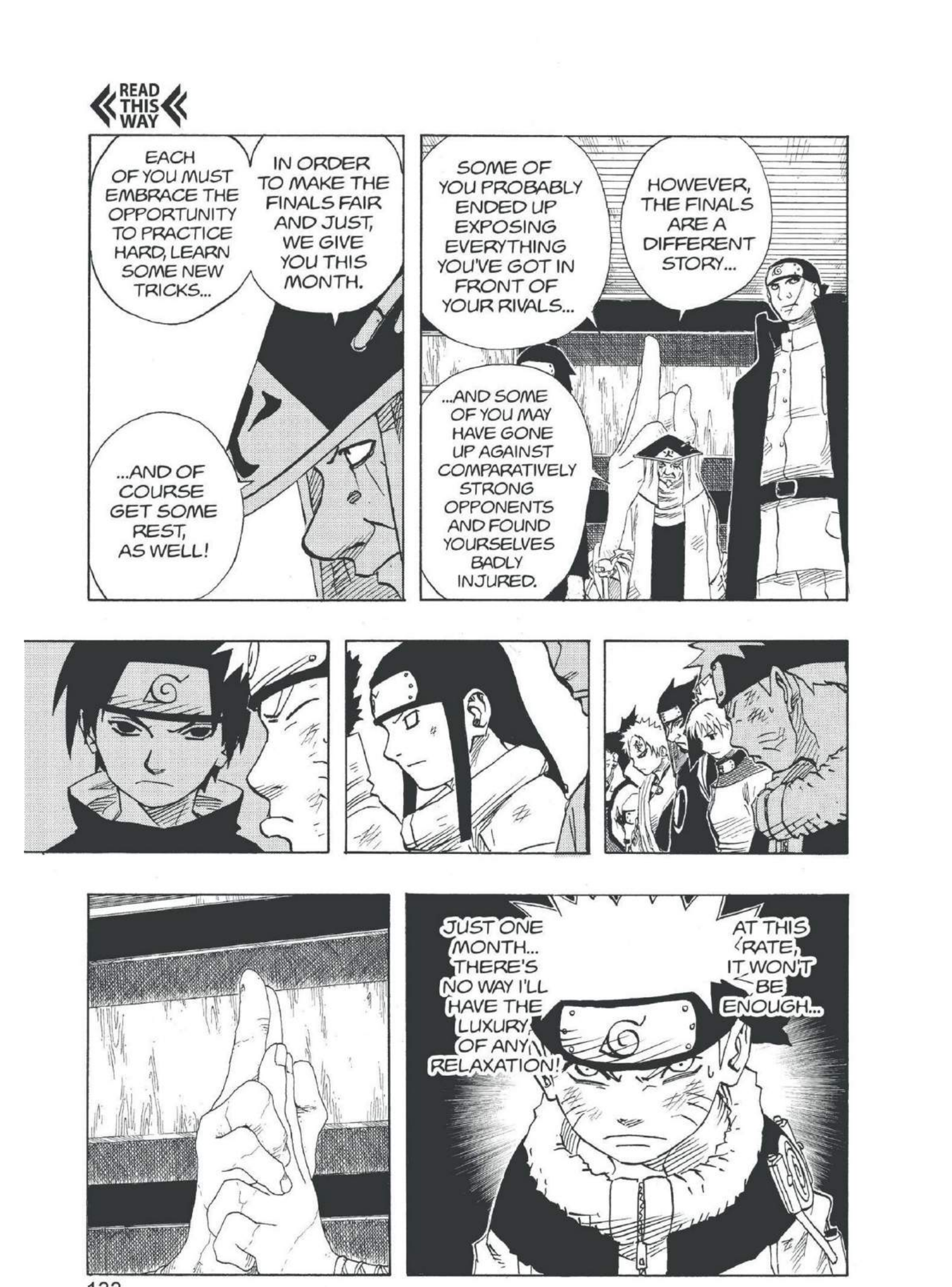

...AND IT ALSO SERVES AS A PREPARATION PERIOD FOR YOU APPLICANTS.
WELL...
IT'S A PERIOD OF TIME THAT ALLOWS US TO RELAY THE RESULTS OF THE PRELIMINARIES TO THE RULERS AND SHINOBI LEADERS OF EACH LAND... AND TO SUMMON THEM TO THE FINALS...


YOU MUST PREPARE TO UNDERSTAND YOUR ENEMY AND UNDERSTAND YOURSELF.

I STILL DON'T GET IT! WHAT DO YOU MEAN?
THIS OLD GEEZER, HE ALWAYS BEATS AROUND THE BUSH...

...WELL, YEAH...!
I NEVER DREAMED THAT THIS GUY WOULD USE SAND AS A WEAPON...

EVEN THOUGH, UP TO THIS POINT, ALL THE BATTLES HAVE BEEN REAL BATTLES...
DURING THIS PERIOD, YOU CAN ANALYZE THE INTELLIGENCE YOU HAVE GATHERED ON YOUR FOES DURING THE PRELIMINARIES...
...AND USE IT TO INCREASE YOUR CHANCES OF VICTORY.
...THEY WERE CONDUCTED ON THE PREMISE THAT YOU WERE FIGHTING AN "UNKNOWN ENEMY"...

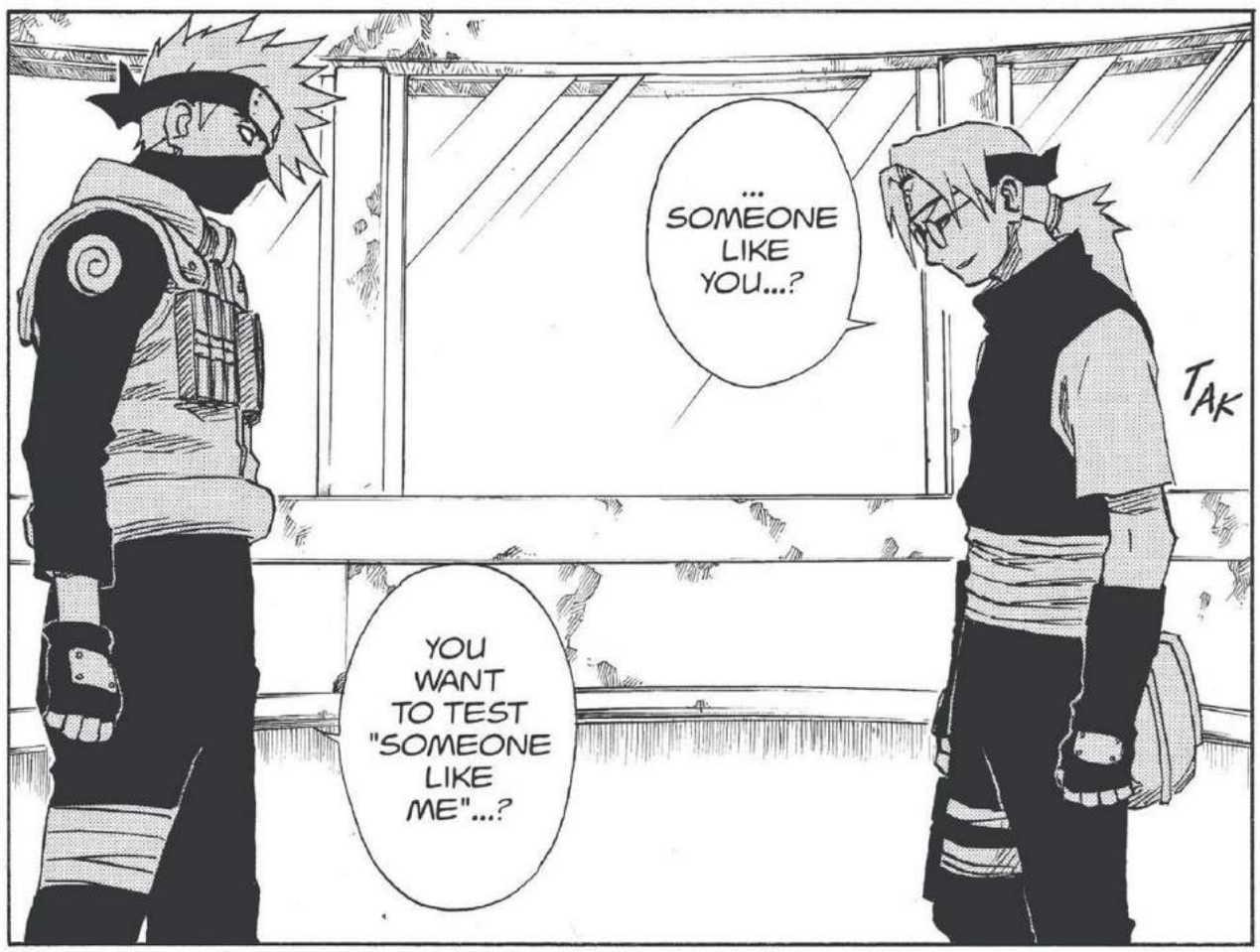

READ THIS WAY
EACH OF YOU MUST EMBRACE THE OPPORTUNITY TO PRACTICE HARD, LEARN SOME NEW TRICKS...
IN ORDER TO MAKE THE FINALS FAIR AND JUST, WE GIVE YOU THIS MONTH.
...AND OF COURSE GET SOME REST, AS WELL!
SOME OF YOU PROBABLY ENDED UP EXPOSING EVERYTHING YOU'VE GOT IN FRONT OF YOUR RIVALS...
HOWEVER, THE FINALS ARE A DIFFERENT STORY...
...AND SOME OF YOU MAY HAVE GONE UP AGAINST COMPARATIVELY STRONG OPPONENTS AND FOUND YOURSELVES BADLY INJURED.
JUST ONE MONTH... THERE'S NO WAY I'LL HAVE THE LUXURY OF ANY RELAXATION!
AT THIS RATE, IT WON'T BE ENOUGH...

THUD
THUD
THUD
WE STOOD OUT TOO MUCH.
I WONDER IF CATCHING LORD OROCHIMARU'S EYE WILL MEAN RUIN FOR BOTH OF US...
AN EXCESS OF BRILLIANCE CAN BE A DISADVANTAGE...
TAK
TAK
SIGH...

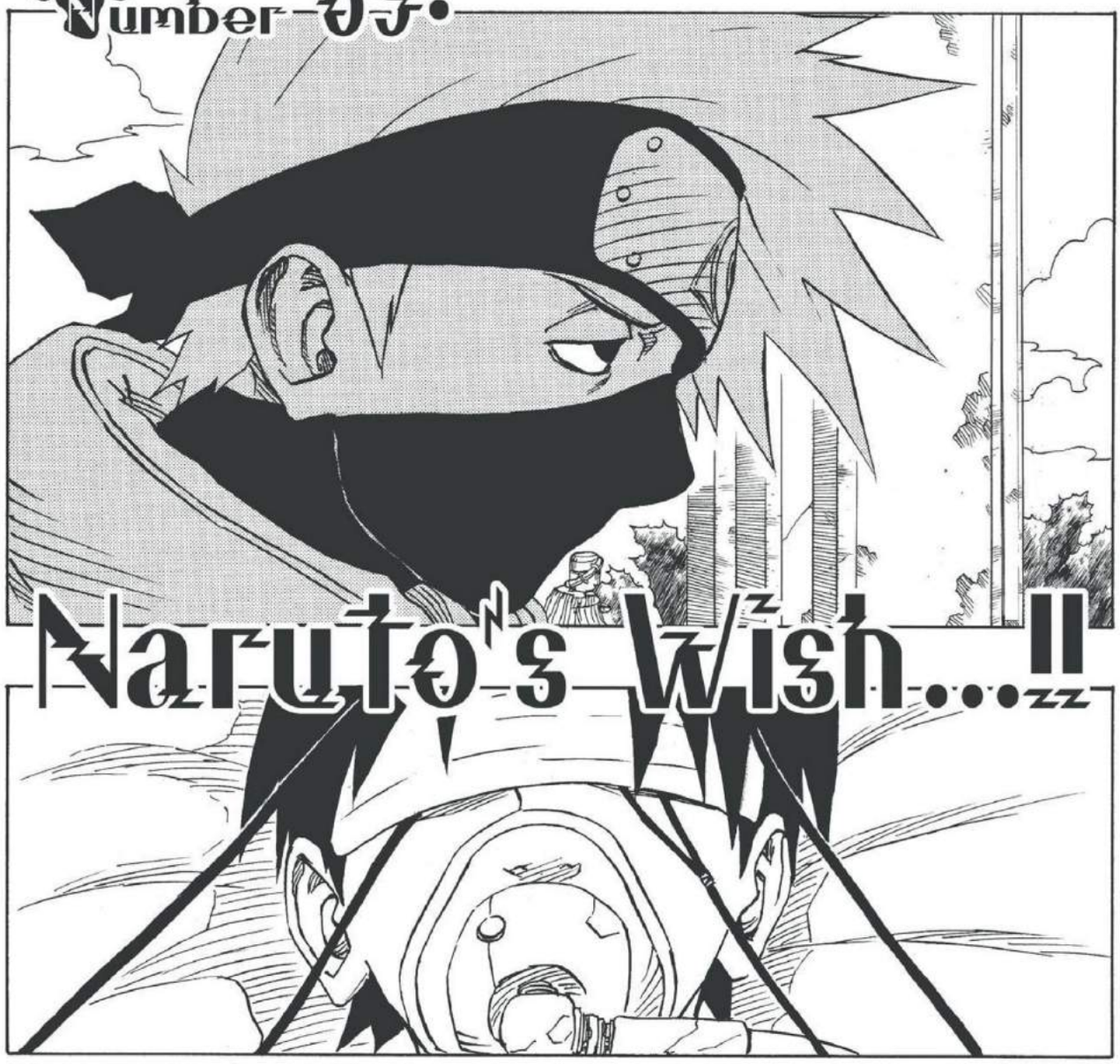
READ THIS WAY
KABUTO...
HE'S SO YOUNG... HOW COULD HE HAVE THIS DEMON DWELLING IN HIS HEART? IT WILL SERVE HIS PURPOSES NICELY...
...WHEN HE EVENTUALLY USES THAT TECHNIQUE TO MAKE THIS KID INTO...
...KILL SASUKE, AFTER ALL...
PERHAPS YOU REALLY WILL...
SWUP
SHOW!!

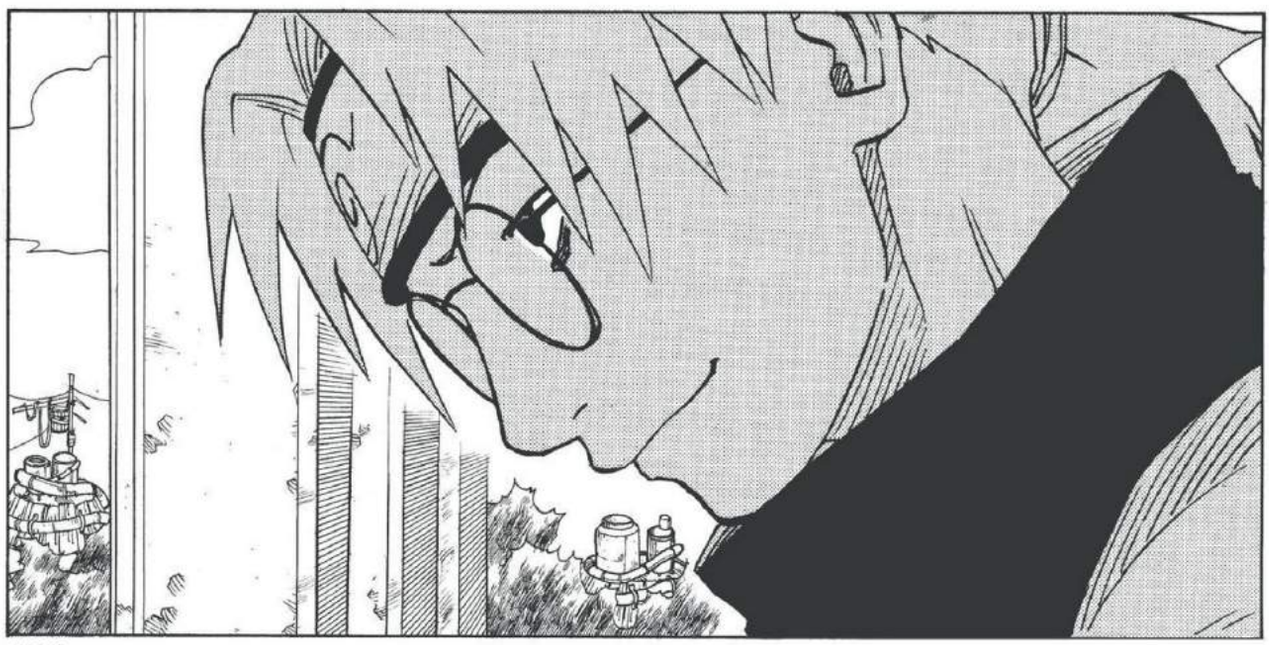
SNATCH
...WOULD THINK TO STOP MY ATTACK FROM MY BLIND SPOT...
ONLY YOU, KAKASHI...

YOU MADE YOUR ATTACK IMMEDIATELY UPON NOTICING MY PRESENCE... YOU'RE PRETTY IMPRESSIVE.
YOU'RE NO ORDINARY GENIN, ARE YOU...?
YOU...
I WONDER IF YOU CAN...?
DEPENDING ON THE CIRCUM-STANCES...
...I'LL HAVE TO ARREST AND INTERROGATE YOU.
WHAT DO YOU WANT WITH SASUKE?
NO...
I'M NOT SO GREAT...

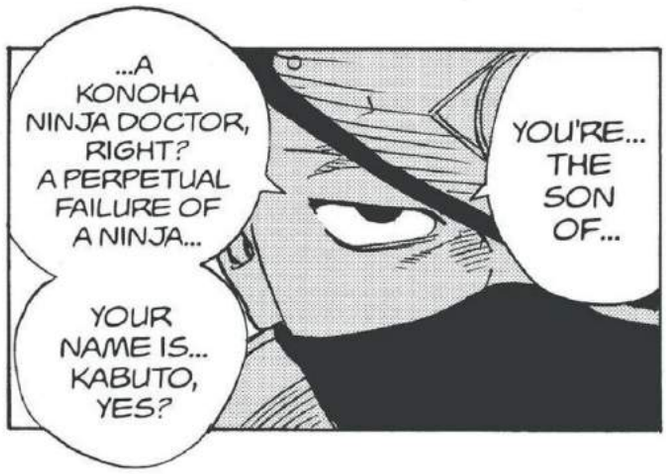

... SOMEONE LIKE YOU...?
TAK
YOU WANT TO TEST "SOMEONE LIKE ME"...?

Number 89:





WHAT ARE YOU?!


...A KONOHA NINJA DOCTOR, RIGHT? A PERPETUAL FAILURE OF A NINJA...
YOUR NAME IS... KABUTO, YES?
YOU'RE... THE SON OF...

HE SLAUGHTERED THEM ALL... AND WITH SUCH EASE!
EVERY SINGLE ONE OF THE BLACK OPS SOLDIERS I HAD GATHERED...

...AT LEAST 10 GUARDS.
...NEXT TIME, YOU SHOULD PROBABLY READY...

...

...SHOW SOME RESPECT.
I'M THE ONE ASKING THE QUESTIONS HERE...
...
JUST SHUT UP AND ANSWER MY QUESTIONS.
AND WHAT IF I REFUSE?
...IN LEAGUE WITH OROCHIMARU?
ARE YOU...
...WHY DON'T YOU JUST LET IT GO FOR NOW?
IT'LL ALL COME OUT EVENTUALLY, SO...
YOU... YOU'RE JUST A SELFISH LITTLE BRAT, AREN'T YOU...?
NO MATTER WHAT KIND OF TORTURE OR GENJUTSU YOU INFLICT UPON ME, I WON'T SPILL A SINGLE SECRET...
IF YOU ARREST ME HERE, RIGHT NOW, YOU MIGHT NEVER BE ABLE TO PROVE MY CONNECTION TO OROCHIMARU.
AND BESIDES, I DON'T REALLY LIKE CONFRONTA-TIONS.

SHF
THWP
...YOU SHOULDN'T MOCK YOUR SUPERIORS.
...THAT THE CIRCUMSTANCES ARE IN MY FAVOR...
YOU'RE ACTING AWFULLY SMUG, CONSIDERING...
YOU KNOW THE LAWS OF THIS VILLAGE...
...HOW SPIES ARE DEALT WITH.
!
TWIK
YOU WON'T JUST RELEASE ME, THEN?
SHF

!
TCH
FWP!!
CHING
WHAK

HOP
FUMP
TAK
A SHADOW DOPPEL-GANGER!!
SKF
OH... AHA!
!!
TAK
UGH...
BLINK
TAP

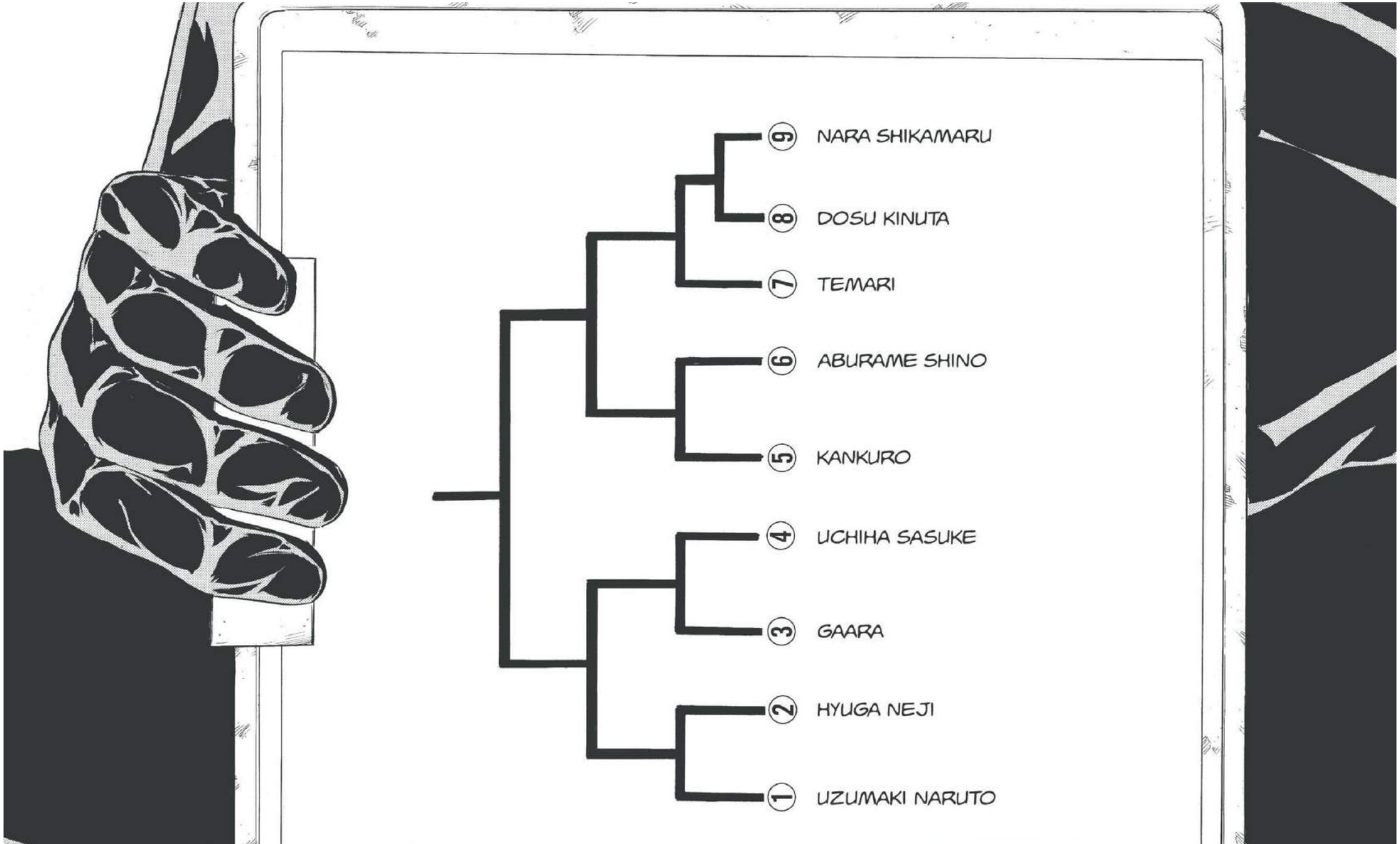
THOK
KRAK
KRAK
THOK
THOK
KRAK
THOK
HOP
WOBBLE
BLINK
!
SL
AM
WHOOOSH
HUP

SKF
DARN IT... HE GOT AWAY...
SWP
...!
TWST
AMAZ-ING...
FUMP
POOF
...IN THE WAY HE ENJOYS TRIFLING WITH CORPSES...
THE INFLUENCE OF HIS ADOPTIVE FATHER, THE CHIEF OF THE MEDICAL CORPS, IS OBVIOUS...
I'M AMAZED... HE WAS SO THOROUGH IN HIS DECEPTION THAT HE EVEN ERASED THE DEAD BODY'S ODOR...
AND HE STILLED HIS OWN HEARTBEAT... DISGUISING HIMSELF AS ONE OF THE BLACK OPS SOLDIERS HE HAD KILLED... TO ALLOW HIS ESCAPE.
JUST AS I THOUGHT... SHIKON NO JUTSU... THE ART OF DEAD SOULS, USED TO TEMPORARILY RESTORE A CADAVER'S HEART BEAT AND MANIPULATE THE CORPSE...
HE SURGICALLY ALTERED THE FACE... TO MAKE IT RESEMBLE HIS OWN...!

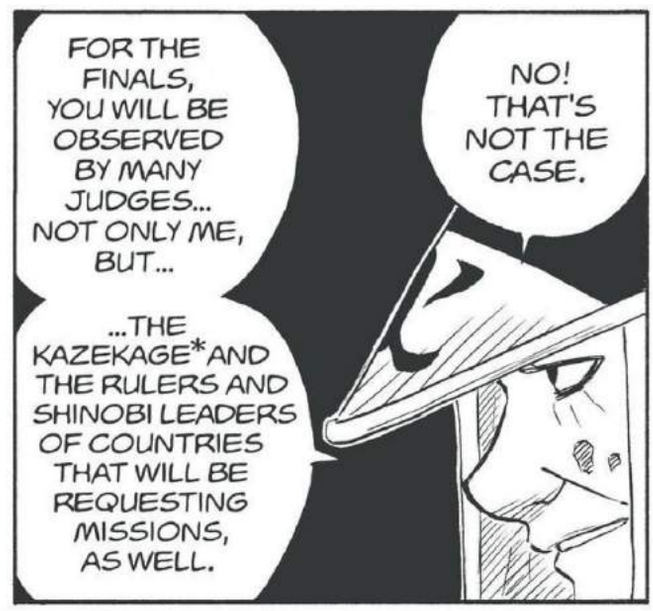
SO... THOSE ARE THE BASICS.
IF SUCH A TALENTED PERSON IS WORKING UNDER OROCHIMARU, THEN...
HIS MOVES WOULD PUT EVEN THE UNDERTAKER SQUAD TO SHAME...
AT THIS RATE, I'LL BE OBSOLETE SOON, TOO...
I'LL COME AROUND, SO LINE UP, OKAY?
NOW THEN, DON'T BE SO IM-PATIENT...
THERE ARE SLIPS OF PAPER INSIDE THE BOX ANKO IS HOLDING... EACH OF YOU, TAKE ONE.
...THERE'S ONE LAST THING WE MUST DO FOR THE FINALS.
I WOULD LIKE TO LET YOU ALL GO NOW, BUT FIRST...
I NEED TO START TRAINING NOW!!
HEY, COME ON!
LUB DUP
DIG DIG
ONE PER PERSON!

TUG
?
1
SWIP
THEN... STARTING AT THE LEFT, EACH OF YOU READ OUT THE NUMBER WRITTEN ON YOUR SLIP!
ALL RIGHT... DOES EVERYBODY HAVE ONE NOW...?
5
7
I GOT 1!
I HAVE 8.

READ THIS WAY
6
2
9
3
...THE MATCH ORDER FOR THE TOURNAMENT-STYLE FINALS!!
AND NOW I WILL REVEAL...
GOOD!
SO UCHIHA WILL BE NUMBER 4...
SO THAT'S WHAT THE DRAWING WAS FOR?!
WHAT?!
GULP
WELL, IBIKI, SHOW THEM THE PAIRINGS.
YES SIR...

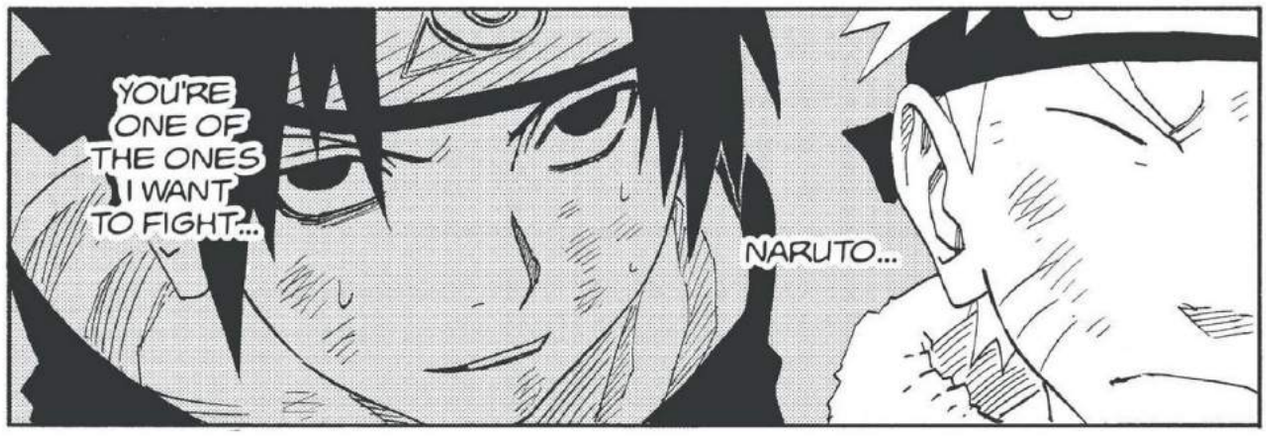

9 NARA SHIKAMARU
8 DOSU KINUTA
7 TEMARI
6 ABURAME SHINO
5 KANKURO
4 UCHIHA SASUKE
3 GAARA
2 HYUGA NEJI
1 UZUMAKI NARUTO

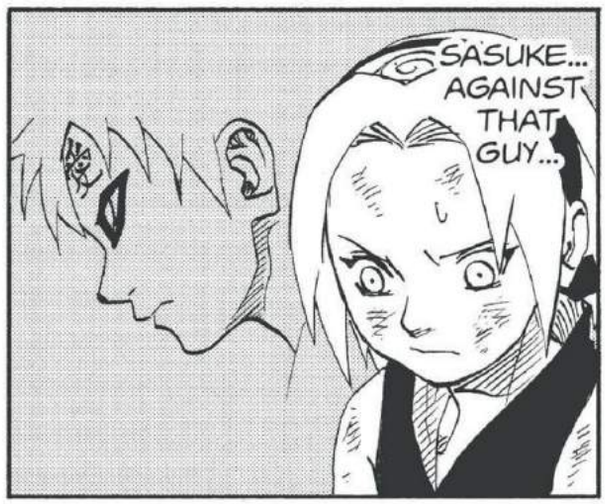
AND I DON'T WANT TO HAVE TO AVENGE CHOJI...
MAN, I'VE GOT TO FIGHT AN EXTRA ROUND.
NO THANKS!
THE FINALS ARE A SIMPLE TOURNAMENT...?
WHAT?
MY MATCH COMES LATE IN THE GAME...
...
...PERFECT.
UCHIHA... SASUKE...
I'M IN A DIFFERENT BRACKET THAN GAARA...
SIGH...
THANK GOODNESS.
I NEVER DREAMED OF A BETTER OPPONENT!
HYUGA NEJI, RIGHT OFF THE BAT?
MAY I?
SURE!
WE'RE ALL FINISHED HERE... UNLESS ANY OF YOU HAVE QUESTIONS?
NOW THEN... IT'S TIME FOR YOU TO GO PLAN YOUR STRATEGIES, REST UP, OR WHATEVER YOU PLEASE.



*THE LEADER OF THE VILLAGE OF SUNAGAKURE (THE VILLAGE HIDDEN IN SAND).

DOES THAT ANSWER YOUR QUESTION, SHIKAMARU?!
GEEZ... HE DIDN'T HAVE TO THROW IT BACK IN MY FACE...
...THAT NONE OF YOU WILL BECOME CHÛNIN!
HOWEVER, IT IS ALSO POSSIBLE...
...IS IN HAVING A GREATER NUMBER OF OPPORTUNITIES TO DISPLAY YOUR TALENTS FOR THE JUDGES.
THE ADVANTAGE OF FIGHTING IN MORE ROUNDS IN THE TOURNAMENT...
YOU ARE DISMISSED UNTIL ONE MONTH FROM NOW!
WELL THEN, GOOD WORK, ALL!
HE WAS STRONG ENOUGH TO WIPE THE FLOOR WITH BUSHY BROWS, SO...
MY SECOND ROUND WILL BE AGAINST EITHER THAT BROWLESS SAND GUY OR SASUKE...?


YOU'RE ONE OF THE ONES I WANT TO FIGHT...
NARUTO...


SASUKE... AGAINST THAT GUY...

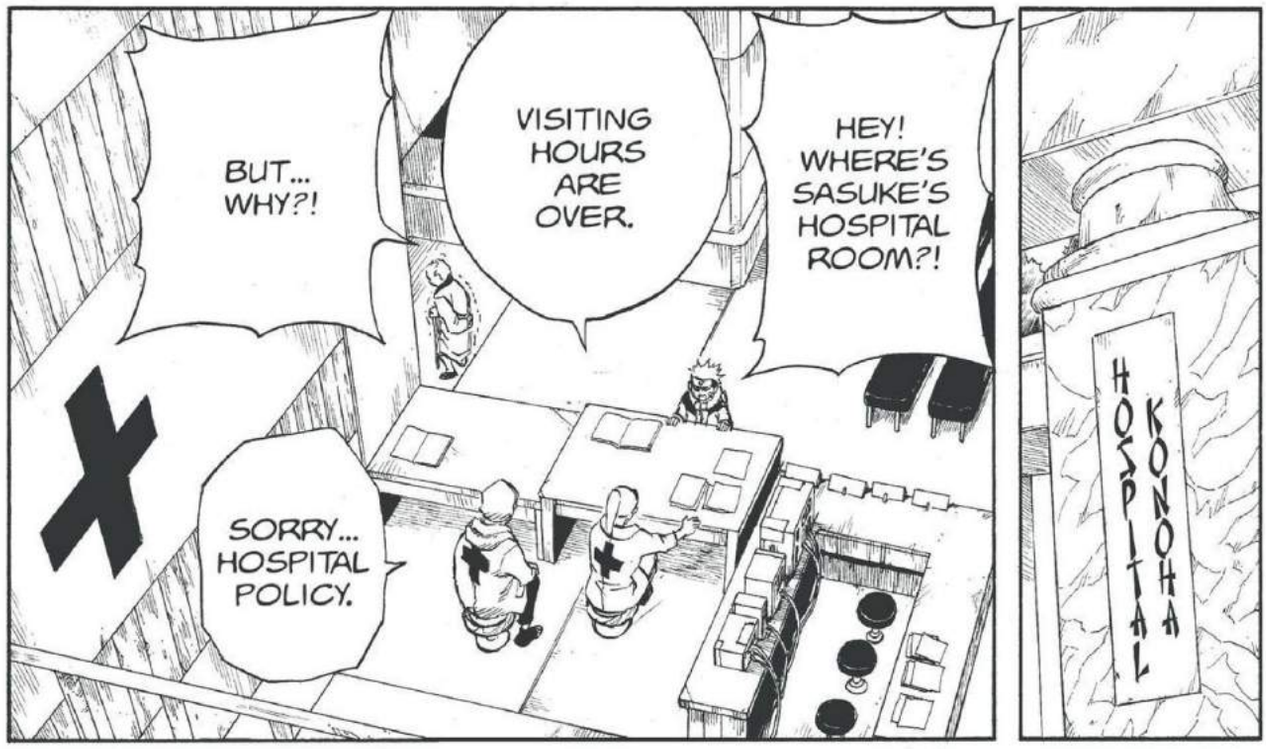
I'D BETTER ASK MASTER KAKASHI FOR HELP!
...

...WITH SASUKE!
HE'S PROBABLY...

SAKURA!! WHERE'S MASTER KAKASHI?!
!

...

THANKS, SAKURA!


HEY! WHERE'S SASUKE'S HOSPITAL ROOM?!
VISITING HOURS ARE OVER.
BUT... WHY?!
SORRY... HOSPITAL POLICY.
KONOHA HOSPITAL

HEY! I NEED A FAVOR!
TAK TAK
STOP RIGHT THERE... I ALREADY KNOW WHAT YOU'RE ABOUT TO ASK, SO...
OH! MASTER KAKASHI!!
NARUTO, YOU'RE IN A HOSPITAL! BE QUIET!

...I COULDN'T GIVE YOU MY FULL ATTENTION.
I'VE GOT OTHER THINGS GOING ON...
HUH?!
I WANT YOU TO TRAIN ME, MASTER KAKASHI!
I'VE FOUND SOMEONE TO OVERSEE YOUR TRAINING.

NOW, NOW! DON'T COMPLAIN.
I FOUND YOU AN EVEN BETTER TEACHER THAN ME.
STAB
LET ME GUESS! YOU'RE TRAINING SASUKE, RIGHT?!
HMPH!
...
YOU'RE...
HEY!
!
HUH?
IT IS I!!
WHO IS IT?!
HOW RUDE!
POKE
...SUPER-PERV!!

THE WORLD OF KISHIMOTO MASASHI
MY PERSONAL HISTORY, PART 13

ONCE I WAS EXPOSED TO *AKIRA*, MY ATTITUDE TOWARD ART BEGAN TO CHANGE DRAMATICALLY. I DID SOME RESEARCH ON THE STYLE OF MR. OTOMO, THE AUTHOR AND ARTIST OF *AKIRA*, IN AN ATTEMPT TO LEARN WHICH ARTISTS HAD INFLUENCED HIM... BUT I COULDN'T FIND ANYTHING. SO I CONCLUDED THAT IT WAS COMPLETELY ORIGINAL... AND THAT'S WHEN IT CAME TO ME: "WOW, THIS IS THE FIRST TIME SINCE SEEING MR. TORIYAMA'S WORK THAT I'VE BEEN SO STRONGLY AFFECTED BY SOMEONE'S ART."

I HAD ABSOLUTELY NO IDEA WHY MR. TORIYAMA'S AND MR. OTOMO'S ART WERE BOTH SO FASCINATING, BUT THERE WERE TWO THINGS THAT I WAS SURE OF. BOTH OF THEM DID WORK THAT SEEMED ORIGINAL AND HAD A GREAT SENSE OF STYLE. I HAD THE FEELING THAT THEIR EFFECTS, DESIGN AND ATTENTION TO DETAIL WERE TOTALLY DIFFERENT FROM THOSE OF OTHER PEOPLE. IN OTHER WORDS, I STARTED THINKING THAT WHAT "FASCINATING ART" MEANT TO ME WAS "ORIGINAL ART," AND THAT COPYCAT ART, NO MATTER HOW TECHNICALLY SKILLFUL, WAS MEANINGLESS.

AFTER THAT, I TRIED TO MAKE SURE THAT EVERYTHING I DREW WAS TRULY ORIGINAL... BUT I ALWAYS ENDED UP LETTING OUTSIDE INFLUENCES CREEP IN, AND MY END PRODUCT WASN'T ORIGINAL AFTER ALL. STILL UNSATISFIED WITH MY RESULTS, I BEGAN STUDYING THE WORK OF MANY DIFFERENT MANGA ARTISTS, ONE BY ONE, WONDERING IF I COULD FIND ANY OTHERS WHOSE ART COULD RIVAL THAT OF THE TWO I ALREADY REVERED.

THAT'S WHEN I REALIZED THAT THE ARTISTS WHOSE WORK I FOUND INTERESTING WERE ALL INFLUENCED EITHER BY ONE OR BOTH OF THE ABOVE TWO, OR BY SOMEONE ELSE, AND THAT A TOTALLY ORIGINAL STYLE IS VERY RARE. IN ANY CASE, I THOUGHT MR. OTOMO HAD THE BEST STYLE OF THEM ALL, SO I STARTED IMITATING HIM. IN THE BEGINNING OF EIGHTH OR NINTH GRADE, I BOUGHT ALL THE *AKIRA*-RELATED MATERIALS I COULD FIND -- THE ART BOOK, MANGA AND MOVIE MANGA -- AND FURIOUSLY COPIED THEM. BUT I CONTINUED TO STRIVE FOR MY OWN STYLE AND WORKED HARD AT ALL DIFFERENT SORTS OF ORIGINAL ART AS WELL. (LATER, I WOULD ENCOUNTER TWO OTHER ARTISTS WHOM I CAME TO CONSIDER ORIGINAL AND STYLISH, BUT THAT IS A TALE FOR ANOTHER DAY.)

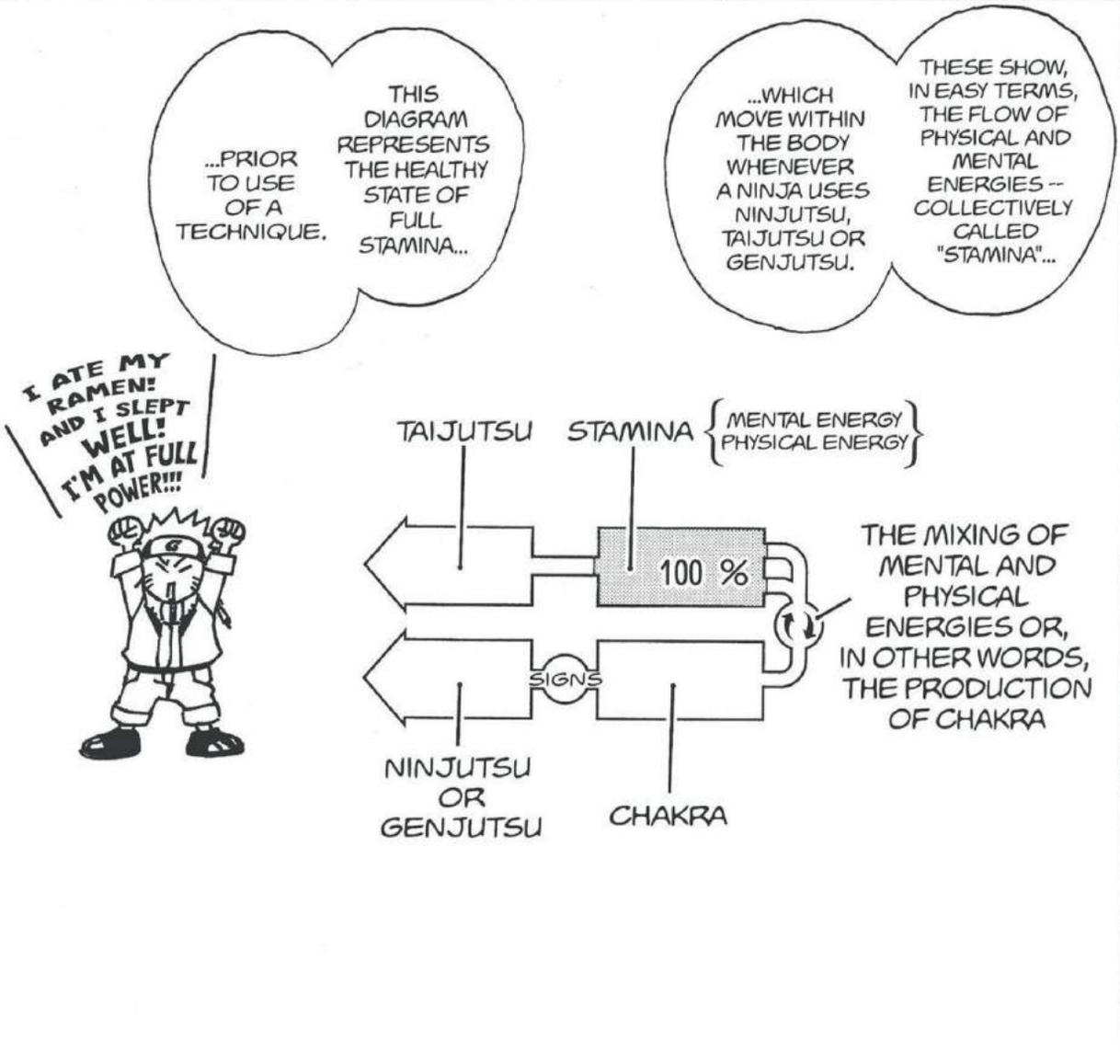
Number 90:

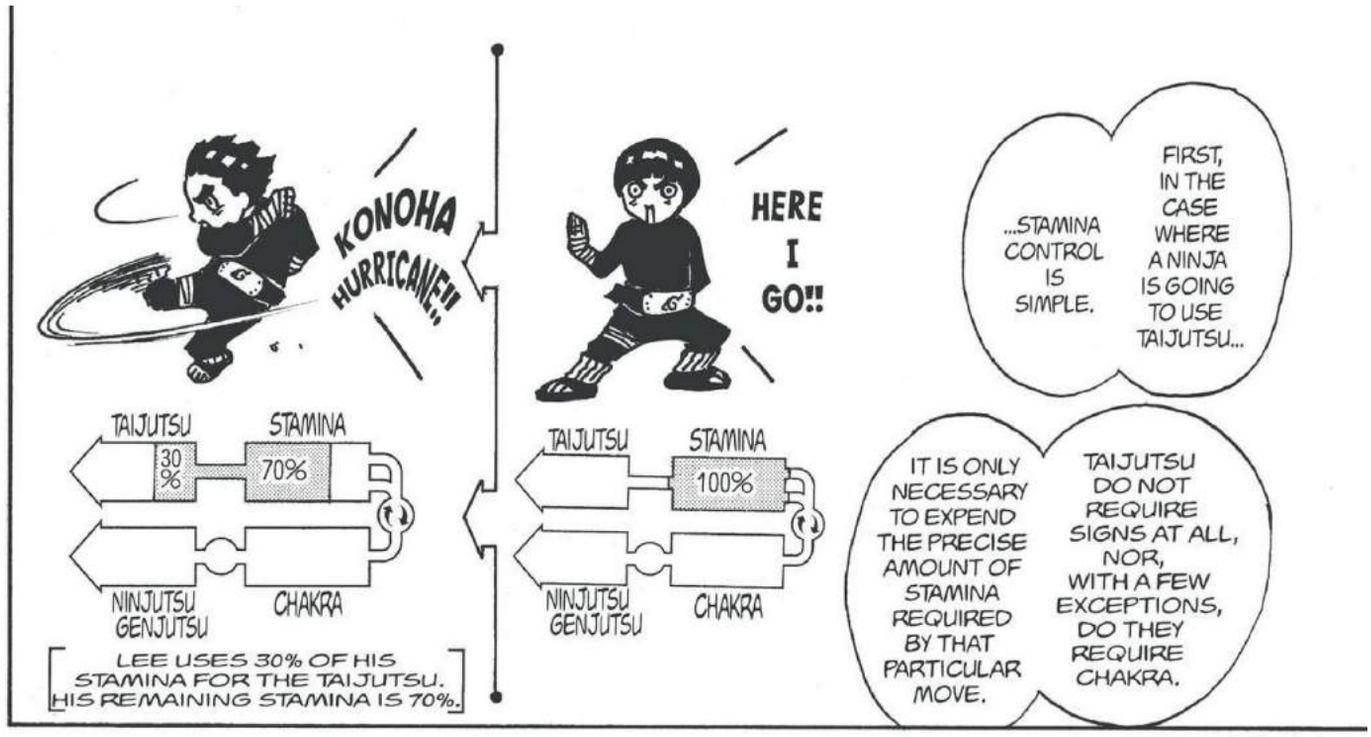
What About My Training?!

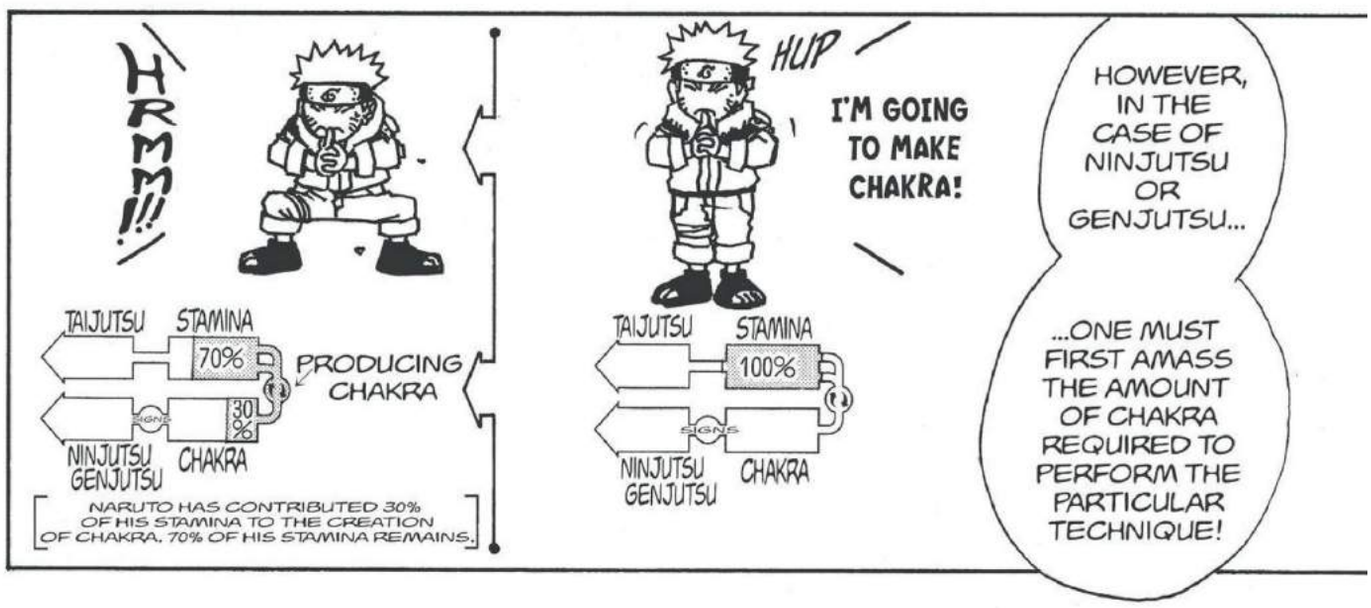
...A SUPER-PERV?
MASTER EBISU...
BESIDES, THIS GUY IS EVEN WEAKER THAN ME!
?
WHY WOULD YOU CHOOSE SUCH A LOSER TO BE MY TRAINER?!
!!
HEY!
D...DON'T SAY IT!!
COME ON! I MEAN, ONE TIME HE EVEN FELL FOR MY NINJA HAREM TECHNIQUE, AND HE...
UH...UM... IT'S NOTHING, SIR! HA HA...
NINJA HAREM ...?
...SWEAR ON IT!
I'LL TREAT YOU TO WHATEVER YOU WANT LATER, SO...
...DON'T SAY ANYTHING MORE ABOUT IT, OK?!
SMOOCH
CLAMP
MMPH!

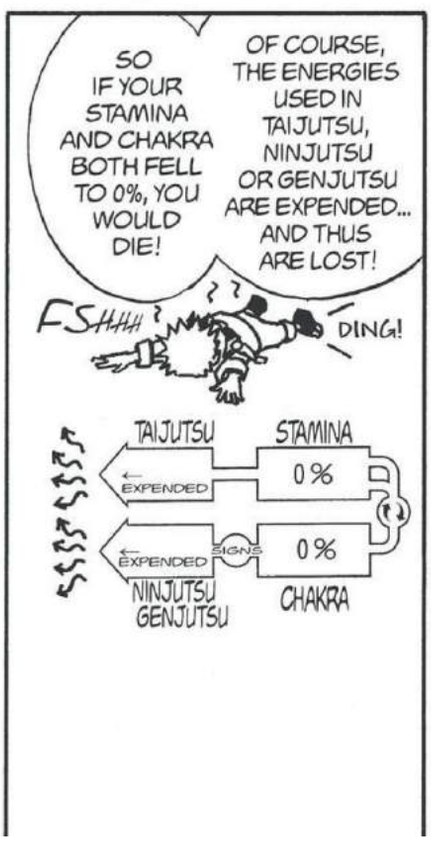
I SHALL NEVER FORGET THAT HUMILI-ATION...
PAT PAT
RIGHT?!
BUT... WHY HIM?!
THIS STINKS...
HA HA... WELL, MAYBE OPPOSITES ATTRACT, OR...
...WOW, I DIDN'T KNOW YOU TWO KNEW EACH OTHER...
AND, WELL... NARUTO, AMONG THE THREE GENIN IN CELL SEVEN...
...YOU'RE THE WEAKEST AT THE BASICS.
THIS TIME, LISTEN CLOSELY AND LEARN IT RIGHT.
GRR!!
HEY! BOTH OF YOU... PLEASE...
INDEED! IF IT WEREN'T FOR KAKASHI'S REQUEST...
...I WOULD NEVER CHOOSE TO TEACH YOU!
HE'S A BETTER TEACHER THAN ME, I PROMISE!
NARUTO! MASTER EBISU IS AN EXCLUSIVE PRIVATE TUTOR WHO TEACHES THE ELITE... HE'S A SPECIAL JÔNIN!
...HOW IN THE WORLD DO I COME UP SHORT?!
WHOA THERE! COMPARED TO SAKURA AND SASUKE...

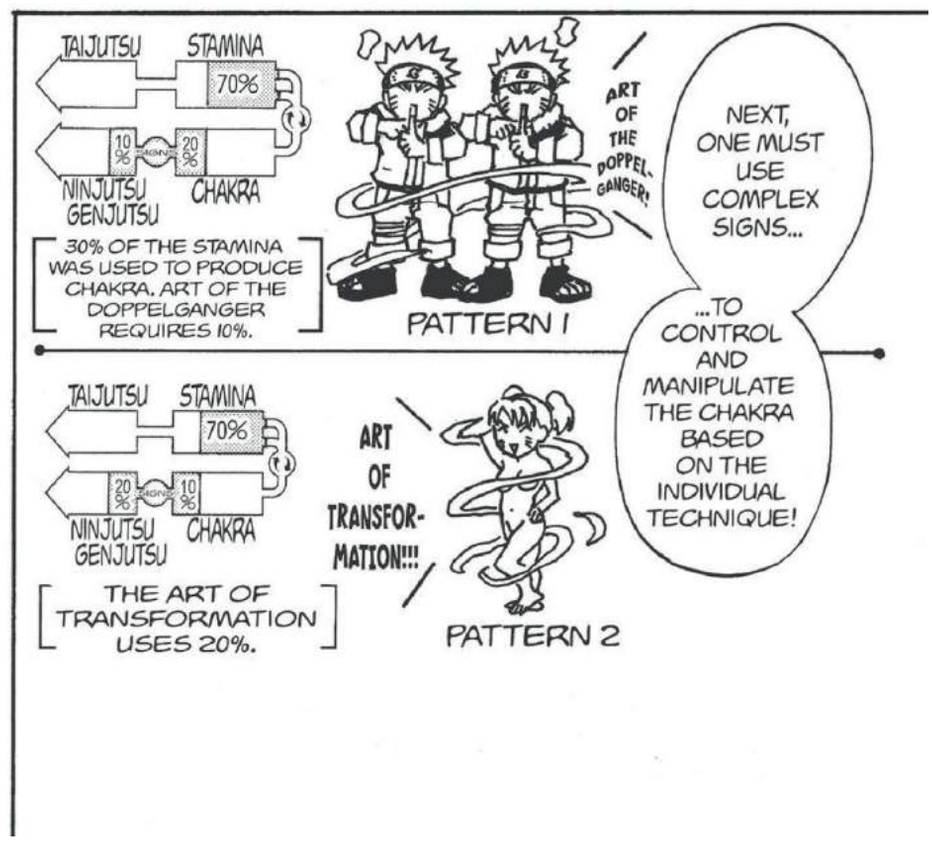
READ THIS WAY

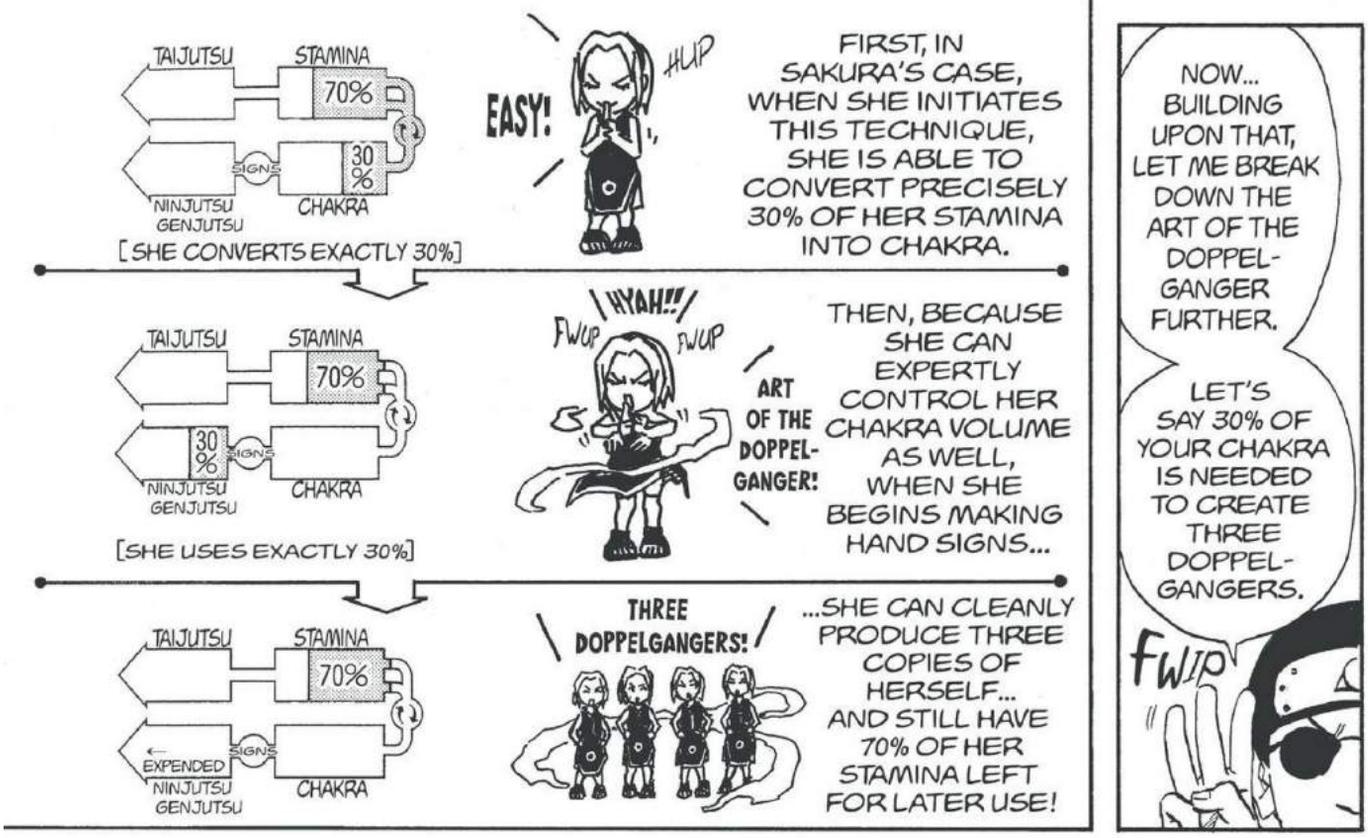



KONOHA HURRICANE!!
HERE I GO!!
TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
30 %
70%
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA
LEE USES 30% OF HIS STAMINA FOR THE TAIJUTSU. HIS REMAINING STAMINA IS 70%.
TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
100%
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA
...STAMINA CONTROL IS SIMPLE.
FIRST, IN THE CASE WHERE A NINJA IS GOING TO USE TAIJUTSU...
IT IS ONLY NECESSARY TO EXPEND THE PRECISE AMOUNT OF STAMINA REQUIRED BY THAT PARTICULAR MOVE.
TAIJUTSU DO NOT REQUIRE SIGNS AT ALL, NOR, WITH A FEW EXCEPTIONS, DO THEY REQUIRE CHAKRA.

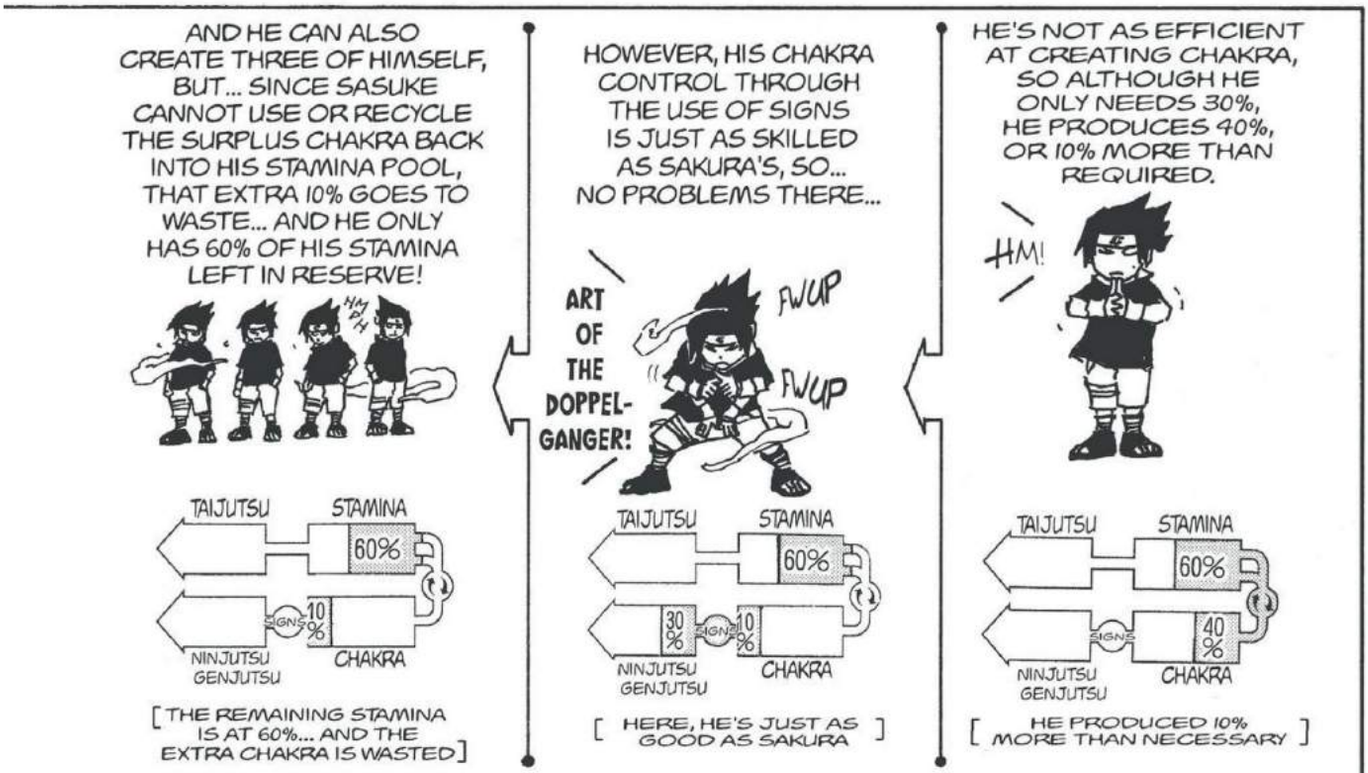

HRMM!!!
HUP
I'M GOING TO MAKE CHAKRA!
TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
70%
PRODUCING CHAKRA
SIGNS
30 %
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA
NARUTO HAS CONTRIBUTED 30% OF HIS STAMINA TO THE CREATION OF CHAKRA. 70% OF HIS STAMINA REMAINS.
TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
100%
SIGNS
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA
HOWEVER, IN THE CASE OF NINJUTSU OR GENJUTSU...
...ONE MUST FIRST AMASS THE AMOUNT OF CHAKRA REQUIRED TO PERFORM THE PARTICULAR TECHNIQUE!


SO IF YOUR STAMINA AND CHAKRA BOTH FELL TO 0%, YOU WOULD DIE!
OF COURSE, THE ENERGIES USED IN TAIJUTSU, NINJUTSU OR GENJUTSU ARE EXPENDED... AND THUS ARE LOST!
FSHHH
DING!
TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
EXPENDED
0 %
EXPENDED
SIGNS
0 %
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA

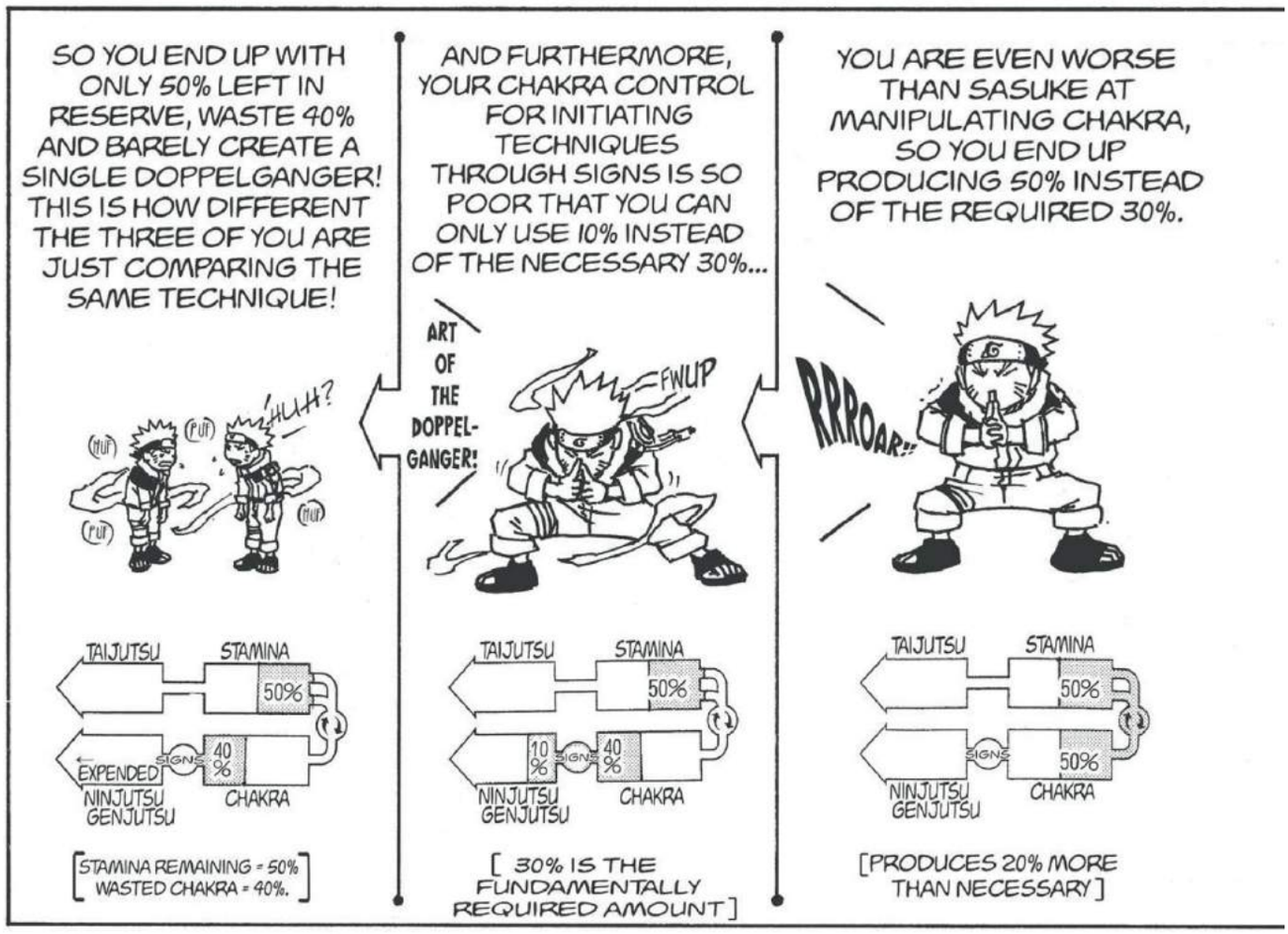

TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
70%
10 %
SIGNS
20 %
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA
30% OF THE STAMINA WAS USED TO PRODUCE CHAKRA. ART OF THE DOPPELGANGER REQUIRES 10%.
ART OF THE DOPPEL-GANGER!
PATTERN 1
NEXT, ONE MUST USE COMPLEX SIGNS...
...TO CONTROL AND MANIPULATE THE CHAKRA BASED ON THE INDIVIDUAL TECHNIQUE!
TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
70%
20 %
SIGNS
10 %
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA
THE ART OF TRANSFORMATION USES 20%.
ART OF TRANSFOR-MATION!!!
PATTERN 2


TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
70%
SIGNS
30%
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA
[SHE CONVERTS EXACTLY 30%]
EASY!
HUP
FIRST, IN SAKURA'S CASE, WHEN SHE INITIATES THIS TECHNIQUE, SHE IS ABLE TO CONVERT PRECISELY 30% OF HER STAMINA INTO CHAKRA.
TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
70%
30%
SIGNS
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA
[SHE USES EXACTLY 30%]
HYAH!!!
FWUP
FWUP
ART OF THE DOPPEL-GANGER!
THEN, BECAUSE SHE CAN EXPERTLY CONTROL HER CHAKRA VOLUME AS WELL, WHEN SHE BEGINS MAKING HAND SIGNS...
TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
70%
EXPENDED
SIGNS
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA
THREE DOPPELGANGERS!
...SHE CAN CLEANLY PRODUCE THREE COPIES OF HERSELF... AND STILL HAVE 70% OF HER STAMINA LEFT FOR LATER USE!
NOW... BUILDING UPON THAT, LET ME BREAK DOWN THE ART OF THE DOPPEL-GANGER FURTHER.
LET'S SAY 30% OF YOUR CHAKRA IS NEEDED TO CREATE THREE DOPPEL-GANGERS.
FWIP

YEP! OKAY!
HE KEEPS DRONING ON AND ON... AND I DON'T UNDERSTAND A BIT OF IT...
NEXT... IN SASUKE'S CASE...


AND HE CAN ALSO CREATE THREE OF HIMSELF, BUT... SINCE SASUKE CANNOT USE OR RECYCLE THE SURPLUS CHAKRA BACK INTO HIS STAMINA POOL, THAT EXTRA 10% GOES TO WASTE... AND HE ONLY HAS 60% OF HIS STAMINA LEFT IN RESERVE!
HM HM
TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
60%
SIGNS
10%
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA
[THE REMAINING STAMINA IS AT 60%... AND THE EXTRA CHAKRA IS WASTED]
HOWEVER, HIS CHAKRA CONTROL THROUGH THE USE OF SIGNS IS JUST AS SKILLED AS SAKURA'S, SO... NO PROBLEMS THERE...
ART OF THE DOPPEL-GANGER!
FWUP
FWUP
TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
60%
30%
SIGNS
10%
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA
[HERE, HE'S JUST AS GOOD AS SAKURA]
HE'S NOT AS EFFICIENT AT CREATING CHAKRA, SO ALTHOUGH HE ONLY NEEDS 30%, HE PRODUCES 40%, OR 10% MORE THAN REQUIRED.
HM!
TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
60%
SIGNS
40%
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA
[HE PRODUCED 10% MORE THAN NECESSARY]

WELL... YOU'RE IN NO POSITION TO BE LAUGHING AT HIM!
AHA! SO SASUKE'S NOT SO GREAT AFTER ALL! HA HA!


SO YOU END UP WITH ONLY 50% LEFT IN RESERVE, WASTE 40% AND BARELY CREATE A SINGLE DOPPELGANGER! THIS IS HOW DIFFERENT THE THREE OF YOU ARE JUST COMPARING THE SAME TECHNIQUE!
AND FURTHERMORE, YOUR CHAKRA CONTROL FOR INITIATING TECHNIQUES THROUGH SIGNS IS SO POOR THAT YOU CAN ONLY USE 10% INSTEAD OF THE NECESSARY 30%...
YOU ARE EVEN WORSE THAN SASUKE AT MANIPULATING CHAKRA, SO YOU END UP PRODUCING 50% INSTEAD OF THE REQUIRED 30%.
HUH?
(puf)
(puf)
(puf)
(puf)
ART OF THE DOPPEL-GANGER!
FWUP
RRROAR!!
TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
50%
EXPENDED
SIGNS
40 %
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA
[STAMINA REMAINING = 50% WASTED CHAKRA = 40%.]
TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
50%
10 %
SIGNS
40 %
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA
[30% IS THE FUNDAMENTALLY REQUIRED AMOUNT]
TAIJUTSU
STAMINA
50%
SIGNS
50%
NINJUTSU GENJUTSU
CHAKRA
[PRODUCES 20% MORE THAN NECESSARY]

...I WAS WAY BETTER THAN SAKURA OR SASUKE...!
BUT... BUT THERE'VE BEEN TIMES WHEN...
STAB

NARUTO, YOU PRODUCE TOO MUCH CHAKRA AND THUS EXPEND TOO MUCH ENERGY...
AND YOUR TECHNIQUE INITIATION IS ALSO UNSTABLE.
WELL, THIS SHOWS THE DIFFERENCES BETWEEN YOU THREE IN A SLIGHTLY EXAGGERATED WAY, BUT...

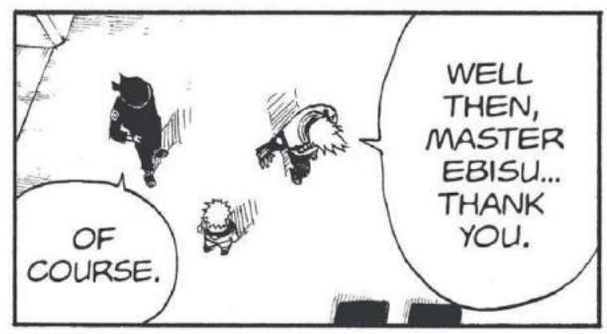
!
...YOU JUST HAPPEN TO HAVE EXTRA-ORDINARY STAMINA.
THAT'S BECAUSE OUT OF THE THREE OF YOU...

...

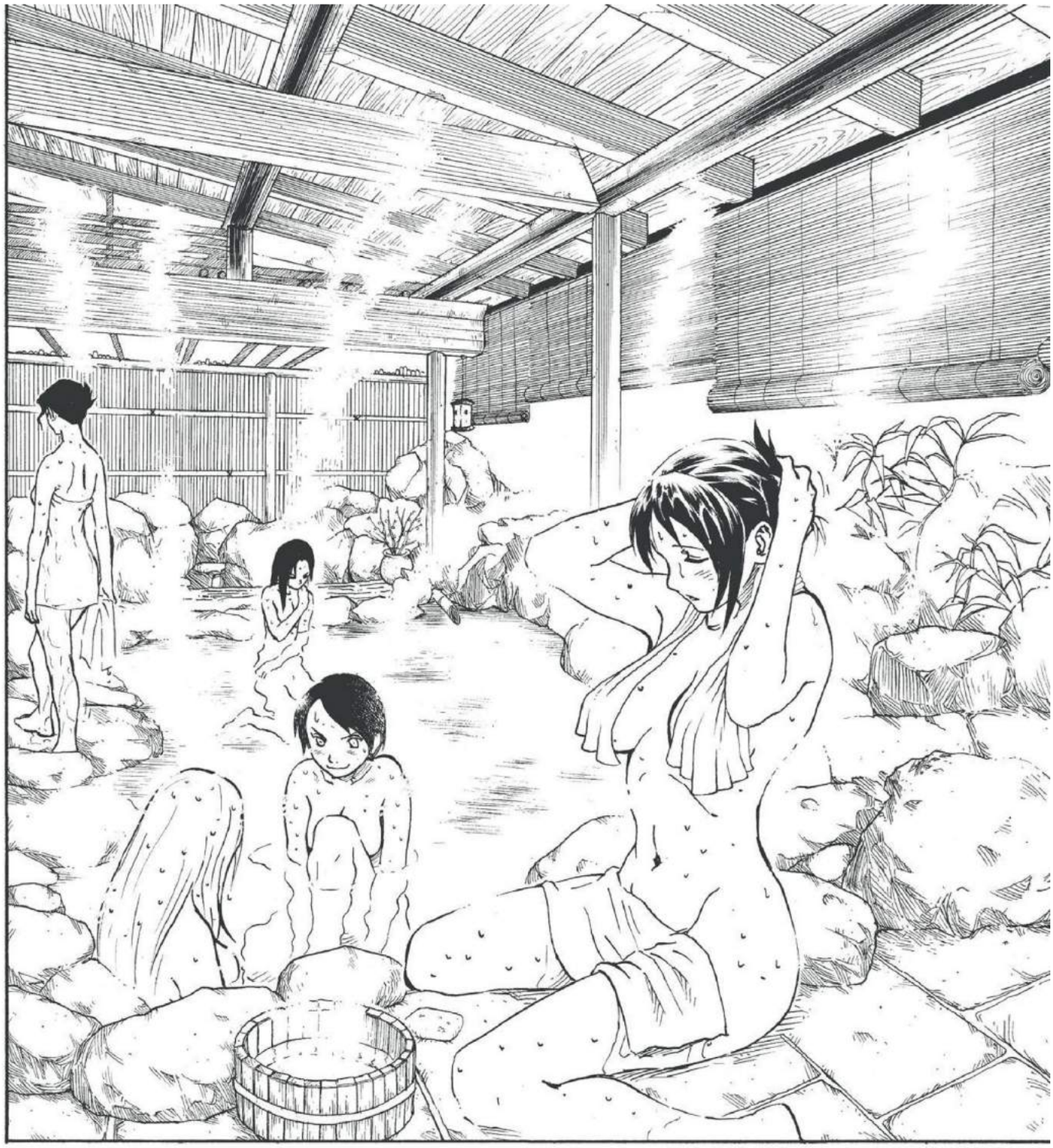
...

...BUT THAT'S ALSO THE REASON HIS CHAKRA CONTROL IS SO ERRATIC.
IT'S THE INFLUENCE OF THE NINE-TAILED FOX THAT MAKES HIS STAMINA SO AMAZING...

...YOU HAVE SO MUCH UNTAPPED POTENTIAL... GOOD LUCK...
SORRY TO ABANDON YOU, NARUTO, BUT...
NOW! LET'S GO!


OF COURSE.
WELL THEN, MASTER EBISU... THANK YOU.

ARGH!

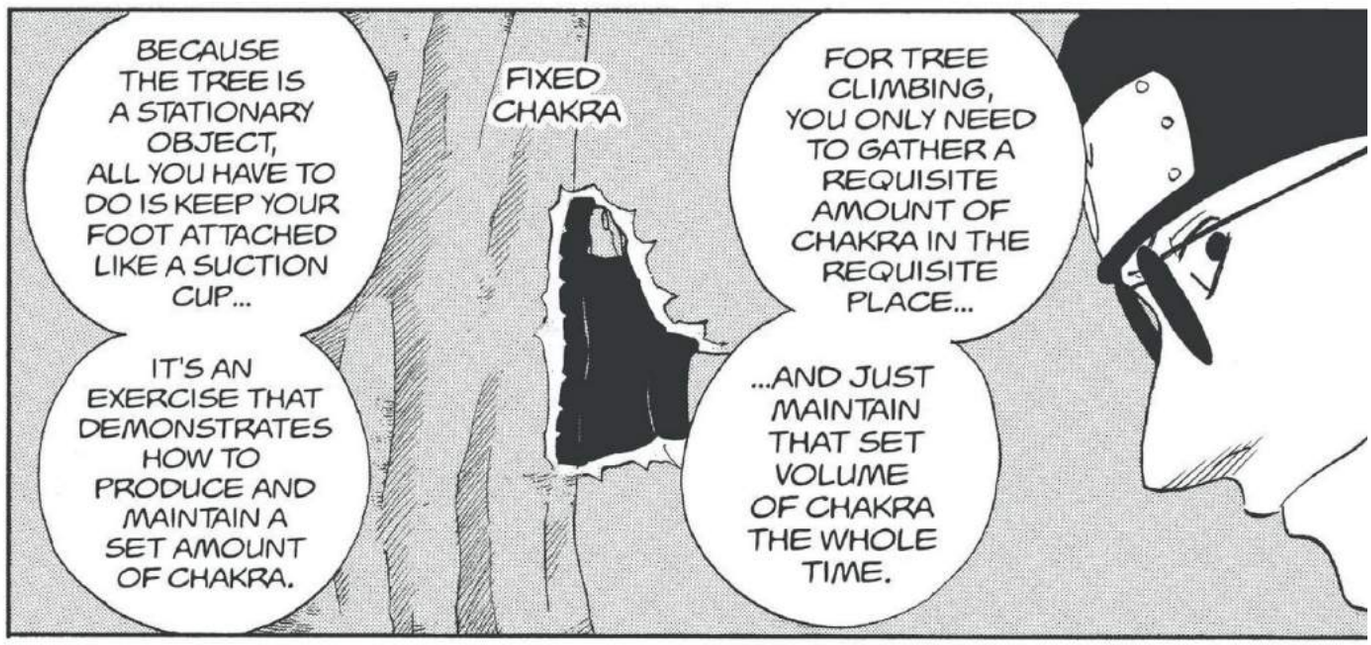


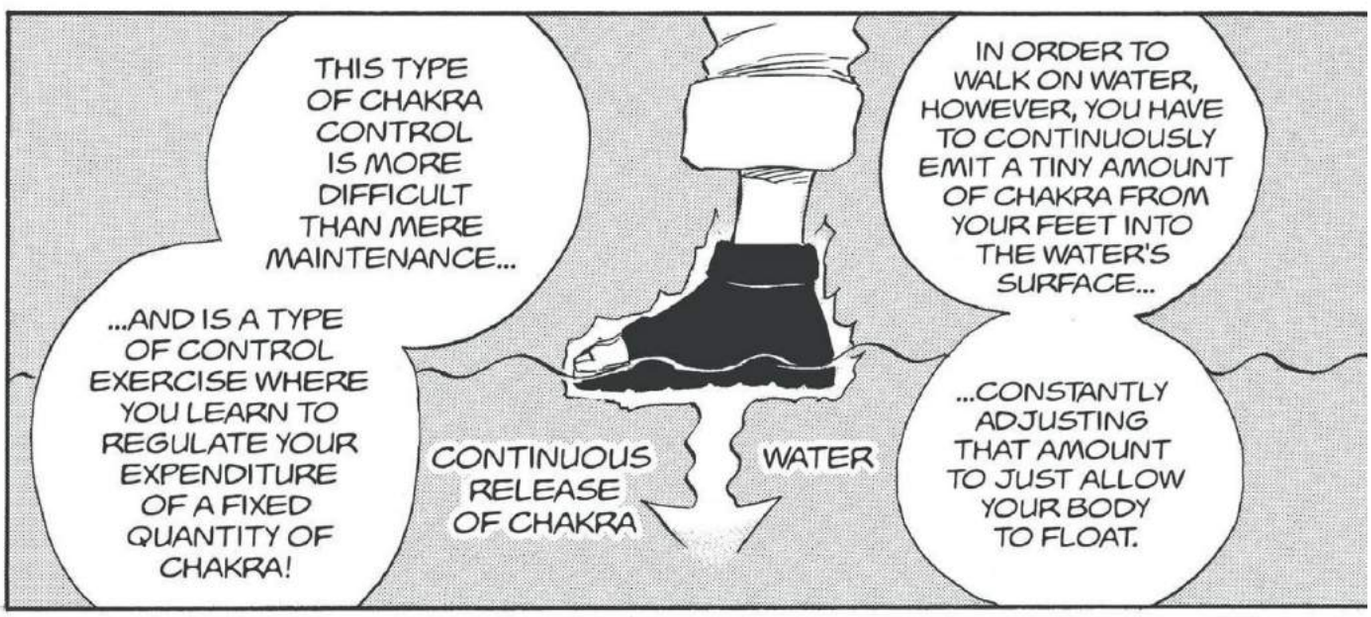
YOU'RE THE ONE WHO'S A PERVERT...!
女
H-HEY, NARUTO! THAT'S THE WOMEN'S BATH!
I WILL NOT PERMIT ANY DISREPUTABLE BEHAVIOR!!!

WHA...?!

READ THIS WAY
?
THESE HOT SPRINGS ARE WHERE WE SHALL TRAIN!!
NO!
WHY DID WE COME HERE, THEN?!
ARE WE GONNA TAKE A BATH BEFORE TRAINING?
HA HA...
?
NOW... HERE WE ARE!
WE'RE GOING TO TRAIN HERE?
WHAT THE HECK ARE WE GOING TO DO?
RUMBLE
...WALK ON WATER!
WE'RE GOING TO...

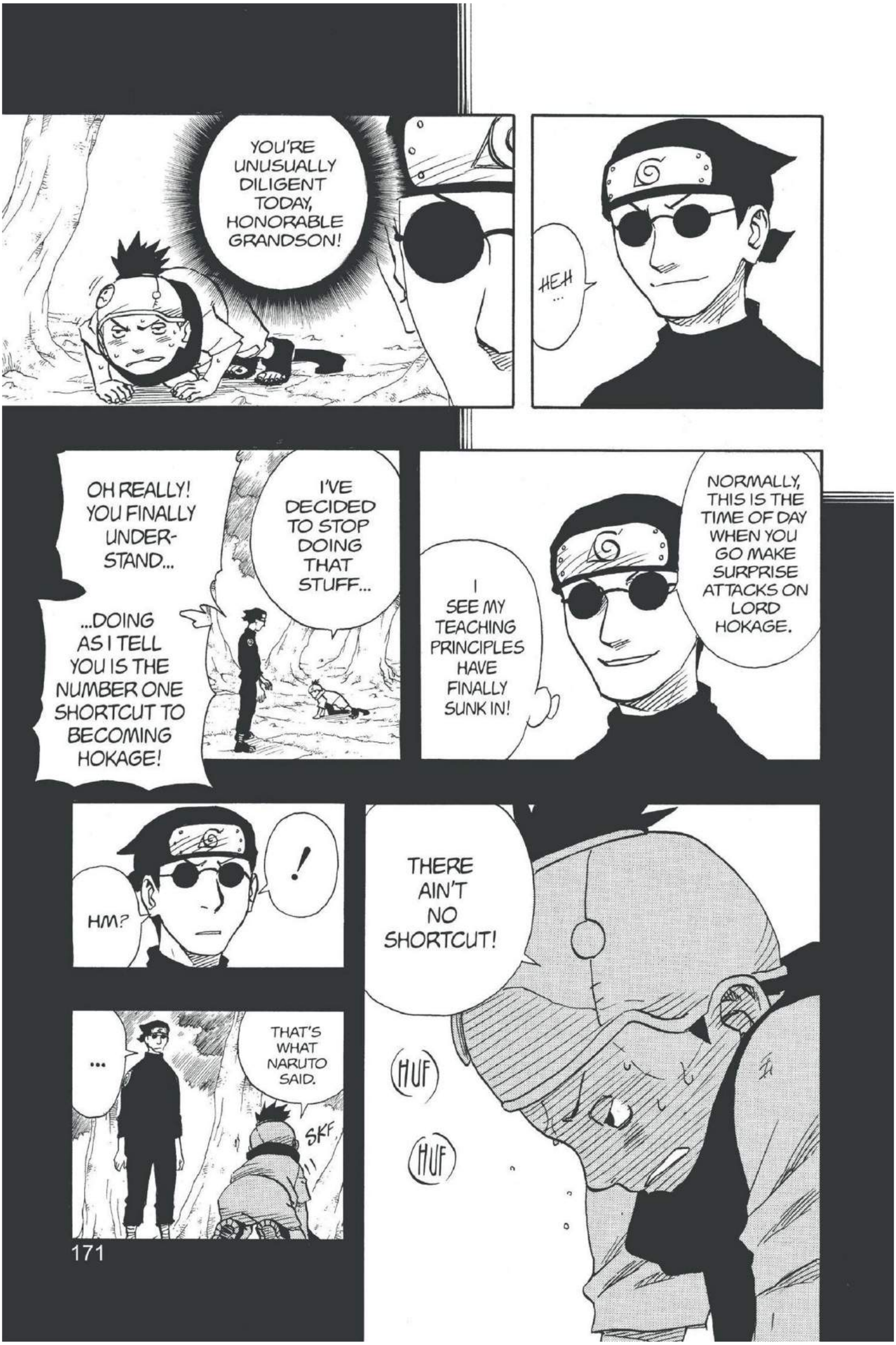
I MEAN, I DON'T REALLY REMEMBER MUCH FROM WAY BACK THEN!
WHAT...?
THIS TAKES IT TO THE NEXT LEVEL!
MASTER KAKASHI TOLD ME THAT YOU'D ALREADY MASTERED THE NO-HANDS TREE CLIMBING EXERCISE.
HUH?!

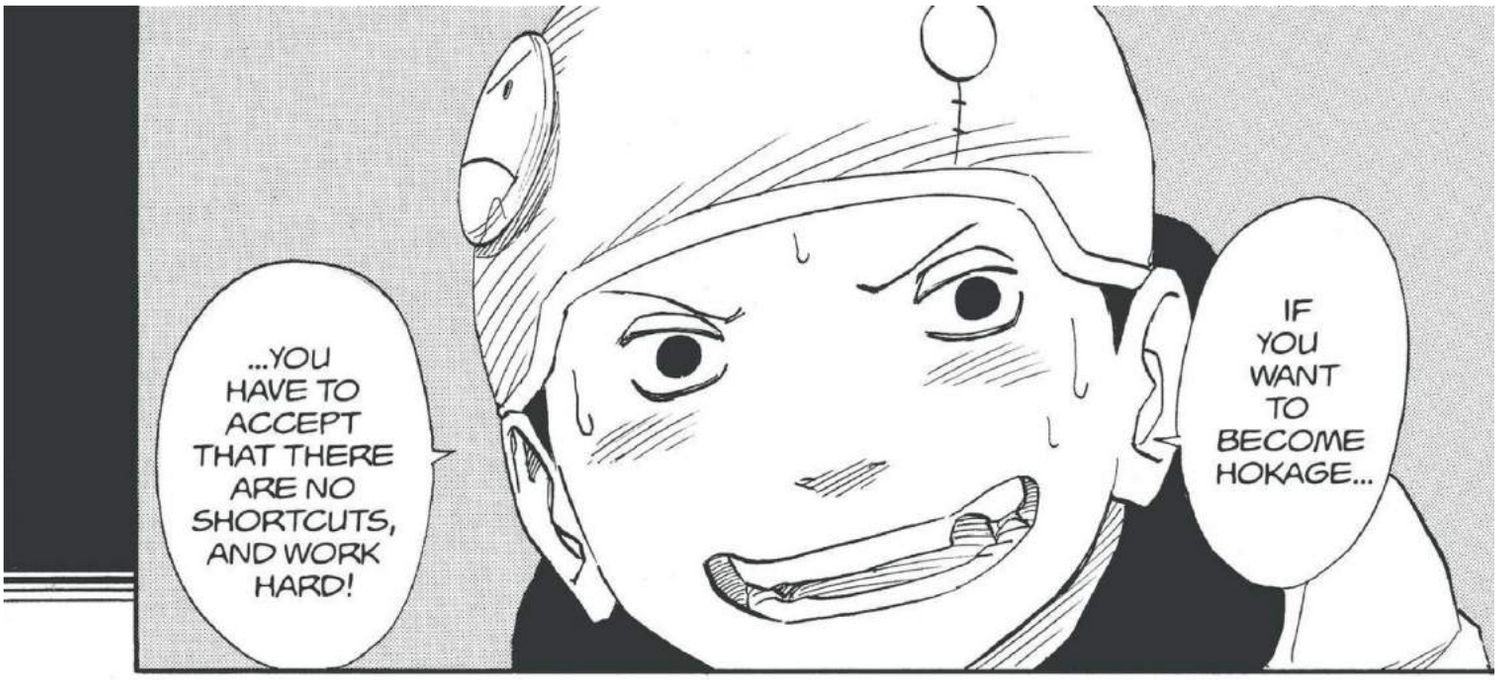

BECAUSE THE TREE IS A STATIONARY OBJECT, ALL YOU HAVE TO DO IS KEEP YOUR FOOT ATTACHED LIKE A SUCTION CUP...
IT'S AN EXERCISE THAT DEMONSTRATES HOW TO PRODUCE AND MAINTAIN A SET AMOUNT OF CHAKRA.
FIXED CHAKRA
FOR TREE CLIMBING, YOU ONLY NEED TO GATHER A REQUISITE AMOUNT OF CHAKRA IN THE REQUISITE PLACE...
...AND JUST MAINTAIN THAT SET VOLUME OF CHAKRA THE WHOLE TIME.


THIS TYPE OF CHAKRA CONTROL IS MORE DIFFICULT THAN MERE MAINTENANCE...
...AND IS A TYPE OF CONTROL EXERCISE WHERE YOU LEARN TO REGULATE YOUR EXPENDITURE OF A FIXED QUANTITY OF CHAKRA!
CONTINUOUS RELEASE OF CHAKRA
WATER
IN ORDER TO WALK ON WATER, HOWEVER, YOU HAVE TO CONTINUOUSLY EMIT A TINY AMOUNT OF CHAKRA FROM YOUR FEET INTO THE WATER'S SURFACE...
...CONSTANTLY ADJUSTING THAT AMOUNT TO JUST ALLOW YOUR BODY TO FLOAT.

...YOU FINE-TUNE IT TO YOUR BODY WEIGHT...
THEN, WHILE YOU CONTINU-OUSLY EMIT A SET AMOUNT...
SWP
SPLASH
WELL... IT'S PROBABLY EASIER TO JUST SHOW YOU...
SHF
HMM... I DON'T GET IT!
BZZ
ZZ
FIRST, YOU GATHER CHAKRA TO THE SOLES OF YOUR FEET.
WHOA!
旭日楼
男
女
SPLISH
SPLISH
AND THEN RELEASE A SET AMOUNT...!
SWP
SPLASH
FIRST, CHAKRA TO MY SOLES!
ALL RIGHT, I WANT TO TRY IT!
BZZ
ZZ

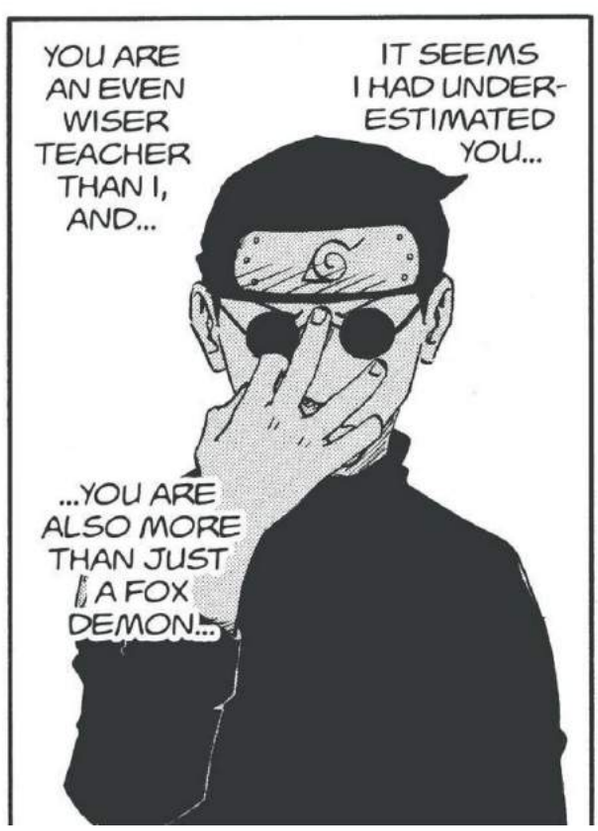
SPLOOSH
JUST AS I EXPECTED...
IF YOU KEEP SCREWING UP, YOU'LL TURN INTO A BOILED OCTOPUS!
I FORGOT TO MENTION IT, BUT THE WATER HERE IS 60 DEGREES CENTIGRADE...
GASP!
HOT! HOT!! HOT!!!
HUF
HUF
HSSS
...AW, MAN!
SPLOOSH
OW OW OWWW!
FW UP
I CAN DO THIS!!


YOU'RE UNUSUALLY DILIGENT TODAY, HONORABLE GRANDSON!
HEH...
I'VE DECIDED TO STOP DOING THAT STUFF...
OH REALLY! YOU FINALLY UNDER-STAND...
...DOING AS I TELL YOU IS THE NUMBER ONE SHORTCUT TO BECOMING HOKAGE!
NORMALLY, THIS IS THE TIME OF DAY WHEN YOU GO MAKE SURPRISE ATTACKS ON LORD HOKAGE.
I SEE MY TEACHING PRINCIPLES HAVE FINALLY SUNK IN!
HM?
!
...
THAT'S WHAT NARUTO SAID.
SKF
THERE AIN'T NO SHORTCUT!
HUF
HUF


IF YOU WANT TO BECOME HOKAGE...
...YOU HAVE TO ACCEPT THAT THERE ARE NO SHORTCUTS, AND WORK HARD!

I THINK I'M STARTING TO GET IT!
SLOSH
HEY!
SLOSH
SPLISH
SPLISH

...


YOU ARE AN EVEN WISER TEACHER THAN I, AND...
IT SEEMS I HAD UNDER-ESTIMATED YOU...
...YOU ARE ALSO MORE THAN JUST A FOX DEMON...

...I NEVER IMAGINED HE WOULD HAVE MATURED THIS MUCH.
MY GOODNESS... HE'S GOTTEN THE KNACK OF THIS CHAKRA CONTROL EXERCISE SO QUICKLY...

...THERE ARE NO SHORT-CUTS IN LIFE.
WHOA!
SLOSH
SPLISH
AND IT'S TRUE... NO MATTER THE CONTEXT...

READ THIS WAY
OH--!
SPLOOSH
WAAH!!
!
...A SPLENDID KONOHA NINJA!
SLOSH
YOU ARE TRULY...
HEH HEH HEH...
HUH?
...I WILL NOT PERMIT ANY DISREPUT-ABLE BEHAVIOR!!
TAK
I DON'T KNOW WHO YOU ARE OR WHERE YOU'RE FROM, BUT...
I SHOVE
HMPH!

POP
SHEESH...
中
AARGH!
SPLAT
SMAK
Y... YOU'RE ...!!
SNAP

TO BE CONTINUED IN NARUTO VOL. II!

VIZMANGA

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